

BAREN SUMP AND THE LAST PRESIDENT

BOOK THREE

The Black Path

THE BLACK PATH

The black path was not a tunnel beneath the house.

It was the route no machine could price because it began with a refusal: the child would not remain available.

Not as proof. Not as witness. Not as remedy. Not as future.

Only as himself.

CHAPTER FIFTY-FIVE

Some Days

Some days refused to become evidence.

This annoyed the adults at first.

Not because they wanted Baren's life to remain a case. They did not. Not consciously. Not anymore.

But adults who had spent weeks saving things, sealing things, filing things, correcting things, protecting things, and proving things developed a reflex. A dropped phrase became possible guidance. A breakfast card became a receipt. A drawing became a preservation question. A schedule became something to review, label, store, redact, and maybe later produce.

Protection had saved him.

Protection had also grown hands.

That was how the black path began: not as escape into darkness, but as refusal to be kept by every hand that called itself safe.

So when Baren woke on the third ordinary morning and announced, "Today I do not want to keep anything," the room reacted like a clerk had shouted fire in a courthouse.

Nurse Imani recovered first.

"Okay."

Morro looked at her.

"Define okay."

Nurse Imani did not blink.

"Okay means okay."

Baren sat up in bed, hair crooked, one sock half off.

“No drawer things today. No table things. No guidance unless I say. No adult sentence collecting.”

Morro slowly lowered her coffee.

“I do not collect sentences.”

Everyone looked at her.

She sighed.

“I collect only necessary sentences.”

Baren looked unconvinced.

“Today, ask first.”

Morro nodded.

“Accepted.”

Lila entered with one folder, stopped, saw his face, and placed it immediately on the chair outside the room.

Baren noticed.

“Good.”

Cole, outside the door, said, “No keeping day.”

Baren nodded.

“No keeping day.”

Nurse Imani wrote nothing.

Then saw Baren looking.

She put the pen down.

“Nothing written.”

“Good.”

Morro looked briefly pained.

Growth hurt.

Breakfast was cereal again.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

No standard.

No doctrine.

Just eating.

The absence of record made everyone weird for six minutes.

Baren noticed.

“You can still remember.”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“You do not have to keep it outside your head.”

Morro looked up.

“That is a dangerous distinction.”

Baren pointed his spoon at her.

“Ask first.”

Morro closed her mouth.

The spoon lowered.

Cereal continued.

From the hallway, Cole said, “Good catch.”

Morro pointed at him.

“Not helping.”

Cole took a sip of bad coffee.

“Still true.”

After breakfast, Nurse Imani cleared the bowl.

No one photographed it.

No one described it.

No one preserved the spoon.

Civilization held.

The national task force did not honor No Keeping Day because it did not know No Keeping Day existed and, more importantly, because adult systems still required documentation to stop other adult systems from pretending ignorance.

At 9:00 a.m., the former Old Court clerk produced the London packet.

Morro took the call in the consult room, door closed, away from Baren’s hallway.

The packet showed that the private governance method had crossed borders through philanthropic education networks, family offices, faith-based reconciliation institutes, and crisis-management firms that sold discretion like bottled water.

No one used the same name twice.

That was part of the design.

Old Court was not a brand.

It was a habit.

Private review.

Continuity counsel.

Family healing advisory.

Legacy ethics circle.

Restoration table.

Next-generation trust forum.

Youth-sensitive resolution panel.

Names changed.

Mechanisms repeated.

Morro listened while Simon presented.

Then said, "Do not chase names first. Chase mechanisms."

The assistant deputy undersecretary, who had improved slightly, asked,
"For the public bulletin?"

"For the investigation."

Dr. Rao nodded.

"Mechanisms reproduce. Names hide."

Morro pointed at the screen.

"That. Use that."

The bulletin drafted itself from there:

Investigators were reviewing recurring mechanisms: private meetings around minors, conflicted repair processes, deferred contact instruments, worker vulnerability, and privacy language used as strategy.

"Good. Ugly. Useful."

The bulletin did not mention Baren.

It did not mention the unit.

It did not mention No Keeping Day.

At 9:30, Baren read about octopuses.

Ms. Rowe had chosen ocean reading because sharks had become too interesting and therefore suspect.

The octopus page caused immediate problems.

Baren stared at the illustration.

"Too many arms."

Ms. Rowe said, "Eight."

"I know. Too many."

"They are very intelligent."

"Adults will ruin that."

"Probably."

"They can change color?"

"Yes."

"Like cuttlefish."

"Yes."

"Lying or surviving?"

"Maybe both."

Cole, outside the door, said, "Pattern."

Baren looked at him.

“No categories.”

Cole lifted one hand.

“No categories.”

Ms. Rowe read that octopuses could squeeze through tiny spaces, use tools, open jars, and sometimes escape tanks.

Baren listened.

Then closed the book.

“No octopus guidance.”

Ms. Rowe smiled.

“No octopus guidance.”

“Octopus can just be octopus.”

“Yes.”

He reopened the book.

Read one paragraph.

Stumbled on **camouflage**.

Corrected it.

No one wrote it down.

He looked at Ms. Rowe.

“You want to write correction.”

“I do.”

“Why?”

“So I can track reading progress.”

“That is okay. Progress records allowed?”

Lila, sitting nearby, asked, “Do you want progress records for school only?”

Baren thought.

“Yes. School progress, not life progress.”

Morro, from the consult-room doorway, looked like she had been physically struck by useful precision.

She asked, “May I write that?”

Baren considered.

“Yes. That is guidance.”

Morro wrote:

SCHOOL PROGRESS, NOT LIFE PROGRESS.

Lila added the adult version:

Educational documentation should track learning needs and supports without converting emotional recovery, disclosure, public engagement, or personal meaning into performance metrics.

Baren read it.

“Lawyer cereal.”

“Dry but useful?” Lila asked.

“Dry but safe.”

That was new.

Morro liked it.

Too much.

She did not say so.

At 10:45, the public guidance desk received seventeen questions from institutions about how to measure whether children felt safe.

Morro looked at them.

“No.”

Lila said, “Some measurement is needed.”

“Some.”

Dr. Rao joined by video.

“Safety can be assessed clinically and procedurally. But institutions love turning safety into survey optics.”

Morro said, “Public.”

The advisory became careful and shorter:

The advisory was shorter now: ask safely, privately, and never turn a child’s comfort, gratitude, silence, or forgiveness into an institutional grade.

Baren was not shown the full advisory.

He asked why adults looked “survey mad.”

Lila explained.

“Some institutions want to know how to measure if kids feel safe.”

Baren frowned.

“They can ask, but not make it a grade.”

Lila nodded.

“Exactly.”

He looked at Morro.

“You can use that.”

Morro wrote:

ASK, BUT DO NOT MAKE IT A GRADE.

Then paused.

“Public?”

“Yes.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Ask, but do not make it a grade.

“Plain enough to survive.”

At noon, lunch was soup.

Baren did not like soup.

He chose it anyway because not every meal had to prove preference.

Then he realized that sentence itself sounded like guidance and told everyone not to write it down.

Morro suffered visibly.

Nurse Imani looked directly at her.

“Judge.”

Morro placed both hands flat on the table.

“I am not writing.”

Baren ate four spoonfuls.

Soup was still shiny.

He said nothing.

The spoon went into the tray.

The tray left.

No record.

No table item.

No drawer item.

No symbol.

Just soup.

Harder than it looked.

At 1:00, Mara arrived for puzzle visit.

She came with no ocean facts.

Baren noticed.

“No facts?”

“No facts.”

“Forgot?”

“No. No Keeping Day.”

He looked pleased.

“You remembered without keeping.”

“I did.”

“Good.”

They worked the cow puzzle.

No work talk.

No facts.

No metaphors.

No otters.

No kelp.

No sharks.

Just cows.

After five minutes, Mara said, "I almost brought a fact."

"I know."

"You do?"

"You have fact face."

"I have fact face?"

"Yes."

"What does it look like?"

"Like you want to be useful."

Mara set down a sky piece.

"That is probably true."

"You can be not useful."

Mara smiled faintly.

"I am trying."

"Trying Adult."

"Yes."

"Not useful trying. Just trying trying."

"That is harder."

"I know."

They placed puzzle pieces in silence.

Baren completed part of a fence.

Mara found a cloud edge.

No one recorded the moment.

It survived anyway.

When Mara left, Baren said, "Next time you can bring one fact."

"Only one?"

"Yes."

"Receipts?"

"No. Trust fact."

Mara blinked.

"Trust fact?"

"One fact I do not check."

Mara understood the size of that and did not make it big.

“Okay.”

Baren pointed.

“If it is wrong, no more trust facts for a while.”

“Fair.”

Morro, who had absolutely been listening from the lounge, whispered to Lila, “This is a major evidentiary development.”

Lila whispered back, “Do not.”

Morro did not.

Barely.

At 2:30, the first indictment connected to Old Court itself was returned under seal.

Not public yet.

Adult names.

Conspiracy counts.

Obstruction.

Witness tampering.

False statements.

Document destruction.

Financial violations.

Potential child endangerment charges referred to state authorities.

Dahlia named.

Two trust attorneys.

One Mercy Continuity officer.

One Elysium-linked data strategist.

One private physician.

One family-office administrator.

Not Thomas.

Dead men were bad defendants.

Not Baren.

Never Baren.

Not children.

Adults.

Morro read the sealed notice in the consult room.

Lila beside her.

Simon on screen.

Federal counsel tired and precise.

No celebration.

Morro said, "Good. Keep building."

Federal counsel said, "We anticipate unsealing within forty-eight hours after arrests."

"Adult names only?"

"Yes."

"Child protections?"

"Incorporated."

"Worker protections?"

"Yes."

"Former minors?"

"By choice."

"Good."

Morro ended the call.

Then stood in the consult room alone for one full minute.

Lila did not interrupt.

Finally, Morro said, "We are not telling him unless necessary."

Lila nodded.

"No Keeping Day."

"No Keeping Day," Morro said.

The indictment stayed outside Baren's room.

At 3:00, courtyard.

The sad maple had dropped more leaves.

Baren stood under it and looked at the ground.

"Tree is losing."

Cole said, "Season."

"Still losing."

"Maybe."

Baren picked up one leaf.

Looked at it.

Lila watched, careful.

He held it out.

"Trash?"

Lila asked, "Do you want to keep it?"

"No. Already have leaf."

"Then trash."

He put it in the trash.

No ceremony.

The sad maple did not object.

Cole said, "Leaf retired."

Baren looked at him.

"Not everything needs a job after."

Cole nodded slowly.

"True."

Baren pointed at him.

"Private."

"Private."

They sat outside for ten minutes.

No insights collected.

No guidance.

No record.

Except the ones they kept by being alive in the same place.

That was allowed.

At 4:00, Serena's visit was canceled.

By Baren.

Not because he was angry.

Because he did not want a visit.

Lila confirmed twice.

Once was not enough because adults needed to distinguish choice from fear.

Twice was enough because adults also needed to stop turning choice into interrogation.

"You can cancel," Lila said.

"I know."

"Do you want to give a reason?"

"No."

"Okay."

Serena received the message through counsel:

Baren does not want a visit today. No reason provided. No response requested.

Serena replied:

Understood. No response needed.

Morro read it.

"Good."

Baren asked later, "Did she answer too much?"

“No,” Lila said. “She answered correctly.”

“Good.”

Then he asked, “Can no reason be enough?”

“Yes.”

Morro, from the lounge, whispered, “Public someday.”

Baren heard.

“Ask first.”

Morro froze.

“May that become guidance?”

He thought.

“Yes.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

The update said a protected child’s refusal did not need a reason before adults respected it.

Baren reviewed it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Too many words.”

Morro said, “Legal systems are word hungry.”

“Feed them less.”

Morro nodded.

“Working on it.”

At 5:30, Chronald requested nothing.

Serena requested nothing.

Crowe sent no advisory.

Mara sent no draft.

Simon sent no map to the unit.

Dahlia’s counsel filed something outrageous, but Morro read it in the consult room and did not bring it into the lounge.

Baren ate grilled cheese.

Straight cut this time.

Two rectangles.

No one mentioned jurisdiction.

Cole looked like he wanted to.

Baren looked at him.

Cole drank water.

Good.

After dinner, Baren asked, "Did big adult stuff happen today?"

Lila answered, "Yes."

"Do I need to know?"

"No."

"Does it affect my room?"

"No."

"Then not today."

"Okay."

He looked at Morro.

"You did not tell me."

"No."

"Good."

Morro inclined her head.

Finding accepted.

Night came plain.

No rain.

No emergency.

No adult names in the hallway.

No toast holiday.

No drawer review.

No table review.

The ocean fact card stayed.

The shark drawing stayed.

The breakfast card stayed.

The ordinary pencil stayed.

The drawer stayed closed.

Baren did not open it.

This made Lila look at him.

He saw.

"What?"

"No drawer check?"

"No."

"Okay."

"It is still there."

"Yes."

"I do not have to check every time."

“No.”

He climbed into bed.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at the desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in the lounge, doing paperwork quietly enough to count as growth.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can some days just be days?”

Lila answered, “Yes.”

“Even if bad things happen elsewhere?”

“Yes.”

“Even if adults keep papers?”

“Yes.”

“Even if tomorrow needs review?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Then:

“No Keeping Day can end.”

“Okay.”

“Do not keep it.”

Lila smiled.

“I won’t.”

Morro, in the lounge, heard and closed her notebook.

For once, she wrote nothing.

The light dimmed.

The hallway quieted.

The big machine kept turning elsewhere, now pursued by adults with warrants, bulletins, protocols, and enough receipts to make denial expensive.

But Baren slept without opening the drawer.

And because no one wrote down the moment, it belonged completely to him.

CHAPTER FIFTY-SIX

The Day That Was Not Kept

The day that was not kept did not disappear.

This surprised the adults.

They had confused preservation with existence because, for weeks, existence had required protection from deletion, distortion, extraction, branding, and theft. Records had been rescue ropes. Filings had been walls. Receipts had been proof that someone's no had not evaporated in a room full of important people.

But Baren slept through the night without checking the drawer, and in the morning the drawer remained there anyway.

Closed.

Ordinary.

Not offended.

At 7:11 a.m., Baren opened his eyes and looked at it.

The drawer did nothing.

Nurse Imani knocked.

"Come in."

She entered with the new schedule.

He took it.

Breakfast.

Reading.

Math.

Courtyard.

Puzzle.

Visit optional.

Adult briefing only if requested.

Review tomorrow.

He read it, then looked at her.

"Today can keep some things."

"Okay."

"But not everything."

"Okay."

"Adults need practice."

Nurse Imani nodded.

"They do."

From the hallway, Cole said, "True yes."

Morro, somewhere in the lounge, said, "I heard that."

Cole said, "Still true."

Baren smiled.

"What is breakfast?"

"Toast, cereal, eggs, or oatmeal."

“Oatmeal sounds like a policy title.”

Morro appeared in the doorway with coffee.

“It often is.”

“Toast.”

“Edges?”

“No.”

“Butter?”

“Present, not shiny.”

Nurse Imani wrote it on the card automatically.

Then froze.

Baren saw.

He looked at the card.

Then at her.

“That one can keep.”

She smiled.

“Okay.”

Morro said nothing.

Heroic restraint was becoming less heroic and more habit.

That was how it worked.

At 8:30 a.m., the first arrests from the sealed indictment began.

Not in Baren’s hallway.

Not in his room.

Not near the breakfast card.

Elsewhere.

Adult places.

A trust attorney in Boston opened his townhouse door wearing exercise clothes and the expression of someone who believed federal agents should have called ahead.

A Mercy Continuity officer was arrested outside a parking garage with two phones and a paper coffee cup that later spilled onto the sidewalk in a way no one interpreted.

An Elysium-linked data strategist was arrested at a coworking space where the inspirational wall read **BUILD WHAT MATTERS**.

Morro saw the photograph and said, “Finally, accuracy.”

The private physician surrendered through counsel.

The family-office administrator tried to delete files during the arrest and failed because the cloud had better memory than loyalty.

Dahlia remained in custody.

Two names were still sealed pending coordinated action.

The task force issued a controlled statement:

Federal authorities have begun arrests connected to alleged obstruction, witness interference, document destruction, false statements, and unlawful private governance activities involving protected persons and institutional records. No protected minor is alleged to have participated in wrongdoing. Child identities remain protected.

“Good.”

Mara’s newsroom carried the story with no child image.

No file photo of Sump House.

No Baren silhouette.

No symbolic empty chair.

Morro had specifically banned empty chairs after the Bellwether chapter of reality.

Headline:

Arrests Begin in Old Court Records Investigation

Dry.

Accurate.

Adult.

Mara wrote only a sidebar explaining the controlled-disclosure framework. The main story belonged to the independent team now.

Progress could feel like exclusion if the ego was hungry.

Mara fed it ocean facts instead.

Baren was told at 9:00 because the arrests were major and he had asked to know when adults were caught.

Lila sat with him after reading.

“Some adults connected to the bad rooms were arrested this morning.”

He looked up.

“Dahlia again?”

“She is already in custody. Other adults.”

“What kinds?”

Lila used his category sheet.

“Paper Adults. Plan Adults. Money Adults. A medical adult. A data adult.”

He frowned.

“Data Adult?”

Morro entered with coffee.

“Adults who use numbers to make harm look like analysis.”

Baren nodded.

“Bad math.”

“Yes.”

“Did they use kids?”

“The allegations involve protected persons and records. The court is keeping child identities protected.”

“Good.”

“Do you want names?”

“No.”

“Do you want to know if they get lawyers?”

“Yes.”

“They do.”

“Do adults have to prove adult?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Then:

“Can I still do ocean reading?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

The arrests left the room.

The ocean book entered.

That was the order.

Ocean reading concerned coral reefs.

Baren liked reefs immediately and distrusted that liking.

“They look like cities.”

Ms. Rowe said, “They are ecosystems.”

“Adults will definitely ruin that.”

“Yes,” she said, giving up the obvious.

Coral was alive.

Tiny animals building structures.

Symbiosis.

Bleaching.

Warm water stress.

Baren did not like bleaching.

“Too much heat makes them lose what helps them live?”

“Yes.”

He stared at the page.

No one spoke.

Then he said, “No guidance.”

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“No guidance.”

He read the paragraph again.

Corrected **symbiosis** on the second try.

Ms. Rowe tracked reading progress.

School progress.

Not life progress.

Baren allowed that.

He drew coral after the lesson.

Not well.

It looked like a nervous tree underwater.

He considered the side table.

Then shook his head.

“Trash.”

Nurse Imani asked, “Are you sure?”

“Yes. Drawing was practice.”

The coral went into recycling.

No ceremony.

The side table did not grow.

Good.

At 10:30, the public began doing what the public did whenever adult arrests created empty attention space.

It looked for children.

The first wave asked whether the protected minor had reacted.

The second asked whether former minors felt vindicated.

The third asked whether Baren would one day testify.

The fourth asked whether the arrests proved his destiny.

The fifth asked why no one had seen him.

Morro read the trend report and placed both hands on the table.

“Correction.”

Mara’s newsroom, the public guidance desk, and the task force issued coordinated language:

Protected minors do not owe reactions to adult arrests. Former minors may speak or not speak through chosen channels. No one should speculate about protected testimony, emotional response, future participation, appearance, location, or identity. Adult arrests should be analyzed through adult charges, adult records, and lawful process.

Morro added:

Curiosity is not standing.

Lila looked at her.

“Public?”

“Adult concept.”

Mara used it in body:

Curiosity is not standing: public interest in a case does not create a right to a protected child’s reaction.

The phrase traveled through legal circles and annoyed everyone who deserved it.

Baren saw the safe version.

“People want reaction?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

He thought.

“My reaction is ocean reading.”

Morro looked at him.

He looked back.

“Not public.”

“Understood.”

He returned to the reef page.

The public did not receive the reaction.

The reef did.

At noon, one of the newly arrested adults released a statement through counsel.

The trust attorney.

Name: Graham Pell.

Adult.

Records.

No child.

His statement said:

Mr. Pell’s work consisted of lawful estate planning and confidential family dispute resolution. He denies participating in any unlawful private governance system and looks forward to clearing his name.

Morro read it and shrugged.

“Acceptable.”

Mara looked surprised.

“That does not bother you?”

“He is denying charges through counsel without using children. That is allowed.”

Crowe, on video, said, “Due process remains irritatingly consistent.”

“Yes,” Morro said.

Baren heard later that one adult denied wrongdoing.

“Can he?”

“Yes.”

“Even if he did it?”

“Yes.”

“Adults prove adult.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He thought.

“If he lies, paper remembers?”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

Baren liked that.

“Paper remembers is Rosa.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

At 1:00 p.m., Rosa returned to the Bellwether Club.

Not secretly.

Not publicly.

Correctly.

Her counsel notified the court. The club had been ordered not to retaliate. A labor monitor was present. Her cleaning cart was where she left it, though someone had removed the good mop head and replaced it with an inferior one.

Rosa noticed immediately.

The inferior mop head became a compliance issue within twelve minutes.

Morro received the message and stared at it.

“The mop?”

Lila read the report.

“Yes.”

“Was the mop head removed in retaliation?”

“Unclear.”

“Then preserve mop records.”

Crowe whispered, “Mop records.”

Morro turned.

“Do you think labor retaliation announces itself with trumpets?”

“No.”

“It often begins with schedules, supplies, keys, storage access, break timing, and supervisors saying tone.”

Lila was already adding the mop issue to the labor monitor file.

Baren heard about the mop only because Rosa permitted a safe update.

“Rosa went back to work. Her cart was there. There is a problem with the mop, and adults are handling it.”

Baren sat up straighter.

“Bad mop?”

“Yes.”

“Did they take her good mop?”

“Maybe.”

“That is punishment.”

“Maybe.”

“Mop matters.”

Morro entered.

“We are aware.”

Baren narrowed his eyes.

“Do better.”

Morro pointed.

“We are doing better faster.”

“Good.”

The guidance desk later issued a labor witness note:

The labor note said retaliation could hide in schedules, supplies, assignments, equipment, breaks, and tone - not only in formal job status.

Baren reviewed the safe summary.

“Work gets paid and gets tools.”

Morro added it.

Plain language addendum:

Work gets paid and gets tools.

Rosa, informed through counsel, replied:

Now he really understands labor.

At 2:30, math returned with decimals.

Baren viewed decimals as fractions wearing office clothes.

Ms. Rowe admitted this was not entirely wrong.

He converted 0.5 to one-half.

0.25 to one-fourth.

0.75 to three-fourths.

Suspicious but eventually correct.

He asked, "Why do numbers need disguises?"

Ms. Rowe said, "Different forms help in different situations."

"Adults too?"

Lila looked up.

Morro, in the doorway, became very still.

Baren saw and sighed.

"No guidance."

"Good," Morro said.

He finished the worksheet.

Three errors.

Corrected two.

Left one.

Ms. Rowe said, "Want to review the last one?"

"No. Tomorrow."

"Okay."

Baren looked surprised.

"You can say okay?"

"Yes."

"Even if wrong?"

"Yes."

"Good."

School progress note:

Decimals introduced. Two corrections completed. One left for tomorrow by choice.

Baren approved.

"Learning can wait without being future claim."

Morro's hand twitched.

Baren pointed at her without looking.

"Ask first."

"May that be guidance?"

He thought.

"For school."

Educational advisory gained:

Unfinished learning can wait without becoming pressure or prophecy.

Morro looked at it.

"Soft."

Ms. Rowe said, "School needs some soft."

Morro accepted reluctantly.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena's optional visit became yes.

Baren chose five minutes before the appointment, which caused a scheduling scramble so small and human that everyone respected it.

Serena arrived with nothing.

Good.

Baren asked about mops.

Serena did not know why but answered seriously.

"I prefer sponge mops for kitchens and string mops for bigger floors."

Baren looked at Lila.

"Is that true?"

Lila said, "I am not mop counsel."

Cole, from outside, said, "String mops hold more."

Baren nodded.

"Cole knows."

Serena smiled.

"Then I defer to Cole."

The visit lasted eight minutes.

They discussed floors, mops, and whether dinosaur boots would track mud.

Baren said yes.

Serena said worth it.

Timer buzzed.

Baren said, "Done."

Serena stood.

"Okay."

No sadness offered.

No sadness requested.

At 5:30, the task force confirmed the two remaining sealed defendants had been located.

One arrest pending.

One negotiating surrender.

National news wanted names.

Morro wanted dinner.

Both continued.

The public bulletin said:

Additional arrests or surrenders are expected. Names will be released after child-risk review and execution of protective measures.

The public disliked waiting.

Too bad.

Waiting without teeth could be protective when adults controlled the teeth.

Baren ate grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

No geometry discourse.

Cole looked like he was suffering.

Baren noticed.

“You can say one thing.”

Cole looked relieved.

“Rectangles stable.”

Baren nodded.

“Accepted.”

Morro did not object.

Some doctrines matured privately.

Evening settled into puzzle.

Mara did not visit.

She sent one trust fact through Lila because Baren had allowed one unchecked fact next time, and Lila asked if written counted.

Baren said yes.

The fact:

Parrotfish make sand by eating coral and grinding it down.

Baren stared at the card.

“That sounds fake.”

Lila said nothing.

“Trust fact means I do not check.”

“Yes.”

He placed it on the side table.

Then picked it up.

Then placed it under the shark drawing.

“Suspicious facts go under shark.”

“Okay.”

Morro saw later and did not ask.

Barely.

Before bed, Baren opened the drawer.

First time since No Keeping Day.

Everything remained.

Dinosaur boots photo.

Leaf envelope.

Private notes.

Category sheet.

Learning plan.

Permanent framework summary.

Blank envelope.

No new court papers.

No adult arrest updates.

No mop filing.

Good.

He added nothing.

Closed it.

Opened it.

Still there.

Closed it.

He looked at the side table.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Breakfast card.

Ordinary pencil.

Suspicious parrotfish fact under shark.

“Table is okay.”

Lila nodded.

“Yes.”

“Drawer is okay.”

“Yes.”

“Trash is okay.”

“Yes.”

“Elsewhere is okay.”

“Yes.”

He lay down.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, finally writing something that was not about him.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Did adults catch more adults?”

“Yes.”

“Did I have to help?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He turned toward the wall.

“Tomorrow can have the wrong decimal.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

The case moved elsewhere.

The child stayed here.

And on the side table, beneath a terrible shark, a suspicious fact waited without proof.

Not everything had to be checked before it could be allowed to sit quietly in the room.

CHAPTER FIFTY-SEVEN

The Wrong Decimal

The wrong decimal waited overnight with admirable patience.

It did not correct itself.

Baren respected that.

At 9:12 a.m., Ms. Rowe placed the worksheet on the table exactly where it had been left the day before. One problem remained unfinished.

0.8 = ?

Baren stared at it.

“Still wrong?”

Ms. Rowe said, “Still waiting.”

“Not angry?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He picked up the pencil.

Morro, near the doorway, pretended to review a document unrelated to decimals, which fooled no one, including the decimal.

Baren wrote:

Then reduced it after a pause.

4/5

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“Correct.”

Baren looked at the page for a moment longer.

“Yesterday it felt too big.”

Lila, seated nearby, said nothing.

Good.

Baren continued.

“Today it is just numbers.”

Ms. Rowe said, “That happens.”

He looked at Morro.

“You want it.”

Morro froze.

“I want what?”

“The sentence.”

“I want many things. Most are denied.”

“Ask.”

Morro took a breath.

“May we use a version for school guidance?”

Baren thought.

“Yes. School only.”

Lila drafted:

A task that feels too large one day may be approachable later when the learner has rested, chosen to return, and is not treated as having failed a character test.

Baren read it.

“Too many words.”

Ms. Rowe wrote a simpler version:

Some wrong answers can wait for tomorrow.

Baren nodded.

“That.”

Morro looked pained but accepted it.

The education advisory gained a small line:

Some wrong answers can wait for tomorrow.

No one made it inspirational.

No one put it over a sunrise.

Morro checked.

Twice.

By 10:00 a.m., the last two sealed defendants were in custody or surrendered.

Adult names.

Adult places.

Adult charges.

The task force released them after child-risk review.

Victor Elysium, founder of Elysium Systems, surrendered through counsel at a federal courthouse. He wore a dark suit, no tie, and the expression of a man who had mistaken inevitability for innocence until paperwork corrected him.

Marian Kade, former director of Mercy Continuity operations, was arrested at a records-storage facility while attempting to access archived material through an expired credential.

The public had expected Victor Elysium eventually.

His name had floated around the edges of the case like smoke that owned lawyers.

But Marian Kade surprised people.

That meant she had done her job well.

Simon knew her.

His face changed when the name was unsealed.

Morro saw.

“Explain.”

Simon swallowed.

“Kade ran logistics. Not public. Not ceremonial. Not strategy language. She made rooms happen.”

“What kind of rooms?”

“All kinds.”

Morro’s eyes sharpened.

“Table Adult?”

“More than that.”

Lila said, “Room Adult.”

Baren’s categories had not included that yet.

Morro wrote it down privately.

Simon continued.

“Kade arranged travel, staff NDAs, minor transport language, counselor schedules, hospitality coding, records pickup, disposal windows, adult-target arrival timing, press quiet periods, medical cover phrases, and post-event summaries.”

Mara, in the newsroom, closed her eyes.

“She made the machine move.”

“Yes,” Simon said.

Morro said, “Public framework?”

Mara answered, already typing.

“Adult logistics.”

“Mechanisms, not mystique.”

The article went live under independent lead:

Elysium Founder and Mercy Operations Director Named in Old Court Indictment

The story explained the charges, the alleged roles, and the court’s continuing child-protection restrictions.

No child faces.

No empty chairs.

No Baren reaction.

High in the body:

Investigators allege that private governance systems depend not only on powerful figureheads, but on operational adults who schedule rooms, move records, manage staff, code travel, control access, and make harmful systems appear administratively ordinary.

Morro approved.

“Good.”

Crowe, appearing by video, said, “Evil needs logistics.”

Morro said, “Public.”

Mara added:

As one advisor put it, “Evil needs logistics.”

Crowe looked both pleased and ashamed.

Morro said, “Adult risk.”

He nodded.

Baren was told after ocean reading.

He had asked whether adults caught the remaining adults.

Lila sat with the category sheet.

“Yes. Two more adult names became public.”

“What kinds?”

“One Money/Data Adult. One Room Adult.”

Baren frowned.

“Room Adult?”

Morro stood near the doorway.

“An adult who makes bad rooms possible. Schedules them. Moves papers. Controls who enters. Makes harm look ordinary.”

Baren looked down at the category sheet.

“That is bad.”

“Yes.”

He wrote:

Room Adults — adults who make bad rooms happen and then say they only handled details.

He paused.

“Details count.”

Morro whispered, “May we—”

Baren pointed.

“Yes. Public. Adults need that.”

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

Details count: scheduling, transport, records, access, forms, staffing, supplies, coding, payment, and follow-up can all enable harm.

Rosa approved through counsel.

Tell him logistics always counts.

Baren smiled when told the safe version.

“Rosa knows.”

“Yes.”

“Her mop?”

“Resolved. Good mop restored.”

He nodded solemnly.

“Justice begins.”

Morro almost laughed.

Almost.

Victor Elysium’s surrender changed the public temperature.

Dahlia had been dangerous because she was intimate with the child’s claim.

Victor was dangerous because he made people feel stupid.

He had built systems.

Platforms.

Prediction architecture.

Sentiment engines.

Engagement classifiers.

Public-meaning products.

The public wanted him to be either genius or monster because both categories protected people from understanding that he had also been a vendor.

A very wealthy vendor.

A vendor with philosophy.

The worst kind.

His company statement read:

Elysium Systems denies wrongdoing and maintains that its products were designed for lawful social analysis, risk forecasting, and institutional decision support. We reject any suggestion that Elysium technology was intended to exploit minors or manipulate public meaning.

Morro read it.

“Vendor words.”

Simon nodded.

“Very.”

Mara’s newsroom published a technical explainer.

Not too technical.

Morro had warned against “hiding harm in diagrams.”

The piece explained that Elysium’s tools did not need to control minds. They only needed to measure attention, identify pressure points, forecast reactions, and suggest language likely to preserve institutional advantage.

That was enough.

Mara’s sidebar, reviewed by independent counsel, said:

Manipulation does not require magic. It can be built from ordinary inputs: what people click, fear, share, doubt, praise, punish, and wait for.

“Good. No machine mysticism.”

Crowe muttered, “The demon is a dashboard.”

Morro turned.

He looked surprised at himself.

“Public?”

Morro thought.

“Body. Adult concept.”

Mara added:

The danger, one advisor noted, is not a mystical machine but a dashboard adults obey because it flatters their appetite for control.

Crowe looked relieved to have been translated.

At noon, Baren had lunch and asked what a dashboard was.

Cole explained badly.

“A board with information.”

Baren frowned.

“Like Morro board?”

Morro said, “My board has judgment.”

Cole said, “Dashboards have numbers.”

“Numbers can lie?”

Ms. Rowe, who had stayed for lunch because Baren wanted to show her the shark drawing under the parrotfish card, said, “Numbers can be true and still used to lie.”

Baren nodded immediately.

“That is Data Adult.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

He looked at his decimal worksheet.

“Numbers need adults watched too.”

Morro asked carefully, “May we use that?”

Baren thought.

“Yes.”

The data advisory gained:

The data note became plain: numbers can be accurate in narrow ways and still be used to manipulate; adults remain responsible for how they use them.

Baren reviewed it.

“Lawyer cereal with numbers.”

“Dry but useful?”

“Dry but necessary.”

At 1:00 p.m., the permanent framework order received its first external citation.

A family court judge in another state cited it anonymously in an order blocking a private school from requiring a student to participate in a restorative meeting with an administrator accused of misconduct.

The student was not named.

The order said:

A child’s refusal to participate in institutional repair is not a failure of healing.

Morro read the citation and sat very still.

Lila noticed.

“You okay?”

“No.”

“Good no?”

“Maybe.”

The law had moved.

Not as brand.

Not as Baren Standard.

As principle.

As wall.

Morro forwarded the order to the task force.

Subject line:

USEFUL. NO CELEBRATION.

The assistant deputy undersecretary replied with no emoji.

Baren was told only the safe version.

“A court somewhere else used similar principles to protect another child from being forced into an adult repair meeting.”

Baren looked up.

“Without me?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He smiled.

Not because he saved anyone.

Because someone else did not need him.

That was the difference adults had been learning too slowly.

At 2:30, Mara came for puzzle visit with one trust fact.

No receipt.

As promised.

She sat across from Baren and said, “One fact?”

“One.”

“Some sea cucumbers breathe through their butts.”

Baren stared at her.

Cole closed his eyes.

Lila looked at the ceiling.

Morro, in the lounge, said, “Absolutely not guidance.”

Baren considered the fact with grave seriousness.

“Trust fact failed.”

Mara laughed.

“It is true.”

“No receipt?”

“No receipt.”

“Then it is either true or you are testing trust.”

“I am not testing trust.”

“It sounds like a fake fact adults use to see if kids believe them.”

Mara opened her mouth.

Closed it.

“That is fair.”

Baren looked at her for a long time.

Then smiled.

“I believe it halfway.”

“Halfway trust?”

“Yes.”

“Is that allowed?”

“Yes. Fraction trust.”

Ms. Rowe, passing by, said, “Fractions return.”

Baren groaned.

Morro whispered, “This is why math matters.”

Baren pointed toward the lounge.

“No doctrine.”

They worked on the cow puzzle.

The sea cucumber fact sat between them, half believed, unverified, and somehow safe.

Mara did not rush to prove it.

That was the important part.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Five minutes requested by Baren.

He asked, “Do you know sea cucumbers?”

Serena blinked.

“Not personally.”

Cole made a sound outside the door.

Baren smiled.

“Good answer.”

Serena asked, “Are we discussing ocean animals?”

“One bad fact.”

“I see.”

He looked at her.

“Can trust be halfway?”

Serena thought.

“Yes.”

“Is that mean?”

“No. Sometimes it is accurate.”

“Can mothers have halfway trust?”

“Yes.”

“Do they get mad?”

“Some do.”

“Will you?”

She took a breath.

“No. I might feel sad. But I will not make you fix it.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

“Okay.”

Before leaving, she said, “Thank you for halfway.”

Baren looked at her.

“That was almost too good.”

She smiled.

“I will work on worse.”

“Good.”

At 5:30, Chronald’s counsel sent a request.

Could Baren be told that Chronald had produced all campaign privacy records and would make no further voluntary statements unless the court required them?

Lila asked Baren whether he wanted an update.

“No.”

So he was not told.

Chronald’s counsel received:

No update given. No response requested.

Chronald sent no response.

Good.

Late Adult learning.

That evening, the big machine became louder again.

Victor Elysium’s surrender awakened tech commentary, investor panic, corporate distancing, and an entire swarm of men explaining that predictive analytics had been misunderstood by people who did not appreciate nuance.

Morro read one thread and said, “Nuance is where cowards rent furniture.”

Crowe begged to use it.

Morro said no.

Mara's newsroom published a technical FAQ:

What Elysium is accused of.

What is not yet proven.

What data tools can and cannot do.

Why engagement prediction can influence institutional choices without mind control.

Why child protection applies even when harm travels through language, metrics, and public expectation rather than direct contact.

Why due process still matters.

Baren did not read it.

He watched an ocean video where a sea turtle ate seagrass without becoming an allegory.

Before bed, Baren finally asked if the wrong decimal had been kept.

Ms. Rowe had left the corrected worksheet in his school folder.

"School folder," Lila said.

"Not drawer?"

"Not drawer."

"Not table?"

"Not table."

"Good."

"What do you want to keep tonight?"

He looked around.

The side table held ocean card, shark drawing, breakfast card, ordinary pencil, suspicious parrotfish fact, and now one blank space where the sea cucumber fact was not written down.

"Nothing new."

"Okay."

He opened the drawer.

Checked.

Closed it.

Only once.

Lila noticed.

He noticed her noticing.

"One check."

"Yes."

"Enough."

"Yes."

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in lounge, receiving reports about arrests without letting them enter the room.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "If other courts use the wall, does that make it less mine?"

Lila sat beside him.

"It was never yours to carry. But some parts came through you."

He thought.

"Can a thing help someone else without taking me with it?"

"Yes."

"Good."

He turned onto his side.

"Then the wall can go."

Lila's eyes stung.

"Okay."

He closed his eyes.

"Not me."

"No. Not you."

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, adult names moved through courts.

Elsewhere, Victor Elysium prepared a defense.

Elsewhere, Dahlia's notebook went through privilege review.

Elsewhere, another child did not have to sit in a room built to repair an adult.

Here, the wrong decimal had waited, been corrected, and gone into a school folder.

A wall had moved without dragging the child behind it.

And on the side table, an unwritten sea cucumber fact remained half believed, which was, for the moment, exactly enough trust.

CHAPTER FIFTY-EIGHT

The Wall Can Go

The wall went before breakfast.

Not physically.

There was no wall in Baren's room except the normal ones, which held paint, a handwashing poster, one outlet plate, and the quiet authority of not being glass.

The wall that went was legal.

Conceptual.

Procedural.

A sentence that had started in a child's protected room and traveled outward without taking the child with it.

At 6:48 a.m., Lila received the order from the other state.

She read it twice.

Then a third time, not because it was unclear, but because clarity had become rare enough to verify.

The child in that case was not named.

The school was not named in the public version.

The administrator was referred to only by role.

The order barred the private school from requiring, encouraging, conditioning, or framing a restorative meeting as part of the student's healing, discipline, scholarship status, community reintegration, or spiritual growth.

The court wrote:

A child's refusal to participate in institutional repair is not a failure of healing.

Then:

Institutional repair is an adult obligation. A harmed child may choose to participate, but the child may not be treated as the missing piece required to complete the adult process.

Lila placed the order on Morro's desk.

Morro read it standing.

Then sat.

This was alarming.

Crowe, present by video because he had sent a plain ocean fact and been temporarily readmitted to adult society, leaned toward the screen.

"Judge?"

Morro held up one finger.

Everyone waited.

Finally, she said, "Good."

One word.

Flat.

Too flat.

Mara, from the newsroom, said softly, "That means very good?"

Morro looked at the order.

"It means the wall moved."

No one spoke.

The wall had moved without Baren's name.

Without his face.

Without the waiting letter.

Without Dahlia.

Without Sump House.

Without Glass Coast.

Without the red copy.

Without the public needing to imagine him at all.

A principle had left the room and become useful somewhere else.

That had been the point.

Also the danger.

Morro stood and walked toward Baren's hallway.

Then stopped.

Turned around.

"No."

Lila looked up.

"No?"

"We do not tell him before breakfast."

"Because?"

"Because he is not a courier for legal relief."

Lila nodded.

"After breakfast if he asks."

"If he asks."

Crowe whispered, "Procedure has become pastoral care."

Morro pointed at the screen.

"Do not relapse."

Baren chose toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

Triangle and rectangle again, but accidental this time because Nurse Imani cut without measuring and then apologized to the geometry.

Baren inspected the plate.

"Accepted."

Cole looked relieved.

Morro watched from the lounge and said nothing.

Private toast had not recurred.

This was just toast.

That mattered.

Baren ate the rectangle first.

Then the triangle.

No interpretation.

Halfway through breakfast, he looked at Lila.

“Did the wall go?”

Lila set down her coffee.

Morro closed her eyes.

Baren sighed.

“You have wall faces.”

Cole muttered, “They do.”

Lila answered.

“Yes. A court somewhere else used a similar protection principle for another child.”

Baren nodded.

“Without me?”

“Yes.”

“Name?”

“No.”

“Face?”

“No.”

“Story?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He ate the triangle corner.

“Did it help?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He looked down at the plate.

“Then the wall can go.”

Lila’s voice softened.

“It did.”

“Not me.”

“No. Not you.”

Morro entered, because she had apparently given up pretending not to be part of breakfast.

“The order moved. You stayed.”

Baren looked at her.

“That is good law.”

Morro paused.

“Yes.”

“You can write that.”

Morro looked startled.

“Public?”

“Maybe not. Adult room first.”

She nodded.

“Adult room first.”

The task force received the phrase two hours later:

Orders and principles should move; protected children should not have to move with them.

Lila marked it for professional training.

Mara did not publish it yet.

Some sentences needed to learn to walk before they were made to run.

At 9:00, Crowe’s plain ocean fact arrived.

One fact.

No sermon.

No metaphor.

Reviewed by Lila for sneaky theology because Crowe had priors.

The fact read:

Some octopuses collect shells and coconut halves to use as portable shelters.

Baren read it.

“Receipts?”

Crowe, on video, held up a marine biology article printout.

Baren looked offended.

“I did not ask for receipts. It was trust fact.”

Crowe froze.

“I overcomplied.”

Morro said, “Common after moral collapse.”

Crowe nodded solemnly.

“Understood.”

Baren considered the fact.

“Portable shelter is good.”

Everyone remained still.

He looked at them.

“No guidance.”

Everyone resumed breathing.

He placed the octopus fact on the side table, then moved it to the floor beside the table.

Lila asked, “Floor?”

“Portable shelter. It can travel.”

Morro stared at the card on the floor.

It took visible effort not to classify the new category of temporary mobile object.

Baren watched her struggle.

“Morro.”

“I am saying nothing.”

“Good.”

Cole looked at the card.

“Octopus knows logistics.”

Baren pointed.

“Careful.”

Cole lifted both hands.

“Plain animal respect.”

“Accepted.”

School reading stayed with oceans.

Ms. Rowe selected a chapter on tide pools.

This was safer than octopuses.

Only somewhat.

Tide pools contained small worlds temporarily separated from the ocean by rock and time. Baren liked them immediately and distrusted that liking even faster.

“No guidance,” he said before anyone breathed.

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“No guidance.”

He read about anemones.

Barnacles.

Small fish.

Water left behind until the tide returned.

He paused at that sentence.

Water left behind until the tide returned.

The room became too attentive.

He looked up.

“No.”

Morro, from the doorway, lifted both hands.

“No writing.”

Lila put her pen down.

Ms. Rowe continued reading as if nothing had happened, which made her the most trustworthy adult in the room for the next three minutes.

Baren liked barnacles less.

“They attach too much.”

Cole said, “Fair.”

Ms. Rowe explained that barnacles attached to survive.

Baren thought.

“Still too much.”

“Okay.”

He drew one barnacle.

It looked like an angry hat.

Trash.

No ceremony.

The side table did not gain barnacles.

Good.

At 10:30, the arrests began producing defenses.

This was healthy.

Annoying.

But healthy.

Victor Elysium’s legal team filed a preliminary statement arguing that his systems were analytical tools, not coercive instruments; that users made independent choices; that public meaning was not property; that prediction was not control; and that the indictment risked criminalizing social science, communications strategy, and lawful risk assessment.

Morro read the statement.

“Some of this is real.”

Mara looked surprised.

“You agree with him?”

“No. I agree that the government must prove the difference between analysis and participation.”

Dr. Rao, on the task force call, nodded.

“The distinction matters. Tools can be used for many purposes. The question is what Elysium knew, designed, encouraged, sold, documented, and profited from.”

Simon added, “And whether the system was configured specifically for child-related public-meaning management, future-claim preservation, or institutional containment.”

Morro pointed.

“Evidence.”

The data advisory was revised.

The revised data advisory separated tools from use: design, marketing, safeguards, warnings, profit, and case-specific deployment would matter.

Mara read it.

“Dry.”

Morro said, “Good.”

“Very dry.”

“Better.”

Baren heard later that Victor Elysium said numbers were just tools.

He frowned.

“A knife is a tool.”

Cole said, “Yes.”

“Toast knife is tool.”

“Yes.”

“Bad knife is tool.”

“Yes.”

“So tool does not answer.”

Lila nodded.

“That is right.”

Baren looked at Morro.

She asked before he could accuse.

“May we use a version?”

“Yes.”

The advisory got a plain-language line:

Calling it a tool did not answer how it was built, sold, used, or controlled.

Morro approved.

“Excellent.”

Baren said, “That one is not lawyer cereal.”

“No?”

“That one is toast knife.”

Morro wrote **toast knife** on her private pad and then crossed it out before anyone could see.

Mara saw.

She said nothing.

Growth was mutual surveillance with mercy.

At noon, lunch was eggs.

This startled everyone.

Baren had avoided eggs because they looked “too breakable and already broken,” which Nurse Imani had wisely not written down in the era before Ask First.

Today he chose them scrambled.

“Dry?”

Nurse Imani asked.

“Not shiny.”

“Everything is not shiny now?”

Baren thought.

“Shiny is suspicious.”

Cole nodded.

“Generally.”

Morro said, “Not legal guidance.”

Baren ate five bites.

Then stopped.

“Done.”

Nurse Imani asked no why.

Took plate.

Good.

At 1:00, Mara’s trust fact from yesterday received a challenge.

Not from Baren.

From Cole.

He had looked up sea cucumbers.

This was a violation of trust fact spirit but not letter, because no one had told Cole he could not verify privately.

The fact was true.

Some sea cucumbers breathe through respiratory trees connected to the cloaca.

Cole learned this and regretted both knowledge and internet access.

He told no one until Baren saw his face.

“You checked.”

Cole froze.

“What?”

“Sea cucumber.”

Cole looked guilty.

Morro looked delighted.

Lila covered a smile.

Baren crossed his arms.

“It was my trust fact.”

Cole nodded.

“I know.”

“You checked it.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because it sounded impossible.”

“Do you trust Mara?”

Cole thought.

“Halfway.”

Baren considered.

“Fraction trust.”

“Yes.”

“Was it true?”

Cole looked pained.

“Yes.”

Baren smiled slowly.

“Mara gets one point.”

Morro whispered, “We are not scoring trust.”

Baren looked at her.

“She gets one point privately.”

“Private point.”

Cole said, “I apologize for unauthorized verification.”

Baren accepted.

“Next time ask.”

“True yes.”

The side table received no new item.

The sea cucumber remained unwritten, half trusted, fully unfortunate.

At 2:00, the task force held its first former-minor advisory session under the new protocol.

Not public.

Compensated.

Independent counsel available.

Cameras off by default.

Participants could use names, pseudonyms, or no name.

They could leave without explanation.

They were not asked to tell their stories.

They were asked to review proposed safeguards.

This distinction mattered.

Dr. Rao opened:

“You are not here to prove harm. The records already show enough to require action. You are here only if you choose to help us avoid building another room.”

Morro approved from her square on the screen.

One participant said, “Paying us is good, but do not make payment feel like buying pain.”

The compensation protocol changed.

Another said, “Do not call us survivors in documents unless we choose that word.”

Language protocol changed.

Another said, “Some of us want public testimony. Do not make protection into silence.”

Speech-choice protocol changed.

Another said, “Some of us want silence. Do not make testimony into courage.”

Public-hearing protocol changed.

Another said, “Stop asking what support would help us share. Ask what support would help us live.”

Morro stopped writing.

Everyone did.

The sentence did not belong to Baren.

It belonged to the adult who said it.

With permission, it entered the advisory:

Ask what helps people live, not only what helps them participate.

Baren never saw the session.

Good.

The wall moved without him.

Other voices entered without becoming him.

Better.

At 3:30, the first public hearing was announced.

Not congressional yet.

State oversight.

Topic:

Private Governance, Child Protection, and Institutional Repair Systems

No protected-minor testimony.

No child witnesses.

Former minors by voluntary written or remote testimony only, with counsel and support.

Workers protected.

Adult records first.

Morro reviewed the hearing plan.

“Acceptable.”

Crowe said, “The title is aggressively boring.”

“Protective.”

Mara’s newsroom published the announcement with rails.

No speculation about whether Baren would testify.

He would not.

Period.

Baren asked about the hearing.

“Adults talking to adults?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“About adult rooms?”

“Yes.”

“Kids?”

“Protected. Former minors can choose.”

“Me?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He went back to the cow puzzle.

The puzzle was nearly finished now.

Only sky remained.

Mara’s section.

She would visit tomorrow.

He left the sky undone on purpose.

Not everything needed finishing today.

At 4:30, Serena sent a request for no visit today.

Her own.

Not because she was upset.

Because she had therapy.

Baren was told.

He looked surprised.

“She can cancel?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Good.”

“Do you want to send a response?”

“No.”

Then:

“Actually yes.”

Lila waited.

“Tell her good therapy. No response.”

Lila sent:

Baren says: good therapy. No response.

Serena replied only through counsel:

Received. No response.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Morro looked at the exchange and said quietly, “Mutual boundaries.”

Baren heard.

“Ask first.”

Morro said, “May that become guidance?”

He thought.

“Yes. Parent visits.”

Guidance gained:

Parent-contact guidance became simpler: adults may need support and limits too, but the child does not manage the adult’s recovery.

Baren read it.

“Lawyer cereal for moms.”

“Dry but useful?”

“Yes.”

At 5:30, puzzle visit from Mara.

She came with no fact.

Baren noticed.

“You owe one point.”

“I do?”

“Sea cucumber true.”

Mara stared.

“You checked?”

“Cole did unauthorized verification.”

Cole looked away.

Mara smiled.

“I see.”

“You get one private point.”

“I am honored.”

“No more sea cucumber facts.”

“Agreed.”

They worked sky.

The cow puzzle had resisted completion for days, maybe because sky was hard or maybe because adults kept interrupting cows with subpoenas.

Mara found three pieces quickly.

Baren found two.

Then one final piece remained.

Blue-gray.

Cloud edge.

Fence shadow maybe.

Mara held it.

Baren looked at it.

“Do not put it in.”

Mara paused.

“Okay.”

“Leave it.”

“Where?”

“Box.”

Mara placed the final piece in the box.

The puzzle remained unfinished by one piece.

Baren looked satisfied.

Morro, from the lounge, appeared physically distressed.

Baren looked at her.

“No.”

Morro said, “I said nothing.”

“Your face said completion.”

“My face has no legal force.”

“Good.”

Mara asked, “Why leave it out?”

Baren shrugged.

“Finished feels like adults coming.”

Mara nodded.

“We can leave it.”

“Not forever maybe.”

“Maybe.”

“Review tomorrow.”

“Review tomorrow.”

The cow puzzle stayed one piece unfinished.

No metaphor.

No ending.

Just choice.

Night arrived without a drawer check.

Then with one.

Baren changed his mind.

He opened the drawer.

Everything still there.

He added nothing.

Closed it.

One check.

Enough.

The side table stayed the same.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Breakfast card.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish fact under shark.

Octopus portable shelter fact on floor beside table, still traveling.

The cow puzzle on the common table, missing one sky piece on purpose.

Cole outside.

Lila nearby.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in the lounge, learning to survive incompleteness.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can the wall go and the puzzle stay unfinished?”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He looked toward the door.

“If other kids use the wall, they can finish their own puzzle.”

“Yes.”

“Or not.”

“Or not.”

He nodded.

“That is good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, former minors told adults how not to build another room.

Elsewhere, adult defendants prepared defenses.

Elsewhere, courts began borrowing walls without taking children.

Here, one puzzle piece remained in the box.

Not lost.

Not hidden.

Not evidence.

Not symbol.

Just not placed yet.

And that made the room feel, for once, like tomorrow had not been ambushed.

CHAPTER FIFTY-NINE

The Piece in the Box

The missing piece became famous only inside the room.

This was the safest kind of fame.

It had no followers, no headline, no foundation grant, no commemorative tote bag, and no adult in a blazer explaining why incompleteness was the new frontier in child-centered reform.

It was a blue-gray puzzle piece sitting in the bottom of a cardboard box.

Cloud edge.

Maybe fence shadow.

Maybe sky pretending to be ground.

Baren checked that it was still there before breakfast.

Not the drawer.

The box.

He lifted the lid, looked at the piece, nodded, and closed it again.

Morro watched from the lounge.

“Box check,” she said.

Baren looked at her.

“Not a thing.”

“Noted.”

“Do not note.”

“Verbally unnoted.”

“That is still noting.”

Morro took a sip of coffee.

“Then forgotten with awareness.”

Baren stared.

Cole, from the hallway, said, “She is trying.”

Baren considered.

“Trying Adult.”

Morro inclined her head.

“Accepted.”

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card today.

Baren did not ask for one.

Nurse Imani did not make one.

The toaster clicked.

Toast arrived.

Toast was eaten.

No public observance.

This, too, was progress.

At 8:30 a.m., the first hearing prep packet arrived at the unit by mistake.

Not a leak.

Not sabotage.

A clerical routing error.

Those were sometimes more dangerous because they had no villain strong enough to satisfy.

The packet was addressed correctly to the task-force evidence room but copied to Lila’s secure inbox under an old distribution tag from the days when the stabilization unit had been mistaken for the center of the universe.

Lila saw the subject line:

STATE OVERSIGHT HEARING — WITNESS ORDER / PRIVATE GOVERNANCE

She did not open the attachments.

She forwarded the error notice to the task force, requested immediate list correction, and logged the routing issue outside Baren's record.

"Good."

Then she called the task force administrator and said, "Remove the child's care team from national hearing distributions unless the material directly concerns his protective order."

The administrator apologized.

Morro said, "Apology received. Correction pending."

Five minutes later, the administrator confirmed the distribution list had been fixed.

Morro replied:

Receipt accepted.

Baren, reading about tide pools, looked up.

"Adult email face."

Lila smiled.

"Wrong packet came here. We sent it away."

"Was it about me?"

"No."

"Did you read it?"

"No."

"Good."

He returned to the tide pool.

Then looked up again.

"Sending away is a thing."

Morro asked, "May we—"

"No."

She nodded.

"Private."

Baren read the next paragraph.

A tide pool fish survived in shallow water until the tide returned.

He closed the book halfway.

"Book is trying."

Ms. Rowe said, "We can switch."

"Oceans are too metaphor today."

"Dinosaurs?"

"Yes."

The ocean book left.

The dinosaur book arrived.

No one made an interpretive note.

The adult world had asked first and been denied.

The wall held.

Dinosaurs were safer until extinction.

This was a problem with dinosaurs generally.

Ms. Rowe chose a section on fossils instead.

Bones.

Tracks.

Impressions.

Sediment.

How scientists learn from what remains.

Baren liked tracks.

"Tracks are receipts," he said.

Then pointed at Morro before she moved.

"No."

Morro froze in the doorway.

"I was merely existing."

"Exist quieter."

Cole coughed.

Nurse Imani looked away.

Ms. Rowe continued.

A fossil was not the animal.

It was evidence that the animal had been there.

Baren sat still.

Then said, "Okay."

No one asked what okay meant.

Good.

He read about a dinosaur footprint preserved in mud that hardened into stone.

"Did the dinosaur know it was making evidence?"

"No," Ms. Rowe said.

"Good."

He turned the page.

"Then it was just walking."

"Yes."

He liked that.

Just walking.

He drew a dinosaur footprint on scratch paper.

Not good.

Not terrible.

True middle.

He placed it near the trash, paused, then put it into the school folder.

“School,” he said.

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“School.”

Not drawer.

Not table.

Not evidence.

Learning.

Categories were not cages when the person controlled them.

Morro wanted that sentence badly.

She did not ask.

Baren noticed.

“You can ask.”

Morro straightened.

“May I use a version for professional guidance?”

He thought.

“Yes. But not about me.”

Lila drafted:

The note said categories had jobs: school record, therapy note, legal filing, keepsake, and public statement were not interchangeable just because they held information.

Baren reviewed it.

“Dry but very safe.”

Morro smiled faintly.

“Excellent.”

At 10:00 a.m., the state oversight hearing plan changed because former minors changed it.

Correctly.

The draft hearing order had placed former-minor statements after agency testimony and before expert panels. That made sense to the adults who wrote agendas. It did not make sense to the former-minor advisory group.

One participant said, “Do not use us as emotional opening act.”

Another said, “Do not put us after agencies like we are public comment on their paperwork.”

Another said, "Some of us want written statements entered without reading them aloud."

Another said, "Some of us want to read. Do not make one format morally better."

The agenda changed.

Adult records first.

Agency mechanisms.

Worker-witness conditions.

Expert safeguards.

Then voluntary former-minor statements in chosen form, with the option to submit written testimony without oral presentation, appear remotely, use a support person, use only first name or pseudonym, or withdraw before the hearing.

Morro read the revised plan.

"Better."

Crowe, remote, said, "The room is learning not to build itself around pain."

Morro pointed at the screen.

"That may be public."

Crowe looked startled.

"It may?"

"Adult concept. Useful."

Mara's newsroom later included:

Advocates involved in hearing planning warned against using former minors as an "emotional opening act." The revised agenda places adult records and institutional mechanisms first, with voluntary testimony offered only under participant-controlled conditions.

Baren was not told the phrase.

He did not need another adult-room improvement inside his lunch.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole was allowed one geometry comment.

He chose, "Stable."

Baren nodded.

Morro said, "This is becoming custom."

Baren looked at her.

"Private custom."

"Accepted."

He ate.

Then asked, "Are other kids talking?"

Lila answered carefully.

“Some adults who were harmed as children are choosing to give advice or statements. Some are not. Both are okay.”

“Do they have to be first?”

“No. They changed that.”

“Good.”

“Why good?”

Baren shrugged.

“If adults made the bad rooms, adults can talk first.”

Morro asked with her face, not words.

Baren sighed.

“Yes.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Oversight guidance said adult records and systems go first; harmed people are not emotional proof for the room.

Baren approved the safe version.

“Good. Adults first when adults did it.”

That line traveled in professional circles.

Not as slogan.

As correction.

At 1:30 p.m., Victor Elysium requested permission to make a public technical statement.

His counsel proposed a white paper explaining the limitations of predictive analytics, institutional decision support tools, and engagement modeling.

Morro read the request and said, “Absolutely not without court review.”

Victor’s counsel argued scientific speech.

Government argued potential jury contamination and public narrative manipulation.

Morro argued, unofficially and to the coffee machine, that men with dashboards should not be allowed to white-paper their way out of indictments before discovery.

The court ordered any public technical statement limited to procedural matters and prohibited discussion of protected persons, child-related modeling, future-claim analytics, or case-specific tool design.

Victor issued no statement.

Instead, several academics unaffiliated with him published explainers.

Some good.

Some allergic to moral responsibility.

One wrote that predictive systems merely reveal social dynamics already present.

Mara read that line and sent it to Morro.

Morro replied:

A mirror can still be aimed.

Mara asked:

Public?

Morro answered:

Adult concept. Yes.

The data explainer updated:

Predictive tools may reflect existing social dynamics, but reflection is not neutral when a tool is designed, aimed, sold, or used to exploit what it reveals. A mirror can still be aimed.

Baren did not read it.

He was outside under the sad maple watching ants attempt a crumb.

Better use of attention.

The ants created an unexpected governance question.

Baren dropped a tiny piece of cracker near the bench.

An ant found it.

Then more ants.

Then too many ants.

Nurse Imani said they should move before the ants discovered jurisdiction.

Baren crouched slightly, watching.

“They work together.”

Cole said, “Yes.”

“Adults will ruin ants.”

“Probably.”

“Are ants good?”

“Ants are ants.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

Then one ant tried to carry a crumb too large and failed.

Another joined.

Then another.

The crumb moved.

Baren watched.

No one spoke.

Finally he said, “Okay.”

They moved benches.

No ant doctrine.

Morro later asked why there was a cracker crumb on the courtyard log.

Nurse Imani said, “Ant matter.”

Morro opened her mouth.

Baren, from the common room, shouted, “No.”

Morro closed it.

At 3:00 p.m., Rosa’s mop issue resolved fully.

Good mop restored.

Supervisor retrained.

Supply closet access logged.

Labor monitor satisfied.

Rosa returned a message through counsel:

Tell everyone I am not famous. I am working.

Morro approved the message.

Baren was told only the safe part:

“Rosa’s good mop is back. She says she is working.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

Then added, “Working is not famous.”

Lila looked at him.

“May that be public?”

“Yes. Worker guidance.”

The labor advisory gained:

Worker-witnesses should not be made famous as a substitute for being protected. Working is not fame; job security, tools, pay, schedules, and freedom from retaliation are the relevant safeguards.

Rosa later replied:

Correct. Also breaks.

The advisory was updated.

Baren approved.

“Breaks matter.”

Morro said, “Labor law agrees.”

“Good.”

At 4:00 p.m., Chronald requested a visit.

Not with Baren.

With Morro.

Morro said no.

Then yes.

Then regretted yes.

The meeting was remote.

Counsel present.

Lila observed.

Chronald looked better and worse. Less staged. More human. Unhelpfully human.

He said, "I do not know what to do with the fact that my best act is staying away."

Morro replied, "Then continue doing it."

He nodded.

"I am producing the remaining donor materials."

"Good."

"I am ending the campaign formally."

No one spoke.

Chronald continued.

"I should have done it earlier."

"Yes," Morro said.

He looked down.

"I wanted to be president."

Morro said nothing.

"I wanted the story to bend around me."

Still nothing.

"I thought refusing to use him might make me worthy of winning."

Morro answered, "There it is."

Chronald closed his eyes.

"I will not announce it as a fatherhood decision."

"Good."

"I will cite legal constraints and ongoing investigations."

"Better."

"I will not mention Baren."

"Correct."

He looked at her.

"Can I say my family requires privacy?"

"No."

"Can I say I am complying with court orders involving my family?"

"No."

"What can I say?"

Morro slid a drafted statement across the screen.

Chronald read it.

I am ending my campaign effective today. Given ongoing investigations and my obligations to cooperate with lawful process, I will not seek office. I will continue producing records as required. I will make no further comment at this time.

He stared.

“That is all?”

“That is all.”

“It sounds like death.”

“It sounds like accountability with the adjectives removed.”

Chronald laughed once.

Not happily.

“I hate it.”

“That improves it.”

He agreed.

The statement went out at 5:00 p.m.

No family.

No son.

No father pain.

No healing arc.

No nation.

No destiny.

Just ending.

Mara’s newsroom published:

Chronald Sump Ends Presidential Campaign Amid Ongoing Records Investigation

The public exploded anyway.

But with fewer handles to grab.

Baren was told because this affected his immediate family and the public environment.

“Your father ended his campaign,” Lila said.

Baren looked at her.

“Did he use me?”

“No.”

“Did he say father?”

“No.”

“Did he say family privacy?”

“No.”

“What did he say?”

Lila read the statement.

Baren listened.

“That is boring.”

Morro said, “Yes.”

“Good.”

He thought.

“Is he sad?”

“Probably,” Lila said.

“Do I have to know?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He went back to the cow puzzle.

The missing sky piece remained in the box.

Chronald’s campaign ended without being placed into Baren’s drawer.

That night, the public tried to make the campaign ending about Baren anyway.

Of course.

Some said Chronald sacrificed power for his son.

Correction.

Some said Baren had destroyed his father’s dream.

Correction.

Some said the child had ended a presidential campaign without appearing.

Correction.

Some said silence was power.

Correction.

Some said privacy had won.

Correction.

Mara wrote until her eyes hurt.

Chronald Sump ended his campaign in a statement citing investigations and legal obligations. The protected minor did not make the decision, issue a statement, appear, testify, or direct the outcome. Adult political consequences should be analyzed through adult records and adult choices.

Morro approved.

Baren saw the safe version.

“Adults keep trying to hand me things.”

“Yes.”

“Do not take them.”

“We won’t.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Before bed, he stood before the cow puzzle.

One piece still in the box.

Mara had not visited today.

The sky waited.

Baren lifted the final piece.

Everyone pretended not to notice.

He held it above the empty space.

Paused.

Put it back in the box.

“Not today.”

Lila nodded.

“Okay.”

He went to his room.

Opened the drawer.

Checked.

Closed it.

One check.

Enough.

Side table unchanged.

Octopus fact still on floor.

The portable shelter had traveled nowhere.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in lounge reading Chronald’s end-of-campaign statement again,
apparently for the pleasure of its ugliness.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can a big thing end and not be mine?”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Even if people say it is?”

“Yes.”

“Receipts?”

“The statement. The corrections. The orders.”

“Good.”

He turned onto his side.

“Campaign can go.”

“Yes.”

“Not me.”

“No.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, a presidential campaign died without music.

Elsewhere, adult defendants hired more lawyers.

Elsewhere, courts borrowed walls.

Elsewhere, workers got mops back.

Here, a puzzle remained unfinished by choice.

And in the box, the last piece of sky waited without becoming the future.

CHAPTER SIXTY

The Campaign Can Go

The campaign tried to die badly.

This was predictable.

Campaigns were not built for dignified death. They were built for music, motion, lighting, slogans, polls, maps, donor calls, volunteer tears, and carefully staged concession speeches in rooms where the flag always looked surprised to be involved.

Chronald Sump gave it none of that.

His statement was four sentences.

No podium.

No family.

No fatherhood.

No nation.

No destiny.

No storm.

No son.

I am ending my campaign effective today. Given ongoing investigations and my obligations to cooperate with lawful process, I will not seek office. I will continue producing records as required. I will make no further comment at this time.

That was all.

Morro called it “the most morally successful boring thing he has ever done.”

Crowe said, “A eulogy without candles.”

Morro looked at him.

“Do not improve it.”

“I am trying to under-improve it.”

“You are failing upward.”

Baren heard the statement after dinner and approved it as boring. Then he sent the campaign away in his own mind with three words:

“Campaign can go.”

Not me.

That was the distinction.

The adult machine did not respect distinctions naturally. Distinctions had to be built, defended, corrected, and occasionally stapled to people’s foreheads in plain language.

So the public tried to connect him anyway.

By 8:00 p.m., the first tribute video appeared.

Chronald in earlier rallies.

Chronald holding babies.

Chronald looking toward a doorway.

Chronald saying, years before any of this, that fatherhood taught him “what power is for.”

The video ended with text:

HE CHOSE HIS SON OVER POWER.

Morro watched it once.

Only once.

Then said, “Correction.”

Mara’s newsroom published:

There is no public record that the protected minor requested, caused, approved, or participated in Chronald Sump’s campaign decision. Sump’s own statement cites investigations and legal obligations. Framing the campaign’s end as a child’s moral victory, a fatherly sacrifice, or a family-healing act risks converting the protected minor’s privacy into political meaning.

“Good.”

Crowe said, “Can we add that adults love smuggling sainthood through exits?”

“No.”

“Internal?”

“Barely.”

The second tribute video appeared at 8:19.

THE BOY WHO ENDED A PRESIDENCY BEFORE IT BEGAN

Morro stood.

No one liked when Morro stood.

Lila was already drafting.

Simon flagged source networks.

Mara wrote fast.

The protected minor did not end a campaign. Adult choices, adult records, adult investigations, and adult legal obligations are the relevant facts. Do not assign political consequence to a child who has not spoken publicly and owes no reaction.

Baren was not told.

He was sleeping.

Good.

Let adults correct adults while the child was not watching them try to hand him a dead campaign like a bouquet.

By morning, the campaign office began emptying.

Boxes.

Staff badges.

Donor call sheets.

Unused signs.

Stage backdrops.

A warehouse full of red, white, and blue rectangles that had once promised history and now promised recycling.

Bex Alton supervised the shutdown with the precision of a woman who had long ago learned that loyalty without boundaries becomes cleanup.

She sent records to the court as ordered.

Draft ads.

Messaging tests.

Internal polling.

Donor memos.

The fatherhood pivot.

The restraint language.

The ordinary-child contingency.

The campaign had tested everything.

How voters reacted if Chronald mentioned Baren.

How voters reacted if he did not.

How voters interpreted silence.

Whether restraint increased trust.

Whether visible grief helped.

Whether “protective father” outperformed “strong leader.”

Whether “family privacy” softened the Elysium issue.

Whether “ordinary childhood” could neutralize public appetite while preserving emotional attachment.

Morro read the poll headings and said, “Politics is a compost heap with fonts.”

Mara asked, “Public?”

“God no.”

“Internal?”

“Unfortunately accurate.”

One poll question read:

Does knowing Candidate Sump refuses to display his minor child make you more likely to view him as morally grounded?

Baren never saw it.

He did not need to know that even not being displayed had been measured.

The court did.

Mara’s article explained the mechanism:

Records show the campaign tested whether the protected minor’s absence could strengthen Chronald Sump’s public image. Such testing illustrates how privacy may become political material even when a child is not shown.

“High body.”

The article also stated:

Non-display is not automatically protection. The question remains who controls the privacy, who benefits from it, and whether the child’s absence is being measured, marketed, or held for future use.

Privacy with receipts.

Again.

Again.

Again.

The public was slow, but repetition with receipts could carve stone.

Baren chose dinosaur reading that morning.

Not oceans.

“Oceans are resting,” he said.

Ms. Rowe accepted this without making the ocean feel abandoned.

Dinosaurs returned through footprints.

Tracks.

Bones.

Teeth.

Eggs.

Baren liked eggs better as fossils than breakfast.

“Fossil eggs do not look shiny,” he said.

Nurse Imani said, “Noted.”

Baren looked at her.

She smiled.

“Remembered, not recorded.”

“Good.”

Ms. Rowe showed him a page about nests.

Some dinosaurs protected eggs.

Some likely did not.

Scientists could infer from nest patterns, but not know everything.

Baren liked that.

“Not know everything is allowed in science?”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Law?”

Morro, from the doorway, answered, “Law pretends no, then builds burdens of proof because yes.”

Baren considered.

“That was almost useful.”

“Almost?”

“Too many doors.”

Ms. Rowe continued.

A fossil trackway showed where a group of dinosaurs had walked together.

Baren touched the picture.

“They were just walking.”

“Yes.”

“And now adults know.”

“Yes.”

“Did walking become evidence later?”

“Yes.”

He thought.

“That is okay if no one made them walk for evidence.”

Morro inhaled.

Baren pointed.

“Ask.”

“May we use that?”

“For adult records. Not me.”

Lila drafted:

Evidence that later proves important is different from conduct created to produce evidence, meaning, or public value. Protection requires distinguishing lived experience from staged or extracted proof.

Baren read it.

“Dry.”

“Useful?”

“Yes.”

“Safe?”

He thought.

“Yes.”

The advisory desk added it.

Morro approved.

The dinosaur continued walking across stone, unaware of its contribution to procedural ethics.

Lucky dinosaur.

At 10:30, Chronald’s former campaign staff began speaking anonymously.

Some claimed they had objected to family messaging.

Some claimed they had never seen the Baren-related strategy.

Some claimed Bex controlled everything.

Some claimed Simon.

Some claimed consultants.

Some claimed the trust.

Some claimed Chronald knew.

Some claimed Chronald did not know.

Morro read the leaks and said, “Rats with résumé formatting.”

Lila said, “Records first.”

“Always.”

Mara’s newsroom declined to publish anonymous blame without documents.

This angered several former staffers, who then tried less careful outlets.

The less careful outlets published.

Mara corrected.

Anonymous campaign claims should be evaluated against documents, sworn statements, communication records, and production logs. Staff disagreement, late discomfort, or selective memory does not establish accountability or innocence.

Baren was not told.

He was doing math.

Decimals again.

The wrong decimal was no longer wrong, but decimals had cousins.

0.6 became 3/5.

0.2 became 1/5.

0.125 made Baren stare at Ms. Rowe like she had betrayed him personally.

“Too small.”

“It is one-eighth.”

“It came dressed as a trap.”

“We can leave it for tomorrow.”

Baren smiled.

“Some wrong answers can wait.”

“Yes.”

He left 0.125 blank.

No shame.

School progress.

Not life progress.

At noon, the state oversight hearing began.

Adult records first.

Morro watched from the consult room.

Not the lounge.

Baren ate grilled cheese in the common area, unaware that across the state adults were finally saying things into microphones that should have been said in smaller rooms years earlier.

The hearing opened with record summaries.

Old Court mechanisms.

Mercy Futures programming.

Institutional repair systems.

Private governance structures.

Worker-witness vulnerability.

Deferred contact instruments.

Data tools.

Media amplification.

Religious language misuse.

Campaign privacy testing.

No child witness.

No protected minor statement.

No photograph.

No empty chair.

The empty chair had been specifically forbidden after someone in hearing planning suggested a “symbolic seat for children not yet ready to speak.”

Morro had responded:

Absolutely not. Buy a printer.

The hearing used binders instead.

Good.

The first adult witness was a records custodian.

Boring.

Essential.

She explained chain of custody for the Bellwether documents, Abiquiú retreat boxes, campaign records, and Dahlia's notebook.

A lawmaker tried to ask what the protected minor thought of the arrests.

The chair cut him off before Morro could send a facial expression through the internet hard enough to crack glass.

"This hearing concerns adult records and systems," the chair said.
"Protected minors are not witnesses here."

Morro sat back.

"Good."

Progress occasionally wore a suit and read instructions correctly.

The former-minor statements came later.

Chosen formats.

Some written only.

Some read by counsel.

One participant appeared by audio, no video.

One used first name only.

One withdrew ten minutes before speaking.

The withdrawal was honored.

No one filled the gap with commentary.

That may have been the most radical moment of the hearing.

An absence stayed empty.

Not interpreted.

Not repaired.

Not mourned.

Not branded.

Just respected.

Morro wrote that down.

Then crossed it out.

No Keeping lesson had damaged her in useful ways.

At 1:30, Baren asked if the hearing was happening.

"Yes," Lila said.

"Adults first?"

"Yes."

"Kids?"

“Former minors only if they choose. One person chose not to speak after all, and adults did not make it a thing.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

“Do you want to know more?”

“No.”

He looked at the cow puzzle.

Missing sky piece still in the box.

“Maybe tomorrow I put it in.”

“Okay.”

“Maybe not.”

“Okay.”

He looked suspicious.

“You are getting better at okay.”

Lila smiled.

“I have good teachers.”

“Do not make that about me.”

“I was including Nurse Imani.”

“Good.”

Nurse Imani, passing with medication inventory, said, “I accept credit.”

At 2:00, Bex Alton requested whistleblower protection.

Morro read the request three times.

“Interesting.”

Bex had produced records.

Bex had supervised shutdown.

Bex had helped draft some messages and blocked others.

Bex had known enough to matter and not enough to be clean.

Her declaration stated:

I believed I was preventing worse exploitation by keeping the campaign from displaying Baren. I did not understand quickly enough that we were still treating his absence as usable. When I did understand, I preserved records. I did not go public because I believed public disclosure would expose him. I now submit to whatever process determines whether that belief was justified or self-protective.

Morro looked at Lila.

“Useful.”

Lila nodded.

“Not absolution.”

“Never.”

Baren was told only because he asked about adult categories after seeing Lila with the sheet.

“What kind?”

“Campaign Adult. Late Adult with documents. Maybe Trying Adult. Still being watched.”

He nodded.

“Did she bring papers?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

“Do you want her name?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

He added nothing to the sheet.

The categories were enough for now.

At 3:30, the hearing reached the worker panel.

Rosa did not testify.

Her choice.

Instead, labor counsel read a statement approved by worker-witness participants:

We are not invisible until useful. We are not brave instead of employed. We are not sources instead of workers. If our records matter, our schedules matter. Our tools matter. Our breaks matter. Our pay matters. Our supervisors matter. Our fear matters. Protection that does not reach the supply closet does not reach the worker.

Morro stood.

Then sat.

No one commented.

Baren was not watching.

He was in the courtyard with Cole, examining whether the sad maple had improved.

It had not.

Good.

Later, Lila told him Rosa’s worker group made a statement and included tools, pay, and breaks.

Baren smiled.

“Good.”

“Do you want to know anything else?”

“Good mop?”

“Yes.”

“Then no.”

At 4:30, the hearing ended for the day.

No closing montage.

No child chorus.

No moment of silence.

The chair said:

“This hearing will continue tomorrow with adult institutional witnesses.”

“Adult institutional witnesses. Excellent punishment.”

Mara’s newsroom published a hearing summary.

Adult records.

Worker protections.

Former-minor choice.

No protected child testimony.

No spectacle.

Headline:

Oversight Hearing Centers Adult Records and Worker Protections in Private Governance Inquiry

Boring.

Strong.

Morro approved.

Baren did not read it.

He watched a dinosaur video where a paleontologist brushed dirt from a fossil very slowly.

He liked the brush.

“Small tools,” he said.

Cole said, “Careful work.”

“No guidance.”

“Private.”

“Good.”

At 5:30, Chronald left the hospital.

Not home.

A secure residence under court-noticed conditions.

No press.

No statement.

No family photograph.

No wave.

No “healing journey.”

Bex made sure.

Baren was told only because he asked if Chronald was still in the hospital.

“He left the hospital and is staying somewhere secure. He made no statement.”

“Good.”

“Do you want more?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

He thought.

“Hospital can go too.”

“Yes.”

“Not me.”

“No.”

The phrase no longer needed guidance.

It was his way of setting things down.

Campaign can go.

Hospital can go.

Wall can go.

Not me.

Adults were finally learning to carry exits without handing them to him.

Evening.

Mara visited.

One fact.

No receipts.

Approved in advance by Baren.

“Some dinosaurs had feathers,” she said.

Baren frowned.

“That sounds like birds trying to win history.”

Mara laughed.

“It does.”

“Trust fact?”

“Trust fact.”

“Halfway?”

“Fair.”

He looked at the cow puzzle.

The last sky piece waited in the box.

Mara did not look at it.

Good.

They worked no puzzle.

Instead, they sat at the common table and discussed whether feathered dinosaurs looked embarrassed.

Baren said no.

Mara said some probably looked majestic.

Cole said some looked like angry chickens with legal standing.

Morro shouted from the lounge, "No legal standing for prehistoric chickens."

Baren laughed.

Real.

Clear.

Allowed.

No one kept it.

Before bed, Baren stood by the cow puzzle.

He lifted the last piece.

Held it.

Put it in.

The sky completed.

No music.

No adult intake of breath.

Morro visibly stopped herself from reacting.

The puzzle was finished.

Baren looked at it for a long moment.

Then took out the piece again.

Placed it back in the box.

Lila smiled.

"Finished and unfinished?"

Baren nodded.

"Both can be true."

Cole said softly, "True yes."

Morro did not ask to use it.

She knew.

Some sentences stayed in rooms.

Baren went to bed.

Drawer check.

One.

Side table check.

None.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge.

The campaign gone.

Hospital gone.

Wall gone.

Hearing elsewhere.

Adults first.

Workers protected.

Former minors choosing.

Puzzle finished and unfinished.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can tomorrow be not the end?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Good."

He closed his eyes.

"Endings make adults weird."

Morro, in the lounge, whispered, "Correct."

No one wrote it down.

The light dimmed.

The case continued elsewhere.

The child remained here.

And the final piece of sky rested in the box, having proven it could fit without being required to stay.

CHAPTER SIXTY-ONE

The Piece Could Fit

The piece could fit.

That was the important fact.

It did not have to stay.

Baren had placed the final sky piece into the cow puzzle, watched the picture become whole, then removed it and returned it to the box. No one clapped. No one sighed. No one said closure. No one said progress.

Morro had looked as if her bones were arguing with procedure, but she survived.

By morning, the puzzle still sat on the common table, complete except for the one deliberate absence.

The piece waited in the box.

The sky had a gap shaped exactly like something known.

Baren approved.

“Good,” he said at breakfast.

Nurse Imani looked over.

“Puzzle?”

“Yes.”

“Still okay?”

“Yes.”

“Toast?”

“Cereal.”

Morro looked up from the lounge.

“Again?”

Baren frowned.

“Cereal is allowed.”

“I did not say otherwise.”

“Your eyebrows did.”

Morro lowered her eyebrows with judicial effort.

“Withdrawn.”

Breakfast proceeded.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

The day began without toast, which helped prevent ritual formation.

Crowe appeared by video for morning check-in because the oversight hearing would continue and religious witnesses were scheduled. He wore a plain sweater and held no ocean fact.

Baren saw him on the lounge monitor.

“No fact?”

Crowe said, “No fact.”

“Forgot?”

“No. I thought maybe facts should not be every time.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

Crowe looked relieved.

Morro muttered, “He can learn.”

Crowe heard.

“Trying Adult.”

Baren approved from across the room.

“Useful now?”

Crowe nodded.

“Useful now.”

“Not sad now?”

“Also sad now.”

“Useful first.”

“Yes.”

The video stayed on mute after that, because adults were going to discuss adult religion again and Baren had requested no Prayer Adult breakfast.

The oversight hearing resumed at 9:00 a.m.

Adult institutional witnesses.

Excellent punishment.

The first witness was a university general counsel who had spent twenty-two years making sentences less guilty.

He testified that private restorative processes were intended to resolve sensitive community matters without exposing students or families to adversarial systems.

Morro watched remotely from the consult room.

Lila beside her.

Mara in the newsroom.

Dr. Rao on task-force channel.

The hearing chair asked, “Were minors provided independent representation before participation in these processes?”

The general counsel said, “We provided supportive adults.”

Morro said, “No.”

The chair said, “That was not my question.”

Good chair.

The counsel adjusted.

“In many cases, parents or guardians were present.”

The chair asked, “Were the institutions whose conduct was at issue involved in selecting those adults?”

The counsel took too long.

“Yes, in some cases.”

The room understood.

Supportive adults chosen by the institution were not independent just because they smiled.

The next witness, a foundation director, testified that youth leadership voices had always been valued.

Morro said, "There it is."

The chair asked, "Were youth participants compensated?"

The director said, "They were offered meaningful leadership opportunities."

Labor counsel, seated behind the witness table, visibly closed her eyes.

The chair repeated, "Were they compensated?"

The director said, "Not generally."

The chair said, "So their value was recognized symbolically."

Morro leaned toward the screen.

"Good."

The director said, "I would not characterize—"

The chair said, "I just did."

Morro sat back.

"Very good."

Crowe, watching from a separate feed, messaged:

Adult institutional witnesses are restorative for me.

Morro replied:

Do not enjoy process too much. It notices.

Baren did not watch the hearing.

He had dinosaur reading.

Ms. Rowe chose a chapter on feathers.

Mara's trust fact had opened the subject, but Ms. Rowe brought receipts because school was not trust fact. School required sources.

Baren accepted this distinction.

The book showed feathered dinosaurs that looked less like majestic ancient beasts and more like angry birds who had lost a court appeal.

Baren stared.

"History is embarrassing."

Ms. Rowe smiled.

"Sometimes."

"Did people think dinosaurs had no feathers before?"

"Yes. Many did."

"Then learned different?"

"Yes."

"Did adults get mad?"

"Some."

“Because old picture wrong?”

“Yes.”

Baren thought about this.

“Changing the picture is hard.”

Lila looked up.

Morro, from the doorway, did not breathe.

Baren glanced at them.

“Ask first.”

Morro asked, “May that be used for learning guidance?”

Baren considered.

“Yes. Learning. Not life.”

Ms. Rowe wrote:

Learning sometimes means changing the picture when better evidence arrives.

Baren nodded.

“That is school-safe.”

Morro looked faintly moved and professionally annoyed.

“School-safe,” she repeated.

“Not court-safe?”

“Everything is court-safe if filed carefully.”

Baren frowned.

“That is why adults are tired.”

“Yes,” Morro said.

He returned to feathered dinosaurs.

Then drew one.

It looked like a furious chicken with a tail.

Cole, outside the door, whispered, “Legal standing.”

Baren pointed without looking.

“No.”

Cole nodded.

“Private.”

At 10:30, Victor Elysium’s defense team filed the first motion to dismiss.

Fast.

Polished.

Predictable.

It argued vagueness, overbreadth, lawful analytics, lack of direct contact with minors, First Amendment concerns, absence of property interest in public meaning, and failure to allege causation.

Morro read the motion once.

Then again.

Then said, "It is not frivolous."

Mara looked at her through the task-force screen.

"That sounds bad."

"It sounds like law."

Simon looked pale.

"Can he win?"

Morro answered, "Some arguments may narrow charges. That is not the same as innocence."

Lila nodded.

The prosecution would need to prove not that Elysium built scary tools, but that he knowingly joined conduct that used those tools to enable unlawful control, obstruction, exploitation, or witness interference.

Morro wrote:

NO MAGIC. PROVE MECHANISM.

Dr. Rao approved.

Mara's newsroom published a legal explainer:

Elysium Motion Tests Boundary Between Analytics and Participation in Private Governance Case

Dry.

Necessary.

The article explained that a system predicting public reaction was not automatically illegal. The question would be whether the defendants used analytics as part of agreements or actions to control records, pressure children or former minors, preserve future claims, obstruct reporting, or manage witness and institutional response.

Baren was not told about the motion unless he asked.

He did not.

He was coloring the feathered dinosaur badly on purpose.

The dinosaur did not need causation analysis.

Lucky dinosaur.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Baren allowed it.

Cole said nothing.

This restraint concerned everyone.

Baren looked at him.

"You can say one."

Cole said, "Triangles returned voluntarily."

Baren nodded.

“Accepted.”

Morro said, “This is now common law.”

Baren pointed.

“No doctrine.”

Morro lifted both hands.

“Joke withdrawn.”

He ate.

Then asked, “Are adults arguing about numbers again?”

Lila asked, “What do you mean?”

“Data Adult.”

“Yes. The data adult’s lawyers are arguing.”

“Can they argue?”

“Yes.”

“Do adults prove tool?”

“They must prove what he did with the tool.”

Baren picked up half the sandwich.

“Toast knife.”

Morro closed her eyes.

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Tool does not answer.”

“No.”

He took a bite.

“Good.”

No further briefing.

The sandwich remained sandwich.

At 1:00 p.m., the hearing reached religious institutional witnesses.

Crowe requested not to watch.

Then requested to watch.

Then requested to watch with camera off.

Morro approved the third.

The first witness was a denominational risk officer who repeatedly used the word **pastoral** as if it were a fire blanket.

Pastoral process.

Pastoral care.

Pastoral response.

Pastoral discretion.

Morro wrote **PASTORAL IS NOT A PERMIT** on her pad, then asked Crowe by text:

Public?

Crowe replied:

Yes. Adult risk.

The hearing chair eventually asked, “Did pastoral discretion include decisions not to notify civil authorities?”

The witness said, “In certain cases, we sought to avoid unnecessary escalation.”

The room chilled.

The chair asked, “Escalation for whom?”

The witness did not answer well.

Good.

The second witness, a restorative-practice consultant, did better.

She admitted that many institutions had used restorative language without survivor control or independent safeguards. She said, plainly, that restorative process should never be offered by the institution that benefits from the person’s participation unless external controls exist.

“Useful.”

Crowe messaged:

She is trying correctly.

Morro replied:

Documented.

The public update read simply:

Pastoral, restorative, therapeutic, educational, or family language does not replace mandatory reporting, independent representation, non-retaliation, record preservation, or lawful process. Care language is not a permit.

Baren saw only the safe version because Prayer Adults were in the air again.

“Care words do not make rules go away,” Lila said.

He nodded.

“Adults love words.”

“Yes.”

“Morro loves rules.”

“Yes.”

Morro called from the lounge, “Rules are words with consequences.”

Baren considered.

“That is good.”

Morro stood very still.

“Public?”

“Adult room.”

“Accepted.”

The task force received:

Rules are words with consequences. Care words without consequences can become cover.

Crowe replied:

Amen—

Then deleted it.

Morro still saw the typing indicator and texted:

I sensed that.

At 2:30, Mara arrived for puzzle visit early because the newsroom had sent her out after she referred to a source as “a man-shaped conflict disclosure.”

She claimed she was fine.

No one believed her.

Baren looked at her across the cow puzzle.

“You have source face.”

“I might.”

“Work face.”

“Yes.”

“No work.”

“I know.”

“Trust fact?”

“No fact today.”

“Good.”

They looked at the puzzle.

One piece in box.

Sky gap.

Baren asked, “Do you want to put it in?”

Mara looked surprised.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

“Are you sure?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

He smiled.

“Good answer.”

She did not touch the piece.

Instead they sorted the box even though only one piece was inside.

This was absurd and calming.

Mara said, "This is the easiest sorting task I have ever done."

Baren said, "You still look stressed."

"I overperform."

"Trying Adult."

"Yes."

"Useful now?"

"Trying."

"Not useful trying?"

"Trying trying."

He nodded.

"Good."

After ten minutes, he picked up the last piece and handed it to her.

She held it.

Did not place it.

He watched.

"You can keep holding it."

Mara held it for one full minute.

Then put it back in the box.

Baren nodded.

"Good."

Mara understood.

Some people could be trusted not because they completed the thing, but because they could hold the piece without deciding where it belonged.

No one said that aloud.

Morro, from the lounge, looked near death from unspoken usefulness.

Lila took pity on her and whispered, "Private."

Morro nodded once.

At 4:00 p.m., the hearing ended its second day with a procedural dispute.

A lawmaker wanted to subpoena protected clinical records.

Morro's face changed in a way that made the task-force call go silent.

The hearing chair denied the request.

The lawmaker argued public oversight.

The chair said, "Oversight of adult systems does not require clinical invasion of protected minors."

Morro said, "Good."

The lawmaker insisted that records might show institutional failures.

The chair replied, "Then subpoena institutional records."

Excellent chair.

Morro wrote:

SUBPOENA THE ADULT SYSTEM, NOT THE CHILD'S HEALING.

She looked at Lila.

"Public?"

Lila nodded.

Baren was asked because the principle came close to him.

He listened to the safe explanation.

"Someone wanted private child care records. The chair said no and told them to look at adult systems."

Baren's face tightened.

"Good."

"May we use a general principle?"

"Yes."

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

Oversight should seek adult-system records before protected clinical or personal records. A child's healing file is not the index to adult failure.

Morro approved.

Baren reviewed it.

"Good."

Then added, "Healing is not table of contents."

Morro looked like a person seeing lightning strike a filing cabinet.

Baren pointed.

"Ask."

"May we use that?"

He thought longer.

"No. Mine."

"Accepted."

The room held it.

At 5:00, Serena canceled again.

Therapy.

Good.

Baren approved.

"Therapy twice?"

“Yes.”

“Good.”

“Do you want to send anything?”

“No. Yesterday enough.”

“Okay.”

He paused.

“Actually: still good therapy. no response.”

Lila sent it.

Serena replied through counsel:

Received. No response.

Mutual boundaries.

Growing.

Not complete.

Good.

Chronald sent nothing.

Campaign gone.

Hospital gone.

Not Baren.

Good.

At dinner, Baren asked if adults could be boring on purpose.

Morro said, “Yes.”

“Are you?”

“Yes.”

“Were you always?”

“No.”

“What were you before?”

Morro considered.

“Tired and precise.”

“That sounds same.”

Lila laughed.

Morro said, “Precision without purpose can become vanity.”

Crowe, on video, whispered, “Oh.”

Baren looked at her.

“Were you a Vanity Adult?”

Morro froze.

The room froze harder.

Then Morro said, “Yes.”

Lila looked at her.

Morro continued.

“Sometimes. Maybe often.”

Baren considered this with the seriousness of a court that had no interest in flattering anyone.

“Trying Adult?”

“Yes.”

“Useful now?”

“I hope so.”

“Still watched.”

“Certainly.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Morro accepted the category.

Later, in the lounge, she wrote nothing.

That was how everyone knew it mattered.

Night came with the cow puzzle still missing one piece.

The piece in the box.

The sky gap.

The octopus fact remained on the floor.

The parrotfish fact remained under the shark.

The breakfast card stayed on the side table.

The drawer was checked once.

Still there.

Closed.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in the lounge, recently categorized and not dead from it.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can adults be useful without being done?”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Can I?”

“You do not have to be useful.”

He smiled faintly.

“Good catch.”

Cole said from outside, “True yes.”

Baren closed his eyes.

“The piece can fit.”

“Yes.”

“Does not have to stay.”

“No.”

“Adults can learn that.”

“They are trying.”

“Trying means useful now.”

“Yes.”

“Not sad now.”

“Useful first.”

“Yes.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, hearings continued.

Elsewhere, indictments were fought.

Elsewhere, campaigns died without music.

Elsewhere, walls moved.

Here, the piece remained in the box, not because the puzzle could not be finished, but because finishing had finally stopped being the only way adults recognized meaning.

And for once, no one tried to prove the lesson by taking it from him.

CHAPTER SIXTY-TWO

Useful First

Morro objected to useful first on legal grounds.

Not because it was wrong.

Because it was imprecise in ways that made her teeth feel procedural.

Useful first.

Useful before sad.

Useful before apology.

Useful before public grief.

Useful before beautiful language.

Useful before being forgiven.

Useful before being understood.

Useful before being centered in one’s own remorse.

Useful before becoming the kind of adult who spoke softly in panels about lessons learned while the people harmed by those lessons sat somewhere else, still paying for therapy, rent, lawyers, bus fare, and good mop heads.

The phrase had begun with Baren talking to Crowe.

Then it moved to Mara.

Then Morro.

Then, because adults were porous under pressure, it entered the task force as a private shorthand before anyone meant for it to.

A prosecutor said, "We need useful first from cooperating witnesses."

A labor attorney said, "Useful first means supplies and schedules before gratitude statements."

Dr. Rao said, "Useful first means support before participation."

Mara's editor said, "Useful first means records before essays."

Crowe said, "Useful first means repentance can begin without an audience."

Morro listened to all of this on the morning call and finally said, "Stop using a child's phrase as operational language without making it adult-owned."

The call went quiet.

Good quiet.

Convicted quiet.

Lila looked at her from across the consult room.

Morro continued.

"The concept is sound. The source remains protected. Translate."

So they translated.

The professional version became:

Corrective action should precede emotional positioning.

Everyone hated it.

"Excellent. No one will put that on a mug."

The task force adopted it.

Corrective action before emotional positioning.

Records before remorse narratives.

Witness protection before praise.

Compensation before advisory labor.

Independent review before public trust statements.

Resignation before healing tours.

Reporting before listening circles.

Tools before worker bravery.

Adult systems before child reactions.

The phrase lost charm.

Good.

Charm was how concepts escaped their fences.

Baren never heard the translation until later, and when he did, he made a face.

“That sounds like a chair with no cushion.”

Morro said, “Exactly.”

“Good.”

The oversight hearing’s third day began with money.

Money made people less poetic.

This improved the hearing.

The first witness was a foundation accountant who had once believed her greatest career danger was donor gala seating.

Now she explained how funds moved through ethics initiatives, family privacy grants, youth leadership programs, pastoral repair retreats, child-centered resilience pilots, and emergency discretion accounts.

The names were soft.

The invoices were not.

Travel.

Consultants.

Media analytics.

Clinical language review.

Security.

Private transport.

Records storage.

Birthday instrument drafting.

Witness relocation contingency.

Labor “transition support.”

That last one caused the labor counsel to lean forward.

“Transition from what?” the hearing chair asked.

The accountant looked at the page.

“Employment risk.”

The chair said, “Risk to whom?”

The accountant swallowed.

“Workers who had access to sensitive rooms.”

Morro, watching from the consult room, said, “There it is.”

Mara typed in the newsroom.

Money remembers differently than paper.

She stared at the sentence.

Too good?

She sent it to Morro.

Morro replied:

Adult concept. Body.

The article later read:

Money remembers differently than paper: invoices and account codes can reveal the operational choices behind language like privacy, repair, discretion, and youth leadership.

No child.

Adult records.

Adult mechanisms.

Useful first.

The accountant was not heroic.

She was useful.

That mattered more.

Baren did not watch the money hearing.

He learned about money in math instead.

Ms. Rowe brought coins.

Pennies.

Nickels.

Dimes.

Quarters.

Fake bills printed for school use.

Baren distrusted the fake bills immediately.

“They feel like lies.”

“They are teaching money,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Still lies.”

“They are labeled.”

He inspected one.

PLAY MONEY

“Okay. Receipts.”

They practiced making change.

Twenty-five cents.

Fifty cents.

Seventy-five cents.

A dollar.

Decimals returned wearing coins now.

Baren tolerated this because quarters were useful and nickels looked stubborn.

He solved four problems.

Then asked, “Can money be evidence?”

Lila looked up.

“Yes.”

“Can money lie?”

Morro, from the doorway, said, “Money lies by telling the truth about what someone valued.”

Baren stared.

“That is too good.”

Morro froze.

Baren pointed.

“Yours. Adult.”

Morro looked almost embarrassed.

“May it be public?”

“Yes. Adult money.”

The hearing explainer gained a line:

Financial records may not tell the whole story, but they often show what institutions valued enough to fund, hide, rename, or repeat.

Baren read the safer version later.

“You made it less good.”

“Yes,” Morro said.

“Good.”

At noon, the hearing turned to compensation.

Former-minor advisory participants had demanded clarity: if adults wanted their expertise, adults should pay for expertise without buying pain.

The foundation witnesses struggled.

A youth leadership director said, “We believed offering platform and voice was itself valuable.”

The hearing chair asked, “Valuable to whom?”

The director said, “To participants.”

“Were they paid?”

“Not generally.”

“Were adult facilitators paid?”

“Yes.”

“Consultants?”

“Yes.”

“Attorneys?”

“Yes.”

“Security?”

“Yes.”

“Venue?”

“Yes.”

“Caterers?”

“Yes.”

“Children?”

The director paused.

The pause did more than the answer.

Morro wrote:

EVERYONE PAID BUT THE CHILDREN WHO MADE THE ROOM MORAL

Then stared at it.

Too sharp.

Too public?

She looked at Lila.

Lila shook her head.

“Adult concept, but dangerous.”

The public version became:

Institutions should examine whether youth participation is being treated as moral value while adult professional participation is treated as paid labor.

Baren later reviewed the safe version.

“Adults got paid and kids got platform?”

“Yes.”

“Platform is not lunch.”

Morro’s eyes lit.

Baren sighed.

“Yes. Public. Adults need that.”

The advisory desk added:

Platform is not lunch. Visibility, leadership titles, gratitude, access, or symbolic honor should not substitute for compensation, support, transportation, meals, legal protections, or safe refusal when youth or former minors provide work or expertise.

Rosa’s counsel sent back:

Correct again. Also overtime.

Updated.

Baren approved.

“Rosa should run labor.”

Morro said, “She may already.”

At 1:30, Mara visited with no trust fact.

Baren looked at her.

“No fact again?”

“No fact.”

“You saving them?”

“Trying not to make facts into obligation.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The cow puzzle remained unfinished by one piece. The piece waited in the box.

Mara sat.

Baren said, “Today you can hold it again.”

Mara picked up the sky piece.

It was small in her palm.

Strange how small things could carry so much adult restraint.

She held it.

Baren watched.

“You want to put it in?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because gaps bother me.”

“Why?”

Mara smiled sadly.

“Because I built a life finding patterns and closing them.”

“Did that help?”

“Sometimes.”

“Did it hurt?”

“Yes.”

“Can you not close this one?”

“Yes.”

“Useful now.”

She nodded.

“Useful now.”

She held the piece for another minute, then placed it back in the box.

Baren approved.

“Trying Adult.”

Mara accepted the category.

Not absolution.

Map.

Then they discussed whether cows knew about money.

Mara said no.

Baren said cows understood value better than donors because cows valued grass honestly.

Morro, in the lounge, whispered, “I am dying.”

Lila whispered back, “Privately.”

Morro suffered in silence.

At 2:30, Victor Elysium’s motion produced the first public misunderstanding of due process.

Supporters said the motion proved the case was weak.

Critics said allowing the motion proved the courts were protecting him.

Influencers asked why a man accused of building systems that harmed children got to argue technical distinctions.

Morro read the thread and muttered, “Because civilization is not a revenge app.”

Mara asked, “Public?”

“No.”

“Please?”

“No.”

The public legal explainer said:

A defendant’s ability to challenge charges is not a sign that the allegations are false or that courts are protecting the defendant. It is part of the process required before punishment. The same procedural rules that make prosecution harder also protect witnesses, victims, children, workers, and the public from power without proof.

Baren saw the safe version.

“Adults prove adult.”

“Yes.”

“Even Data Adult.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Then he asked, “Can rules be useful first?”

Morro looked at him.

“Yes.”

“Then rules are Trying Adults?”

“No,” Morro said quickly.

Baren smiled.

“Rules are words with consequences.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

At 3:30, the task force moved to international coordination.

London.

Not as a scandal destination.

As paperwork.

The British solicitors had already issued phrases like **safeguarding review, historic advisory arrangements**, and **confidential family resolution practices**.

Morro requested plain descriptions.

They sent longer phrases.

Morro sent back:

Who met, who paid, who decided, who was affected, who objected, who has records?

The solicitor replied:

We are determining the relevant scope.

Morro replied:

That is scope.

The call was scheduled for the next day.

Baren was not told.

He was in the courtyard with Cole and the sad maple.

The sad maple had dropped another leaf.

Baren ignored it.

The leaf remained on the ground.

This seemed to bother Cole.

Baren noticed.

“You want to pick it up.”

Cole said, “Maybe.”

“Why?”

“Habit.”

“Protector habit?”

“Maybe.”

“Leave it.”

Cole left it.

The leaf stayed where it landed.

Useful now, for Cole, meant not fixing the harmless thing.

He did not say that.

Good.

At 4:00, Serena visited.

She brought nothing.

Baren asked if therapy was boring.

Serena thought.

“Sometimes.”

“Good.”

“Good?”

“If it is too interesting, adults might make it content.”

Serena smiled.

“Mine is not content.”

“Good.”

He asked, “Did you talk about me?”

“Yes.”

He stiffened.

She added quickly, “Not your details. My choices. My guilt. My boundaries. What not to bring to you.”

He relaxed slightly.

“Useful?”

“Yes.”

“Sad?”

“Yes.”

“Useful first?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good therapy.”

The timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

“Okay.”

No extra.

No repair request.

Trying Adult.

Still watched.

Useful first.

At 5:30, Chronald sent another nothing.

This one came through Bex:

No update requested. Records production continues.

Lila did not tell Baren because he had not asked.

Morro read the notice and said, "Bex may survive herself."

Mara, on secure chat, asked, "Public?"

"No."

Bex remained a category under review.

Campaign Adult.

Late Adult.

Records.

Still watched.

Maybe useful.

Not absolution.

Map.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment returned.

Baren chose it because the day had involved money, hearings, and adult utility, though he did not know most of that.

Sometimes the body knew to choose boring.

He ate half.

Stopped.

No reason.

No interrogation.

Nurse Imani cleared.

After dinner, Baren asked if he was useful.

The room went still in the wrong way.

Lila moved first.

"You do not have to be useful."

"I know."

"Then why ask?"

He looked toward the cow puzzle.

"Everyone says useful first."

Morro closed her eyes.

There it was.

Leakage.

Even protected language could make pressure if adults let it float.

Morro came into the room and sat across from him.

“Useful first is for adults who caused, enabled, ignored, profited from, or are now responsible for correcting harm. It is not for you.”

Baren listened.

Lila added, “Children do not have to become useful to justify protection.”

Nurse Imani said, “You can be useless all day and still get dinner.”

Cole said, “Preferred sometimes.”

Baren smiled faintly.

Morro continued, “We translated the adult version so it would not land on you. If it did, that is our error.”

He nodded.

“Corrected?”

“Yes.”

“Receipts?”

Morro turned to the whiteboard and wrote:

USEFUL FIRST IS FOR RESPONSIBLE ADULTS.CHILDREN DO NOT OWE USEFULNESS.

Baren read it.

“Good.”

“Public?”

He thought.

“Yes. Other kids.”

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

Corrective action duties belong to responsible adults and institutions. Children and harmed people do not owe usefulness, participation, teachability, forgiveness, leadership, testimony, gratitude, or visible improvement in order to receive protection.

Morro approved.

Baren reviewed it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Too many words, but good.”

The correction mattered.

Adults had almost made another room with a better phrase.

They caught it.

Late.

That night, Baren opened the drawer.

One check.

Everything still there.

He added nothing.

He looked at the side table.

Ocean fact.

Shark drawing.

Breakfast card.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish fact under shark.

No new useful-first card.

Good.

He looked at the cow puzzle.

Piece in box.

Gap in sky.

Mara had held it and not placed it.

Good.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, rewriting the task-force internal language to remove any phrase that could accidentally make children feel responsible for being useful.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can I be useless tomorrow?"

Lila smiled.

"Yes."

"Can adults still do work?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Cole said from the hallway, "I support uselessness."

Morro called from the lounge, "Do not make it a movement."

Baren laughed.

Small.

Sleepy.

Unkept.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, money testified.

Elsewhere, defendants argued.

Elsewhere, hearings corrected agendas and adults tried to sound less guilty.

Here, the most important correction of the day was not in court.

It was on a whiteboard where a child could see it:

CHILDREN DO NOT OWE USEFULNESS.

By morning, Morro would erase it from the room and leave it in the guidance where adults could carry it.

Baren did not need to wake under that sentence forever.

He only needed it long enough to know the duty was not his.

CHAPTER SIXTY-THREE

The Useless Day

Baren woke determined to be useless.

He announced it before breakfast.

Not dramatically.

Dramatic uselessness would have defeated the point.

He opened his eyes, saw the half-open door, heard Cole shift in the chair outside, watched the ceiling remain uninterested in him, and said, "Today I am being useless."

Cole replied, "Strong plan."

Nurse Imani knocked.

"Come in."

She entered with the schedule.

Baren pointed at it from bed.

"Does it allow useless?"

Nurse Imani reviewed the paper with professional seriousness.

"Breakfast, reading, math optional, courtyard, puzzle, visit optional, no public obligations."

"Math optional?"

"Ms. Rowe said the unfinished decimal can wait if you want."

Baren nodded.

"Good. Useless compatible."

Morro appeared in the doorway holding coffee and suspicion.

"Define useless."

Baren sat up.

"No guidance. No categories. No helping adults understand things. No making good sentences. No reviewing public language unless it is about me directly. No useful first."

Morro's face changed.

Not offended.

Corrected.

“Accepted.”

Lila entered behind her, heard the list, and placed her folder face down without looking theatrical about it.

“Accepted,” she said.

Baren looked at Cole.

Cole lifted his cup.

“I support uselessness.”

Morro said, “Do not make it a movement.”

Baren pointed.

“That joke is yesterday.”

Morro lowered the coffee.

“Withdrawn.”

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No record.

No standard.

No doctrine.

Baren ate slowly, enjoying how little the cereal improved society.

The adult world objected immediately.

Not personally.

Structurally.

At 8:40 a.m., the task force needed clarification on whether former-minor advisory payments should be categorized as consulting fees, participant support, expert compensation, restorative planning honoraria, or witness-adjacent stipends.

Morro read the email in the consult room.

“Witness-adjacent stipends.”

Lila, beside her, said, “No.”

“Correct.”

Morro drafted:

Compensation should be plain, accurate, and non-coercive. Do not disguise advisory labor as gratitude, healing support, honoraria, or witness-adjacent anything. If former minors or youth provide expertise, call it paid advisory work unless counsel identifies a specific legal reason otherwise.

She stopped before sending.

Looked toward Baren’s hallway.

Useful first was for adults.

This was adult work.

She sent it.

No child review.

At 9:10, a foundation counsel asked whether an apology archive could include anonymized quotes from youth participants if all names were removed.

Morro replied:

Not without consent, context, independent review, and a reason that benefits the speaker rather than the institution. Anonymized extraction is still extraction.

She stopped again.

That line was good.

Too good.

Adult concept.

She sent it to the task force.

Not to Baren.

At 9:30, a media outlet asked Mara whether the protected minor had “inspired” the new hearing protocols.

Mara replied through counsel:

No comment on protected minor. The protocols arise from court orders, adult records, former-minor advisors, worker-witness input, clinical experts, and legal process.

Morro saw the response and approved.

The adult world kept trying to tug the line back to the child.

Adults kept cutting it.

That was useful.

Baren was busy being useless by reading a cereal maze and refusing to solve it because “the cereal company wants engagement.”

Cole said, “Wise.”

Morro did not ask to use that.

Growth.

Reading became non-reading.

Ms. Rowe arrived with books.

Ocean.

Dinosaurs.

Space.

Baren looked at all three.

“No.”

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“Okay.”

“Is that allowed?”

“Yes.”

“What happens?”

“We can do quiet reading later. Or I can read and you can ignore me. Or we can skip reading today.”

Baren looked suspicious.

“Skip?”

“Yes.”

“Will school explode?”

“No.”

“Will adults write concern?”

“No. I will note that reading was offered and declined without distress.”

“That sounds like school progress.”

“It is.”

“Not life progress?”

“Not life progress.”

He considered.

“Okay. You can note declined.”

Ms. Rowe wrote:

Reading offered. Declined without distress.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Then he picked up the dinosaur book and looked at pictures only.

Ms. Rowe did not say this was still reading-adjacent.

Morro, in the doorway, did not say anything at all.

Heroic restraint had matured into actual restraint.

Mostly.

At 10:00 a.m., the oversight hearing began its fourth day.

Technology witnesses.

Victor Elysium was not testifying.

His lawyers would have combusted.

Instead, independent technologists, platform auditors, data ethicists, and one extremely irritated product safety researcher explained how engagement tools could become harm accelerators without any machine becoming magical.

One witness said, “The system did not need to predict truth. It needed to predict traction.”

Morro wrote that down.

Adult concept.

Public.

Mara's newsroom used it in the explainer.

Another witness said, "Risk scores often become permission slips when executives want them to."

Morro approved that too.

A lawmaker asked whether algorithms had brainwashed the public.

The product safety researcher sighed into the microphone.

"No. They gave interested adults a faster way to find and feed existing appetites."

Morro stood.

"Excellent."

Crowe, watching remotely, messaged:

Appetite language. May I?

Morro replied:

No sermon. But yes.

The public guidance desk issued:

Technology did not need to create public appetite to be dangerous. Records suggest that adults used analytics to identify, measure, and feed existing appetite for child-centered meaning, institutional repair, and delayed public revelation. Responsibility remains with the adults who built, bought, configured, and obeyed those systems.

Baren was not told.

He had declined reading and was now inspecting the cow puzzle box.

The piece remained inside.

Useless.

Both, apparently, could coexist if adults stopped grabbing.

At 11:00, Baren did something dangerously ordinary.

He got bored.

Not tragic bored.

Not isolated bored.

Not trauma-response bored.

Just bored.

He lay sideways on the common room couch and said, "This is boring."

Every adult in the room experienced a different professional emergency.

Nurse Imani recovered first.

"Good."

Baren looked at her.

"Good?"

"Yes."

"What do I do?"

“Be bored.”

“For how long?”

“Until you are not.”

“That sounds fake.”

“It is real.”

Cole said, “Boredom is hard.”

Baren nodded.

“Harder than decimals?”

“Different.”

Morro entered, saw the couch posture, and stopped.

“What is happening?”

“Boredom,” Nurse Imani said.

Morro assessed the situation like a jurisdictional puzzle.

“Any distress?”

“No.”

“Any safety issue?”

“No.”

“Any intervention required?”

“No.”

“Proceed.”

Baren looked at her.

“Boredom has permission?”

“No. Boredom does not require permission.”

He narrowed his eyes.

“That is almost useful.”

Morro froze.

He smiled faintly.

“But today no.”

She nodded.

“Today no.”

He stayed bored for eleven minutes.

No one fixed it.

Then he got up and sharpened the ordinary pencil.

Not because he needed it.

Because sharpening a pencil was something to do.

The pencil became sharper.

The day did not become evidence.

At noon, lunch was soup.

Baren chose it because uselessness apparently required accepting shiny disappointment.

He ate three spoonfuls and stopped.

Nurse Imani cleared the bowl.

No questions.

Cole looked at the bowl as it left.

“Soup remains suspicious.”

Baren nodded.

“True yes.”

Morro opened her mouth.

Closed it.

After lunch, Lila asked whether he wanted a visit with Serena later if she requested one.

“No.”

“Do you want to give a reason?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

The message went out:

Baren declines a visit today. No reason provided. No response requested.

Serena replied:

Received. No response.

Baren asked if she answered right.

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Then he resumed being useless by lying on the floor and looking under the couch.

“What is under there?” Cole asked.

“Dust and one green thing.”

Nurse Imani investigated.

The green thing was a puzzle piece from a different puzzle.

Not cow.

Not lighthouse.

Unknown.

This could have become a whole situation.

Baren picked it up.

Looked at it.

Put it in the trash.

“Not ours.”

Morro looked like she wanted to applaud due process.

She did not.

At 1:30, Mara arrived and was informed it was Useless Day.

She accepted this faster than expected.

“No facts?” she asked.

“No facts,” Baren said.

“No puzzle?”

“Maybe no.”

“No work?”

“No.”

“Can I sit?”

“Yes.”

They sat.

For six minutes.

No talking.

Mara had not known how loud her own usefulness was until she tried to leave it outside.

Her hands wanted a notebook.

Her eyes wanted pattern.

Her mind wanted to turn silence into structure.

Baren looked at her.

“You are bad at useless.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because if I am not useful, I have to just be there.”

“That is the point.”

“I suspected.”

He looked toward the cow puzzle.

“You can hold the piece if you want.”

“Would that be useful?”

“No. Today it is just holding.”

Mara picked up the piece.

Held it.

No lesson.

No trust exercise.

No metaphor.

Just cardboard.

After a while, Baren said, "Okay."

She put it back.

He nodded.

Mara left after ten minutes.

In the hallway, she cried once.

Quietly.

Not because something had happened.

Because nothing had.

No one wrote it down.

At 2:00, the task force almost used Baren again by accident.

A draft public bulletin included the phrase:

The protected minor's case has taught institutions—

Morro stopped reading.

"No."

The drafting attorney looked confused.

"It is anonymized."

"It still makes him teacher."

The attorney nodded slowly.

Morro dictated:

Recent court orders, adult records, former-minor advisors, worker-witnesses, clinicians, and investigators have clarified institutional duties—

"Better," Lila said.

Morro looked at the attorney.

"Do not make a child the source of adult education because you like narrative compression."

The attorney wrote that down.

Morro said, "Do not write that down for public use."

Too late.

Private training gained:

Narrative compression often relocates adult responsibility onto the most compelling child. Resist.

Adult concept.

Internal.

Not Baren.

At 3:00, courtyard.

Baren declined.

No reason.

Accepted.

At 3:30, math.

Declined.

No reason.

Accepted.

At 4:00, ocean video.

Declined.

No reason.

Accepted.

At 4:15, Baren sat by the window and watched nothing in particular.

Lila sat nearby.

Not too near.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in consult room dismantling adult euphemisms with a red pen.

Baren said, "Useless is hard."

Lila nodded.

"Yes."

"Because adults wait."

"Yes."

"For what?"

"For a sign you are okay."

He thought.

"What if okay is not doing signs?"

"Then adults should learn that."

He looked at her.

"That is useful."

"Yes."

"Not today."

"Not today."

He leaned against the chair.

"Can okay be private?"

"Yes."

“Good.”

No guidance.

No public.

No adult room.

Just answer.

At 5:00, the hearing produced a moment the public wanted to turn into a clip.

A data ethicist told a lawmaker:

“You keep asking whether the tool predicted behavior. The better question is why adults wanted children’s behavior to be predictable.”

The room went silent.

Public clip.

Adult witness.

Adult issue.

Mara’s newsroom used it, carefully.

No Baren.

No child reaction.

No symbolic footage.

The clip traveled.

Fine.

Some sentences could travel because adults had said them in adult rooms about adult responsibility.

That was the new rule.

Baren was eating grilled cheese and did not care.

At 6:30, dinner.

Macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

He ate most of it.

This surprised him.

“Macaroni improved.”

Nurse Imani said, “Or you were hungry.”

“Both can be true.”

Morro looked up.

Baren pointed.

“Old sentence. Already private.”

She lowered her pen.

After dinner, he asked, “Did I help today?”

Lila answered, “No.”

He smiled.

“Good.”

Morro added, “Adults still worked.”

“Good.”

“Without you.”

“Good.”

“Some did badly.”

“Normal.”

“Some corrected.”

“Good.”

“Some will need review tomorrow.”

“Adults always need review tomorrow.”

Morro almost wrote it down.

Almost.

Night arrived.

No drawer check.

Then Baren changed his mind.

One drawer check.

Everything still there.

No addition.

Side table unchanged.

Cow piece in box.

Octopus card still on floor.

Green unknown puzzle piece gone to trash and not mourned.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Lila nearby.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in lounge, quietly removing the protected minor from every sentence where adult laziness had placed him.

Before sleep, Baren said, “Useless Day can end.”

“Okay,” Lila said.

“Do not keep it.”

“I won’t.”

He looked toward the lounge.

“Morro.”

Morro appeared.

“I won’t,” she said.

“Even privately?”

Morro hesitated.

Then said, “I will remember the instruction, not preserve the day.”

Baren considered.

“Accepted.”

He turned onto his side.

“Tomorrow I might be medium useful.”

Cole said, “Ambitious.”

“Medium.”

“True medium.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, adult systems learned that technology did not need magic when appetite was enough.

Elsewhere, hearings asked why adults wanted children predictable.

Elsewhere, public bulletins were corrected before they made a child into a teacher.

Here, Useless Day ended without being kept.

And because it was not preserved, it remained exactly what Baren had asked it to be:

his.

CHAPTER SIXTY-FOUR

Medium Useful

Medium useful began with eggs.

This was not planned.

Planning medium usefulness would have made it large useful, and Baren had been clear that he was not ready for that kind of institutional creep.

He woke at 7:09 a.m., door half open, Cole outside, Nurse Imani at the desk, Lila nearby, Morro somewhere in the lounge already correcting adult language with the soft violence of a red pen.

Baren sat up.

“Today I might be medium useful.”

Cole opened one eye.

“Scale?”

“Not useless. Not useful first. Medium.”

“Examples?”

Baren thought.

"I can answer things if they are already mine. I can help with school. I can say no. I can maybe review one sentence if adults are about to mess it up."

Nurse Imani knocked.

"Come in."

She entered with the schedule.

"Breakfast?"

"Eggs."

Everyone reacted too much.

Baren noticed.

"Eggs are allowed."

"Yes," Nurse Imani said quickly.

"Scrambled. Not shiny."

"Understood."

Morro appeared in the doorway with coffee.

"Medium useful permits eggs?"

"Yes."

"Noted."

Baren looked at her.

Morro corrected herself.

"Remembered temporarily."

"Better."

Eggs arrived.

Scrambled.

Not shiny.

Toast on the side, edges removed without ceremony.

Baren ate four bites of eggs and half the toast.

Then stopped.

"Medium."

Nurse Imani cleared the plate.

No one asked whether the eggs meant progress.

Eggs meant eggs.

Medium useful was already working.

The adult world, regrettably, had no medium setting.

At 8:30 a.m., the oversight hearing entered its fifth day, and the witness table filled with people whose job titles sounded like a fog machine had learned compliance.

Senior Vice President for Trust Initiatives.

Director of Youth-Centered Engagement.

Chief Continuity Counsel.

Restorative Process Liaison.

Deputy Ethics Strategist.

Morro read the witness list and said, "Every title is a hiding place."

Crowe, remote, whispered, "Public?"

"No. Too sweeping."

"Internal?"

"Yes."

Mara, in the newsroom, wrote it in her private notes anyway.

The first witness, the Director of Youth-Centered Engagement, said her institution believed in empowering young people to participate in decisions affecting them.

The hearing chair asked, "Could young people decline participation without consequence?"

The director said, "We encouraged full engagement."

The chair repeated, "Could they decline?"

The director said, "We viewed reluctance as part of the engagement journey."

Morro stood.

Lila closed her eyes.

Mara typed.

The chair leaned forward.

"Reluctance is not consent in transit."

The room went silent.

Morro pointed at the screen.

"Public."

Mara's newsroom used it within the hour:

A hearing chair challenged testimony that youth reluctance was treated as part of an "engagement journey," stating that reluctance is not consent in transit.

The phrase traveled.

Adult said.

Adult room.

Adult responsibility.

Allowed.

Baren did not hear it.

He was doing school reading.

Medium useful did not include absorbing every adult sentence that finally learned how to behave.

School reading returned to dinosaurs.

Ms. Rowe brought the feathered dinosaur book and a short article about paleontologists revising old assumptions.

Baren accepted reading.

Medium useful.

He read two paragraphs aloud.

Corrected **hypothesis** on the third try.

Then asked, "What if adults like old wrong better?"

Ms. Rowe said, "That happens."

"Do they keep wrong?"

"Sometimes."

"Because changing picture is hard."

"Yes."

He looked at Lila.

"That was yesterday."

"Yes."

"Still true."

"Yes."

He looked toward the doorway.

Morro was there but pretending not to be.

"You can use school version again."

Morro nodded.

"Thank you."

Ms. Rowe added to the learning note:

Student connected revised scientific models to evidence-based correction.

Baren read it.

"That sounds like I did more than I did."

Ms. Rowe crossed it out and wrote:

We talked about changing old pictures when better evidence arrives.

Baren approved.

"Better."

Morro also approved, though with less joy because precision had lost a decoration.

At 10:00 a.m., the task force received the first confirmed international match.

London was not only paperwork.

A private educational foundation had hosted “family resolution panels” involving minors connected to donor families, school misconduct allegations, and reputation-managed restorative meetings.

One record included the phrase:

student voice environment prepared in advance

Morro read it aloud.

“No.”

Dr. Rao said, “Prepared voice environment means scripted safety.”

Crowe said, “A room that rehearses listening.”

Morro said, “Both are public if translated.”

Lila drafted:

A youth or student voice process is not independent merely because a young person is invited to speak. Safeguards must address who prepares the room, who frames the issue, who controls records, who selected facilitators, whether participation is voluntary and revocable, and whether refusal ends the process.

Mara published the international development carefully.

No names yet.

No minors.

Mechanisms.

Headline:

Investigators Review Similar Private Governance Practices in U.K.-Linked Educational Foundation

Dry enough to protect.

Specific enough to matter.

Baren was not told about London.

He was examining a fossil footprint and deciding whether the dinosaur had been “walking regular or walking with agenda.”

Ms. Rowe said scientists could not know.

Baren liked that.

“No agenda unless receipts.”

“Correct.”

Morro inhaled from the doorway.

Baren said, “Medium useful says no.”

Morro exhaled.

“Accepted.”

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole said nothing.

Baren looked at him.

“Allowed one.”

Cole shook his head.

“Saving it.”

“For what?”

“Unknown geometry.”

Baren nodded.

“Strategic.”

Morro said, “Do not militarize sandwiches.”

Cole said, “Too late.”

Baren smiled.

Lunch remained lunch.

Then Lila asked whether he wanted an adult update.

“Any adult caught?”

“No new arrests.”

“Any wall moved?”

“Some international adult rooms are being reviewed.”

He paused.

“Ocean rooms?”

“Across an ocean, yes.”

“Is that why adults had ocean face?”

Lila smiled sadly.

“Maybe.”

“Still not mine?”

“Still not yours.”

“Good.”

He ate.

“Medium useful question: do other countries have Morros?”

Morro, from the lounge, said, “Insufficient evidence.”

Baren nodded.

“Concern.”

“Agreed.”

At 1:00 p.m., the hearing produced the first genuinely useful apology.

It came from an unexpected person: the former operations manager of a youth leadership foundation.

She did not cry.

She did not ask to meet anyone.

She did not say healing.

She did not say journey.

She brought spreadsheets.

“I approved transportation reimbursements only for youth who agreed to attend full-day sessions,” she said. “That meant youth who chose not to participate did not get reimbursed for travel already undertaken. At the time, I treated it as attendance policy. I now understand it functioned as pressure.”

The hearing chair asked, “What did you do when you realized that?”

“I preserved the reimbursement records, notified counsel, and recommended repayment with interest to all affected participants, including those who did not complete sessions.”

“Useful first.”

Then caught herself.

“Corrective action before emotional positioning.”

Lila smiled.

The operations manager continued:

“I am not asking affected people to view that as repair. It is a debt calculation.”

Morro stood again.

“Excellent.”

Mara’s newsroom used the exchange.

Headline:

Hearing Witness Identifies Travel Reimbursement Rules as Participation Pressure

Not exciting.

Good.

Baren later received a safe summary because the principle touched youth participation.

“An adult realized money rules pressured young people to stay in meetings and recommended paying them back.”

Baren nodded.

“Money made the room sticky.”

Lila looked at Morro.

Morro asked, “May we use that?”

Baren thought.

“Yes. Adult money.”

The compensation advisory gained:

Funding rules can make a room sticky. Travel reimbursement, meals, stipends, scholarships, access, grades, recommendations, or housing support should not depend on a child or former minor completing a process they must be free to leave.

Morro approved.

Baren read it.

“Good. Sticky is clear.”

“Very.”

“Do not make stickers.”

“No stickers.”

At 2:00 p.m., Mara arrived with one trust fact.

Baren had allowed facts again under medium useful rules.

Mara sat across from him at the cow puzzle.

“Ready?”

“Maybe.”

“Some whales have regional songs that change over time.”

Baren narrowed his eyes.

“Receipts?”

“Trust fact.”

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

He thought.

“Whales get new songs?”

“Yes.”

“Do old whales get mad?”

“I do not know.”

“Good.”

Morro whispered from the lounge, “That is restraint.”

Baren ignored her.

The cow puzzle still missed one sky piece.

Baren opened the box.

The piece waited.

He pushed it toward Mara.

“Today maybe place.”

Mara looked at him.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

“You sure?”

“No. Medium.”

She held the piece.

Waited.

Baren watched.

Then nodded once.

Mara placed it into the sky.

The puzzle became complete.

No one spoke.

No one clapped.

No one breathed too loudly.

The cow stood in a field under a finished sky and did not know it had just survived adults.

Baren looked at the puzzle for a long time.

Then said, "Okay."

Mara asked, "Leave it?"

He thought.

"For today."

Lila nodded.

"For today."

Morro looked like a woman watching a verdict she had no jurisdiction to improve.

The piece stayed.

Not forever.

Not as ending.

For today.

Medium useful allowed some things to be finished temporarily.

At 3:30 p.m., Baren requested courtyard.

The sad maple had dropped enough leaves to look intentional.

Baren stood beneath it.

"Tree committed to losing."

Cole said, "Season remains season."

Baren picked up a leaf.

Not the same one as before.

New leaf.

He held it.

Then placed it on the bench.

Lila asked nothing.

Good.

He looked at the tree.

"Can something lose leaves and still be doing what it is supposed to?"

Cole answered, "Yes."

Baren looked at him.

"That one can be private."

"Good," Cole said.

The leaf stayed on the bench until wind moved it.

No one chased it.

At 4:30, Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren told her the cow puzzle was complete for today.

Serena smiled carefully.

"For today sounds good."

"It does not mean done forever."

"I understand."

"Do you?"

"I think so. It means today it is allowed to be complete without tomorrow being trapped by that."

Baren considered.

"That is actually good."

"Too good?"

"Medium good."

"I will accept medium."

He asked about therapy.

She said it was useful and sad.

He said useful first was for adults.

She said she knew.

Timer buzzed.

He said, "Done."

She stood.

No extra.

Good.

At 5:30, Chronald sent a production certification.

All known campaign materials involving Baren, family privacy, child absence, fatherhood restraint, public meaning, and related polling had been produced under penalty of perjury.

Morro read the certification.

"Good if true."

Lila said, "Receipts?"

“Production log attached.”

Baren was not told because he had not asked.

Campaign could go.

Not him.

The certification went to adult rooms.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate all of it.

This alarmed everyone.

He looked at them.

“I was hungry.”

Nurse Imani said, “Accepted.”

“No meaning.”

“None.”

Morro did not move.

After dinner, Baren asked whether medium useful had been too useful.

Lila answered, “You decide.”

He thought.

“No. I said no when needed.”

“Yes.”

“I reviewed one adult sentence.”

“Yes.”

“I did school.”

“Yes.”

“I let puzzle finish today.”

“Yes.”

“I did not hold big machine.”

“No.”

He nodded.

“Medium.”

“Medium,” Lila agreed.

Morro said, “Standard established?”

Baren looked at her.

“No standard.”

She nodded.

“Today established.”

“Review tomorrow.”

“Review tomorrow.”

Before bed, the cow puzzle remained complete on the common table.

Baren looked at it.

Then did not remove the piece.

“For night too?” Lila asked.

“For night.”

“Okay.”

He went to his room.

Opened the drawer.

One check.

Everything still there.

Side table unchanged except the octopus fact had migrated under the table, probably by air or Cole’s boot.

Baren noticed.

“Portable shelter moved.”

Cole looked guilty.

“I may have nudged it.”

“Did it choose?”

“No.”

“Then put it back near table.”

Cole did.

“Consent matters for octopus facts.”

Morro whispered, “I am in pain.”

Baren smiled.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, pretending not to worry about the completed puzzle.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can complete be temporary?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Can useful be temporary?”

“Yes.”

“Can useless come back?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He closed his eyes.

“Medium tomorrow maybe. Maybe not.”

“Review tomorrow.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, hearings continued turning soft titles into hard questions.

Elsewhere, money made rooms sticky.

Elsewhere, international rooms learned that distance was not deletion.

Here, the cow puzzle was complete for the night.

The piece fit.

The piece stayed.

Not because adults needed closure.

Because Baren allowed today to be whole.

CHAPTER SIXTY-FIVE

Whole for the Night

The puzzle stayed complete through breakfast.

This was not small.

It looked small, which was how the best dangerous things disguised themselves. A cow puzzle on a common room table. A field. A fence. A sky with no gap. One final piece placed by Mara, allowed by Baren, survived by Morro, and not immediately converted into closure by any adult with access to language.

By 7:30 a.m., the puzzle had made it twelve hours.

Morro checked the room three times without admitting she was checking the puzzle.

Baren noticed all three.

“You are orbiting.”

Morro stopped near the coffee machine.

“I am walking.”

“In circles.”

“The lounge has limited geometry.”

Cole, outside the door, said, “Orbit confirmed.”

Morro looked at him.

“Do not encourage astronomy.”

Baren entered wearing gray socks and a skeptical expression.

He stood over the puzzle.

The cow remained whole.

The sky remained filled.

The fence remained unnecessarily peaceful.

He did not touch it.

“Still okay,” he said.

Lila smiled.

“Good.”

“Not forever.”

“Okay.”

“Not ending.”

“Okay.”

“Not evidence.”

Morro took a breath, then stopped herself.

Baren turned.

“Good not asking.”

Morro nodded once.

“Learning.”

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

No private toast.

No ritual.

Just toast.

Baren ate while the puzzle stayed complete in the next room, doing nothing to the legal system.

This, Morro later admitted privately to absolutely no one, was impressive.

At 8:45 a.m., the oversight hearing entered its sixth day and began with a mistake.

A large poster board appeared behind the first witness.

It showed a diagram of the private governance networks under review.

At the center of the diagram was a blank circle labeled:

Protected Minor Catalyst Event

Morro saw it and said, “Remove it.”

The task-force liaison texted hearing staff.

The hearing chair paused proceedings within four minutes.

The poster was removed.

The witness looked confused.

The chair said into the microphone, “This hearing will not visually or conceptually center a protected minor. Adult systems are the subject of review.”

Morro sat back.

“Good.”

Mara’s newsroom did not show the poster.

The correction went out through the public guidance desk:

Do not place protected minors at the center of diagrams, timelines, training materials, network maps, or explanatory visuals unless legally necessary and independently reviewed. Adult systems should be mapped around adult conduct, institutions, records, money, authority, and decisions.

Baren was not told about the poster.

He had specifically said medium useful did not mean emergency diagram feelings.

Instead, he read about dinosaur tails.

Tails were for balance.

Not symbolism.

Morro was not allowed near that sentence.

School went well until balance became suspicious.

Ms. Rowe explained that many dinosaurs used tails to help balance their bodies when moving.

Baren looked at the picture.

“So the front did not fall because back helped.”

“Yes.”

“Adults will ruin that.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

She had stopped fighting inevitability.

Baren looked toward the doorway.

Morro was there.

Of course.

“No.”

Morro lifted both hands.

“I said nothing.”

“Your face said task force.”

“My face is under review.”

“Good.”

He returned to the book.

They read three paragraphs.

He stumbled on **counterbalance**, then got it.

He liked the word.

“Counterbalance sounds like an adult pretending not to fall.”

Ms. Rowe smiled.

“Maybe.”

He drew a dinosaur with a tail too large for its body.

The dinosaur looked offended by physics.

He placed the drawing in the school folder.

School progress.

Not drawer.

Not table.

Safe.

Then he looked at the completed cow puzzle.

“Puzzle is balanced.”

No one answered.

At 10:00, the state hearing called the first technology procurement witness.

Not a founder.

Not a visionary.

A purchasing director.

This delighted Morro.

“Finally,” she said. “Someone who knows where the invoices went.”

The purchasing director explained how Elysium tools were acquired by institutions through risk-management budgets, donor-funded innovation grants, public-trust pilots, crisis-response retainers, and leadership analytics packages.

Mara wrote:

Technology entered the room through procurement, not prophecy.

She sent it to Morro.

“Body. Adult.”

The witness testified that many institutions did not ask what safeguards existed for minors because the tools were described as audience analysis and reputational risk support, not child-impact systems.

A lawmaker asked, “Were there no warnings?”

The witness produced a procurement checklist.

One question read:

Could use of this tool affect vulnerable populations, minors, complainants, witnesses, or people subject to institutional authority?

The box had been checked N/A.

Morro stared at it.

“N/A is where conscience goes to die.”

Crowe, remote, whispered, "Public?"

Morro considered.

"Adult. Body."

Mara added it later with attribution:

As one advisor observed, "N/A" can become a place where conscience disappears when institutions fail to ask who may be affected by a tool.

She softened die to disappears.

Morro approved reluctantly.

"Cowardly but printable."

Baren did not hear the line.

He was in math learning that 1.0 and 1 could be the same amount.

This offended him.

"Why add the dot?"

Ms. Rowe said, "Sometimes the format helps with other numbers."

"It looks like one wearing a name tag."

Cole said, "Office one."

Baren nodded.

"Exactly."

Morro was banned from decimal commentary after "toast knife," so she said nothing.

At noon, lunch was soup.

Baren chose it.

No one understood why.

He ate two spoonfuls and frowned.

"Still soup."

Nurse Imani said, "Reliable?"

"No. Macaroni is reliable disappointment. Soup is variable disappointment."

Cole nodded.

"Important distinction."

Morro looked toward the whiteboard, then away.

No record.

Variable disappointment remained private.

After lunch, Baren stood by the cow puzzle.

"It can stay complete until evening."

Lila nodded.

"Okay."

"Then maybe box."

“Okay.”

Morro looked like she needed a legal pad.

Baren said, “No.”

“Understood.”

“Complete can visit.”

That one hurt the adults.

A beautiful sentence, entering the world unclaimed.

Morro closed her eyes briefly.

Baren watched her.

“Private.”

“Yes,” Morro said.

“Good.”

The puzzle stayed.

Complete visiting.

No one wrote it down.

At 1:30, Mara arrived for puzzle visit and discovered there was no puzzle to work.

The cow puzzle was complete.

This caused a problem.

Not for Baren.

For Mara.

She stood beside the table and looked at the finished picture.

“Oh.”

Baren nodded.

“Yes.”

“Do we take it apart?”

“Not yet.”

“Do we start another?”

“No.”

“Then what is puzzle visit?”

“Visit.”

Mara absorbed this.

“Without puzzle?”

“Yes.”

She sat.

He sat across from her.

The cow puzzle sat beside them, complete and irrelevant.

Mara had brought one trust fact but did not offer it.

Baren noticed.

“Fact?”

“I have one.”

“Say.”

“Some cows have best friends and can get stressed when separated.”

Baren stared.

Cole, from the doorway, whispered, “Cow fact.”

Morro looked personally threatened.

Baren thought.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

He looked at the cow puzzle.

“Do puzzle cows?”

“I do not know.”

“Good.”

The fact sat in the air.

Not written.

Not checked.

Half believed.

Mara looked at the puzzle.

“It is hard not to do anything with it.”

Baren nodded.

“Useful adults.”

“Yes.”

“Can you just visit?”

“I am trying.”

“Trying trying?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

They sat for ten minutes.

No puzzle work.

No fact checking.

No article.

Mara left looking unsettled and lighter.

Both could be true.

At 2:30, the hearing finally said Chronald's name out loud.

Not dramatically.

In connection with campaign records, privacy polling, fatherhood messaging tests, donor communications, and the decision to end the campaign.

The chair was careful.

"Mr. Sump is an adult subject of record review and a producing party. The protected minor is not a witness to this committee."

Good.

Bex Alton testified remotely under subpoena.

She looked prepared.

Tired.

She admitted the campaign tested Baren-related privacy language.

She admitted she had argued against using direct images but did not initially object to measuring the value of absence.

She admitted she preserved records after realizing absence had become strategy.

A lawmaker asked, "Are you asking this committee to view you as a whistleblower?"

Bex answered, "No. I am asking you to review the documents I preserved."

"Excellent."

Lila marked:

Late Adult with documents.

Still watched.

Not absolution.

Mara's article led with Bex's line.

No. I am asking you to review the documents I preserved.

Adult-owned.

Public.

Receipts.

Baren was told later, safe version.

"A campaign adult testified and said adults should look at documents, not treat her as hero."

Baren nodded.

"Good. Hero is sticky."

Morro looked at him.

He sighed.

“Yes. Adult public.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Hero narratives can become sticky. Cooperating adults may provide important records without being converted into symbols of redemption. Review documents, conduct, timing, incentives, and remaining accountability.

Morro approved.

“Sticky remains useful.”

Baren said, “Because it is clear.”

“Yes.”

“No stickers.”

“No stickers.”

At 4:00, the hearing adjourned early because one witness produced surprise records and everyone needed to stop pretending surprise records could be responsibly handled live.

Morro approved the adjournment.

“Stopping is competence.”

The surprise records concerned a second public-trust lab.

Not Elysium.

Not Sump.

Adjacent.

The machine widened again.

The task force moved it elsewhere.

Not the unit.

Baren was in the courtyard with Cole, looking at the sad maple.

The leaf on the bench from yesterday was gone.

Wind, probably.

“Leaf left,” Baren said.

Cole nodded.

“Looks like.”

“Not stolen?”

“Probably not.”

“Good.”

They sat.

No new leaf selected.

No object kept.

No metaphor, though several hovered nearby like adult mosquitoes.

Cole swatted none.

That was growth too.

At 5:00, Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Five minutes.

Baren told her the cow puzzle was complete for today.

She smiled.

“For today.”

He studied her.

“You remembered.”

“I did.”

“Good.”

She asked, “May I ask what the picture is?”

“Cows.”

“Good cows?”

“Neutral cows.”

“Best kind.”

He nodded.

Then asked, “Do cows have best friends?”

Serena blinked.

“I do not know.”

“Good. Halfway fact.”

“Okay.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

“Okay.”

At the door, she paused, then did not say the thing she wanted to say.

Baren saw.

“What did you not say?”

She turned back.

“That I was glad you had a complete puzzle.”

He considered.

“You can say that.”

“I am glad you had a complete puzzle.”

“Had?”

“For today.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Visit ended.

No overreach.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

Then went to the common table.

The cow puzzle waited.

Complete.

He stood over it.

Everyone accidentally noticed.

Then pretended not to.

He lifted the final sky piece.

Paused.

Put it back in the box.

The sky opened again.

The cow remained calm.

Mara was not there, but Lila texted her later only after Baren said she could know:

Piece back in box. For tonight.

Mara replied:

Understood. No meaning added.

Baren approved the response.

“She is learning.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Trying Adult.”

“Yes.”

Morro watched the puzzle gap return and looked relieved against her will.

“Completion visited,” Baren said.

No one wrote it down.

Morro whispered, “I may need medical support.”

Nurse Imani said, “Noted.”

Baren pointed.

They both froze.

He smiled.

“Joke.”

Everyone exhaled.

Before bed, the drawer got one check.

Still there.

Nothing added.

Side table unchanged.

Octopus fact still beside table.

Parrotfish fact still under shark.

Cow puzzle incomplete again.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, staring at the puzzle gap like a judge respecting a sealed record.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can something be whole and then not whole and still okay?"

Lila answered, "Yes."

"Can people?"

"Yes."

"Can adults?"

"Yes."

"Can cases?"

"Yes."

"Can tomorrow?"

"Yes."

He nodded.

"Good."

Then:

"Do not use that."

"I won't."

Morro called softly from the lounge, "Private."

Baren smiled.

"Good."

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, hearings stopped because surprise records deserved care.

Elsewhere, adult witnesses learned that documents mattered more than hero stories.

Elsewhere, another public-trust lab entered the map.

Here, completion had visited and left.

The piece could fit.

The piece could stay.

The piece could go back in the box.

And because Baren controlled the movement, none of it became a cage.

CHAPTER SIXTY-SIX

Completion Visited

Completion visited again the next morning and behaved better than expected.

It did not knock.

It did not bring flowers.

It did not arrive wearing a sash that said **closure**.

It sat in a cardboard box beside a cow puzzle with a missing piece of sky and waited for Baren to decide whether today was the kind of day that wanted a whole picture.

At 7:22 a.m., Baren entered the common room in yellow socks.

This caused no reaction, which meant the adults had either learned or were pretending well enough to count.

The cow puzzle waited on the table.

Gap in sky.

Piece in box.

Morro stood by the coffee machine, deeply committed to looking elsewhere.

Cole sat in the hallway chair, awake, boots tied, coffee untouched.

Nurse Imani carried breakfast cards and no assumptions.

Lila held one folder.

Closed.

Baren walked to the table and looked at the puzzle.

“Still not whole.”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Still okay.”

“Yes.”

He opened the box.

The final piece sat there, same as yesterday.

Small.

Blue-gray.

Patient.

He picked it up.

Morro stopped breathing in a way that would have been actionable if Baren had wanted to make it actionable.

He placed the piece into the puzzle.

The sky closed.

The cow stood whole again.

Baren looked at it.

Then looked at Morro.

“You may breathe.”

Morro breathed.

Cole whispered, “Court resumes.”

Baren smiled.

“Private.”

“Private,” Cole said.

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

Baren ate beside the completed puzzle.

No ceremony.

No declaration.

No card.

The cow endured wholeness with admirable neutrality.

After three bites, Baren said, “It can be whole for breakfast.”

Lila nodded.

“For breakfast.”

Morro asked nothing.

That was the miracle.

At 8:30 a.m., the oversight hearing entered surprise-record day.

The second public-trust lab had a name.

Civic Horizon Lab.

Morro hated it immediately.

“Every dangerous institution wants a horizon,” she said.

Crowe, remote, said, “Because horizons cannot be subpoenaed.”

Morro pointed at the screen.

“Adult. Body maybe.”

Mara wrote it down.

The lab’s records showed consulting work for universities, family offices, political campaigns, faith networks, and philanthropic boards. Not child programming directly. That was the defense. Civic Horizon did not “work

with children.” It worked with institutions that worked around children, near children, through children, and occasionally because of children.

The invoices used clean words.

Trust restoration.

Stakeholder confidence.

Future leadership alignment.

Narrative cooling.

Sensitive population optics.

Youth-adjacent impact modeling.

Morro placed her coffee down with exaggerated care.

“I want the phrase youth-adjacent placed in protective custody.”

Lila nodded.

“Agreed.”

A Civic Horizon partner testified that the lab did not make decisions. It provided decision support.

The hearing chair asked, “Support for whose decisions?”

The partner paused.

“Institutional clients.”

“Were affected minors or former minors clients?”

“No.”

“Were workers clients?”

“No.”

“Were complainants clients?”

“No.”

“Were families whose privacy was being framed clients?”

“Generally, no.”

The chair leaned back.

“So the people most affected by the decisions were not the people purchasing support.”

“There.”

Mara typed:

Decision support for institutions can become decision pressure on everyone else.

She sent it to Morro.

“Adult concept. Public.”

The article later read:

The hearing raised a central question about “decision support” vendors: support for institutional clients may function as pressure on non-clients, including students, workers, complainants, families, or

minors affected by the resulting strategy.

Dry.

Good.

Baren did not hear it.

He was doing school reading about dinosaur nests, which he had declared
“less suspicious than horizons.”

School reading went sideways when Ms. Rowe introduced the word
incubation.

Baren stared.

“Egg waiting.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Waiting can have teeth.”

Lila looked up.

Baren looked at her.

“Old sentence.”

“Yes.”

“No new guidance.”

“Okay.”

Ms. Rowe explained how eggs needed conditions.

Temperature.

Protection.

Time.

Not too much disturbance.

Baren liked that until adults seemed likely to ruin it.

He closed the book.

“Enough eggs.”

“Okay.”

“Math?”

Ms. Rowe blinked.

“Math?”

“Medium useful.”

Decimals returned.

0.125 still waited.

The old trap.

Baren looked at it.

“One-eighth.”

Ms. Rowe smiled.

“Yes.”

He wrote it down.

“Not too small today.”

“Good.”

He looked at the paper.

“Some numbers get less scary when you leave them alone.”

Morro made a strangled sound in the doorway.

Baren turned.

“School?”

Morro asked carefully, “May that be used for school?”

He thought.

“Yes.”

Ms. Rowe wrote the school version:

Some difficult tasks become easier after rest and no pressure.

Baren approved.

“Safe.”

Morro exhaled.

The adults had begun asking correctly.

That was not everything.

But it was a lot.

At 10:30 a.m., the first defendant tried to plead usefulness.

Not legally.

Publicly.

Graham Pell, the trust attorney, issued a statement through counsel saying he had “facilitated continuity discussions in good faith” and that his “administrative role” had been “mischaracterized by those seeking villains in complex family systems.”

Morro read the statement.

“Administrative role.”

Lila looked tired.

“Room Adult defense.”

Simon nodded from the screen.

“Common.”

Mara’s newsroom published a short legal explainer:

The “administrative role” defense will likely become central in the Old Court prosecutions. Prosecutors will need to show not merely that a person performed logistics, drafting, scheduling, coding, or record handling, but that the person knowingly furthered unlawful activity. At the same time, the case has already shown why details matter: harmful systems are often made real through administrative acts.

Morro approved.

“Balanced.”

Mara frowned.

“I hate balanced when he is lying.”

“Balance is not pretending. Balance is aiming.”

Mara wrote that down privately.

Morro saw.

“Not public.”

“I know.”

Baren was not told.

He was inspecting whether the cow puzzle should remain whole through lunch.

It did.

The puzzle stayed complete through lunch.

This created quiet pressure.

Completion had lasted breakfast, reading, math, one adult hearing segment, and grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

No geometry comment.

Cole appeared to be physically unwell from restraint.

Baren noticed.

“You may say one.”

Cole leaned forward.

“Rectangles remain stable under observation.”

Baren nodded.

“Accepted.”

Morro muttered, “This family has lost its mind.”

Lila said, “Not family.”

The room paused.

Lila had not meant to correct the word hard.

But it landed.

Not family.

Not exactly.

Team.

Protective structure.

Temporary room.

People in proximity with responsibilities.

Some affection, yes.

Some care.

Some habit.

But family was not a word adults got to assign because the room had survived crisis.

Baren looked at Lila.

“Good catch.”

Lila nodded.

Morro said, “Corrected.”

Cole looked toward the hallway.

“Protective structure?”

Baren made a face.

“Sounds like scaffolding.”

Morro said, “Scaffolding is useful and temporary.”

Baren looked at her.

“That is good.”

Morro froze.

Baren considered.

“Adult guidance?”

Lila asked, “About care teams?”

“Yes.”

The guidance desk later added:

Protective teams should not assume family-like permanence or emotional entitlement because they provided care during crisis. Temporary structures can be deeply important without claiming the protected person. Scaffolding is useful because it supports without becoming the building.

Baren read the safe version.

“Good. Do not make shirts.”

“No shirts.”

Cole looked vaguely hurt.

“Scaffolding shirt?”

“No,” everyone said.

At 1:00 p.m., the hearing produced the sentence that would probably survive the week.

It came from an unlikely source: a procurement officer from a mid-sized university system.

He had been asked why his office approved multiple public-trust and youth-engagement contracts without child-impact review.

He looked at the invoices, then at the committee.

“Because the harm was not described in the language of purchasing.”

The room went quiet.

He continued.

“It was described as engagement, retention, trust, family confidence, donor continuity, risk reduction. Purchasing systems catch prohibited vendors, pricing problems, conflicts sometimes. They do not catch a child becoming the product unless someone says the child is part of the product.”

Morro stood.

“Public.”

Mara typed with care.

The article led:

A procurement witness told lawmakers that institutional systems failed partly because potential harm to children and vulnerable people was “not described in the language of purchasing.”

The line moved through compliance networks with the force of a brick quietly dropped into an aquarium.

Procurement.

Contracts.

Vendors.

Scopes of work.

Risk language.

Child-impact review.

The machine had found another mundane doorway.

Baren was not told.

He had asked for no adult hearing details until after dinner.

The cow puzzle remained whole.

That was enough for now.

At 2:00 p.m., Mara arrived.

Puzzle visit.

But the puzzle was complete.

Again.

She stood at the table.

“Whole.”

“For now,” Baren said.

“For now.”

“Can you visit without fixing?”

“I practiced yesterday.”

“How did you do?”

“Medium.”

“Good.”

She sat.

No fact.

No notebook.

No puzzle piece to hold.

The cow looked at both of them with the calm of an animal uninvolved in public meaning.

Baren asked, “Did adults try to make you family?”

Mara blinked.

“No. Not exactly.”

“Do you want that?”

She answered slowly.

“I want to matter without taking.”

Baren thought.

“That is a good want.”

“It is also dangerous.”

“Yes.”

He looked at the puzzle.

“Scaffolding.”

“Maybe.”

“Scaffolding leaves.”

“Yes.”

“Can it come back?”

“If asked.”

“Good.”

Mara swallowed.

“I can be scaffolding.”

“Maybe. Still watched.”

“Yes.”

“Puzzle visits are okay.”

“Good.”

No one cried.

No one made it bigger.

The cow remained cow.

At 3:30 p.m., the task force issued a new vendor bulletin.

It was ugly in exactly the right way.

Child-Impact Review for Institutional Decision-Support Vendors

Morro loved the title because no one else would.

The bulletin required institutions using analytics, public-trust consulting, restorative-process facilitation, youth engagement vendors, crisis communications firms, or family governance consultants to assess whether the work could affect minors, complainants, workers, former minors, students, patients, or dependent persons even if those people were not direct clients.

Questions included:

Who pays?

Who is affected?

Who has independent representation?

Can affected people refuse?

Are minors involved directly or indirectly?

Are records preserved?

Are worker-witnesses protected?

Does the vendor measure silence, absence, refusal, forgiveness, public expectation, or future participation?

Does the strategy benefit from a protected person not knowing they are part of the strategy?

Morro approved every question.

Baren saw none of them.

He was outside with Cole, watching the sad maple fail to impress spring.

“Still sad,” Baren said.

“Committed,” Cole said.

“Maybe okay.”

“Maybe.”

They sat quietly.

The tree did not become a resilience metaphor because both of them were tired and had standards.

At 5:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Baren told her the protective team was scaffolding.

She listened.

Then said, “That sounds right.”

“Are mothers scaffolding?”

Serena took longer.

“Sometimes. Sometimes mothers are foundation. Sometimes shelter. Sometimes repair crew. Sometimes a person who has to stand farther away so the building can be inspected.”

Baren looked at her.

“That is too good.”

“I am sorry.”

“Was it from therapy?”

“Yes.”

“Tell therapy less good.”

“I will try.”

He thought.

“You can be far scaffolding.”

Serena’s eyes filled.

She did not make him fix it.

“Thank you.”

“Not forever maybe.”

“I understand.”

“Still watched.”

“Yes.”

Timer buzzed.

“Done.”

She stood.

No extra.

At the door, she said, “Far scaffolding is enough for today.”

Baren considered.

“Good.”

Then she left.

Lila wrote nothing.

Morro, when told, also wrote nothing.

Some structural engineering remained private.

At 6:00 p.m., Baren decided the cow puzzle could remain complete overnight again.

This surprised him.

The adults were better this time.

No one reacted too much.

Morro only nodded once.

Cole said nothing.

Lila said, “Okay.”

Nurse Imani asked about dinner.

Macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

He ate most of it again.

“Macaroni is becoming less disappointing,” he said.

Cole looked concerned.

“Change happens.”

Baren nodded.

“Review tomorrow.”

After dinner, Lila gave him the adult update he had requested.

“Adult hearings continued. Adults talked about vendors, money, religious words, technology, and campaign records. No child testimony. Worker protections continue. Other adults are carrying the big work.”

“Any adult caught?”

“No new arrests today.”

“Any wall moved?”

“Vendor rules maybe.”

“Without me?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He thought.

“Did adults try to center me?”

“Yes. A hearing visual did, and it was removed.”

His face tightened.

“Removed?”

“Yes. Quickly.”

“Good.”

“Do you want details?”

“No.”

He looked toward the completed puzzle.

“Sometimes remove piece. Sometimes remove poster.”

Morro closed her eyes.

Baren saw.

“Private.”

“Private,” she said.

Before bed, he checked the drawer once.

Everything still there.

He added nothing.

The cow puzzle remained complete in the common room.

Side table unchanged.

Octopus fact near table.

Parrotfish under shark.

Breakfast card.

Ordinary pencil.

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, learning the difference between a sentence offered and a sentence available.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can scaffolding care?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Can scaffolding leave?"

"Yes."

"Can leaving be care?"

"Yes."

"Can staying be care?"

"Yes."

"How know?"

Lila thought.

"Ask who it supports."

He nodded.

"That is good."

"Private?"

"Private."

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, procurement learned how harm hides in invoices.

Elsewhere, vendors learned affected people can exist without being clients.

Elsewhere, hearings continued adult-first.

Here, the puzzle stayed whole for another night.

Not as closure.

Not as proof.

Not as a promise.

As a visit that had been invited to stay until morning.

CHAPTER SIXTY-SEVEN

Scaffolding

The puzzle remained whole until morning.

No one died.

This disappointed several adult nervous systems that had prepared for consequences.

At 7:06 a.m., Baren walked into the common room, saw the cow puzzle still complete, and nodded like a building inspector who had found nothing alarming but refused to compliment the contractor.

“Still whole.”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Still not ending.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Morro stood near the coffee machine, watching with the expression of a person who had spent the night respecting a boundary and wanted no medal for it, though perhaps a notarized acknowledgment would have been acceptable.

Baren looked at her.

“You survived.”

Morro took a sip.

“Barely.”

“Trying Adult.”

“Apparently.”

Cole, outside the hallway, said, “Useful now.”

Morro pointed her mug at him.

“You are becoming too fluent.”

Cole shrugged.

“Protective structure learns.”

Baren looked at him.

“Scaffolding learns?”

Cole paused.

“Maybe the people on it do.”

Baren considered this.

“Good.”

Morro inhaled.

Baren pointed.

“Private.”

She exhaled.

“Private.”

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

No doctrine.

The puzzle stayed whole through cereal.

The cow seemed fine.

The task force discovered scaffolding before 9:00 a.m. and immediately tried to overbuild it.

A draft protocol arrived titled:

Temporary Supportive Relational Infrastructure for Protected Minors in Crisis-Related Institutional Proceedings

Morro read the title aloud.

Baren, who was nearby looking for the ordinary pencil, stopped.

“That title hurt me.”

Morro looked at the screen.

“Me too.”

Lila covered her mouth.

Crowe, remote, whispered, “It sounds like scaffolding went to graduate school and never came back.”

Morro said, “Publicly accurate.”

The task-force drafter explained that the protocol was meant to govern relationships between protected minors and adults who had assisted during crisis: journalists, advisors, former clergy, protective witnesses, nurses, counsel, consultants, and other people who were important but not family.

Baren stood in the doorway.

“Scaffolding protocol?”

Lila looked at him.

“You do not have to help.”

“I know.”

“Do you want the short version?”

“Yes.”

Morro summarized.

“Adults are trying to write rules for people who helped during crisis so they do not start believing they own permanent emotional access.”

Baren nodded.

“That is good.”

“Yes.”

“Title is bad.”

“Catastrophic.”

“Call it leaving rules.”

Everyone paused.

Morro tilted her head.

“Leaving rules?”

“For scaffolding. How to stay right. How to leave right. How to come back only if asked.”

Lila wrote it down.

Morro looked at Baren.

“May we use the concept?”

“Yes. Adult guidance.”

The title became:

Leaving Rules for Crisis Support Adults

The lawyers hated it.

Morro loved it.

That meant it was correct.

The protocol stated:

Crisis support does not create permanent access.

Care does not create ownership.

Shared danger does not create family status.

The protected person may want continued contact, limited contact, changed contact, or no contact.

Adults should not make the protected person manage their sadness about changed roles.

Contact should be scheduled, revocable, documented appropriately, and reviewed for the protected person’s benefit.

Adults who helped may still be accountable for mistakes.

Leaving can be care.

Returning can be care only when requested or authorized.

Morro approved the final line:

The goal of scaffolding is not to be loved by the building. The goal is to support until support is no longer needed in that form.

Baren read the safe version.

“That is almost too good.”

“Adult concept,” Morro said.

“Okay.”

“Public?”

“Yes. Adults need leaving rules.”

The guidance went out under its ugly-simple title.

Some professionals objected that “leaving rules” sounded unsophisticated.

Morro replied internally:

Correct. It can be understood.

At 10:00 a.m., school reading resumed with dinosaurs.

Ms. Rowe brought a chapter on migration.

Baren was suspicious immediately.

“Moving.”

“Yes.”

“Animals move because conditions change?”

“Yes.”

“Adults will ruin that.”

“Likely.”

“Okay.”

He read about herds moving for food, weather, safety, and reproduction. He skipped the reproduction paragraph because “not today.” Ms. Rowe accepted this without blinking.

Migration made sense to him.

Not destiny.

Not exile.

Movement.

He asked, “Do animals know they are migrating?”

Ms. Rowe said, “Some probably respond to signals. Food, weather, seasons. They may not think of it like a plan.”

Baren liked that.

“Moving without making it a story.”

Morro was not in the doorway.

This was lucky for everyone.

Lila was there.

She did not write it down.

Baren noticed.

“Good.”

He drew a line of very bad dinosaurs moving across a page.

One dinosaur faced the wrong direction.

He liked that one best.

“School folder,” he said.

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“School folder.”

The oversight hearing spent the morning on leaving rules without knowing it.

Former staff from Mercy Futures, university programs, and youth leadership retreats testified about post-crisis contact.

Follow-up calls.

Check-ins.

Alumni networks.

Mentorship offers.

Private invitations.

Birthday messages.

Holiday cards.

Scholarship renewals.

Leadership reunions.

Some were kind.

Some were traps.

Often the difference depended on who controlled the contact and whether refusal ended it.

A former program coordinator testified that staff were instructed to “maintain warm connection” with youth participants who had withdrawn.

The hearing chair asked, “Did withdrawal end contact?”

The coordinator said, “Not necessarily. We viewed continued warmth as care.”

Morro said, “No.”

The chair said, “Could it also function as monitoring?”

The coordinator paused.

“Yes.”

There it was.

Warmth could be surveillance if the person could not make it stop.

Mara’s newsroom published:

Hearing Examines Post-Crisis Contact and “Warm Monitoring” of Youth Participants

Morro approved the phrase warm monitoring because it was adult witness language and ugly enough to warn.

The article explained:

Supportive contact after crisis may be appropriate, but when controlled by an interested institution, ongoing “warm connection” can become monitoring, pressure, or preservation of future access. Refusal must be allowed to end contact unless a lawful safety duty requires otherwise.

Baren was not told the phrase during lunch.

He had declared lunch a “low adult concept zone.”

Morro respected it by force.

Lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole used his one geometry comment early.

“Rectangles remain administratively efficient.”

Baren nodded.

“Accepted.”

Morro whispered, “That was not worth saving.”

Cole said, “Private.”

After lunch, Baren stood over the complete cow puzzle.

“Today it can come apart.”

Lila nodded.

“Okay.”

He removed one corner piece.

Then another.

Then stopped.

“Not all.”

“Okay.”

He looked at Mara’s sky piece.

Still in place.

“Leave sky.”

Morro looked interested despite herself.

Baren looked at her.

“No.”

“Understood.”

He removed fence pieces.

Two cows lost their boundaries.

No one interpreted.

Then he left the puzzle partly undone and went to the courtyard.

Completion had visited.

Now departure visited.

Both behaved.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara arrived for puzzle visit and saw the partial dismantling.

She stood in the doorway.

“Oh.”

Baren looked at her.

“Too hard?”

“No.”

“Lying?”

“A little.”

“Okay.”

She sat.

The sky piece remained in place.

Fence pieces were scattered.

Cows partly unbordered.

Mara asked, “What do we do?”

“Take apart some.”

They removed pieces slowly.

Mara took apart sky last only because Baren said so.

When she reached the final sky piece, the one that had fit and left and fit again, she paused.

Baren nodded.

She removed it.

Placed it in the box.

No one died.

Morro, in the lounge, appeared to age backward from relief and forward from restraint simultaneously.

Baren looked at Mara.

“Good leaving.”

Mara swallowed.

“Good leaving.”

“Scaffolding.”

“Yes.”

“You can come back.”

“If asked.”

“Puzzle visits.”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The puzzle returned to pieces.

Not destroyed.

Available.

Different.

At 3:00 p.m., the leaving rules caused immediate institutional discomfort.

Emails poured in.

How long should support adults remain available?

What if a child appears attached?

What if an adult is the only trusted person?

What if a journalist, advocate, teacher, pastor, or guard has become important?

What if withdrawal harms the child?

What if staying harms the child?

What if the adult needs closure?

Morro answered the last one herself:

The adult's closure is not the protected person's assignment.

Public.

Adult concept.

The guidance expanded:

Crisis-created trust should be handled carefully, not abruptly severed or possessively preserved.

Baren read the safe version because leaving rules had started with him.

He nodded.

"Adults need their own adults."

"Yes," Lila said.

"Mara has editor. Crowe has Morro?"

Crowe, remote, looked alarmed.

Morro said, "I am not clergy."

Baren smiled.

"Better."

"Cole has who?" Lila asked gently.

Cole, in the hallway, stopped moving.

Baren looked at him.

Cole said, "Working on it."

Morro wrote on her pad:

PROTECTORS NEED SOMEWHERE TO PUT FEAR

She did not ask.

Private for now.

Cole had earned privacy too.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Five minutes.

Baren told her the puzzle came apart.

She listened carefully.

“Was that okay?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

“Scaffolding leaves.”

“Yes.”

“Can moms leave right?”

Serena’s face changed.

“I hope so.”

“What is leave right?”

She thought.

“Not disappearing. Not forcing. Being reachable through the rules.
Accepting no. Coming when invited. Leaving when time ends. Doing my
own work elsewhere.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

“Too good?”

“No. Medium.”

She smiled.

“I will take medium.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

“Okay.”

No extra.

Leaving right.

At 5:30, Chronald requested a channel for future updates that did not pass
through Baren unless Baren asked.

Lila approved through counsel.

Morro reviewed.

“Good.”

Chronald’s adult accountability updates would remain in adult systems.

If Baren asked, safe summaries.

If not, no delivery.

Campaign gone.

Hospital gone.

Father's sadness elsewhere.

Leaving rules.

Trying Adult.

Still watched.

Baren was not told because he did not ask.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment restored its reputation.

Baren ate half.

"Back to normal," he said.

Cole nodded.

"Disappointing?"

"Reliably."

Morro said, "At least something is governed."

After dinner, Baren looked at the common table.

The cow puzzle was now fully in the box.

Mara had helped.

No picture.

No field.

No cow.

No sky.

Just pieces.

He seemed okay.

Lila asked nothing.

Good.

He said, "Puzzle can rest."

No one wrote it.

Morro looked at the ceiling.

Baren laughed.

"You are getting better."

"I am suffering privately."

"Good."

Before bed, drawer check.

One.

Everything still there.

He added nothing.

Side table unchanged except the octopus fact had been placed properly near the table after its unauthorized travel.

Baren inspected it.

“Octopus shelter returned.”

Cole said, “With consent?”

“I moved it.”

“Then yes.”

“Good.”

Door half open.

Cole outside.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, revising leaving rules so adults would know how to stop making protected children hold the emotional weight of adults who helped them.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can people be pieces?”

Lila sat beside him.

“What do you mean?”

“Fit sometimes. Leave sometimes. Come back sometimes. Not lost.”

Lila thought.

“Yes.”

“Can adults handle that?”

“Some.”

“Morro?”

From the lounge, Morro said, “Under protest.”

Baren smiled.

“Mara?”

“Trying,” Lila said.

“Cole?”

Cole answered from outside.

“Working on it.”

“Serena?”

“Trying.”

“Chronald?”

Lila paused.

“Early trying.”

Baren accepted that.

“Me?”

“You decide.”

He nodded.

“Not tonight.”

“Okay.”

He turned toward the wall.

“Scaffolding can leave.”

“Yes.”

“Pieces can box.”

“Yes.”

“Still there.”

“Yes.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, hearings learned warmth could monitor.

Elsewhere, institutions objected to leaving rules because adults disliked not being needed.

Elsewhere, support structures began asking how to exit without becoming another claim.

Here, the cow puzzle rested in the box.

Not gone.

Not displayed.

Not finished.

Not unfinished.

Available only because no one demanded it be anything else.

CHAPTER SIXTY-EIGHT

Available

Available was better than waiting.

The black path was not disappearance. It was availability without claim.

Baren decided this before breakfast and announced it to no one.

That made it stronger.

Waiting had teeth when adults owned it. Waiting had a room prepared behind it, a letter sealed for eighteen, a future claim with soft lighting and the correct amount of sorrow.

Available was different.

Available did not lean.

Available did not knock every hour.

Available did not send birthday cards written by committees.

Available did not say, when you are ready, the room will be ready for you.

Available simply remained where it had been allowed to remain.

The cow puzzle was available in its box.

The drawer was available.

The side table was available.

The octopus fact was available near the table, still pretending it had not been moved without consent.

Mara was available for puzzle visits.

Crowe was available for plain ocean facts and adult advisories that did not require Baren to listen.

Serena was available through rules.

Chronald was available through counsel and records, which was better than through longing.

Cole was available outside the door.

Lila was available nearby.

Morro was available in the lounge, like a courthouse alarm someone had accidentally taught to make coffee.

None of that meant Baren had to use them.

That was the difference.

At 7:18 a.m., he opened his eyes, saw the half-open door, and said, "Available is not waiting."

Cole, outside, made a sound.

Not too much.

Good.

Nurse Imani knocked.

"Come in."

She entered with the schedule.

"What was that?"

Baren sat up.

"Available is not waiting."

Nurse Imani looked at him carefully.

"Do you want that written anywhere?"

He thought.

"No."

"Okay."

Morro appeared in the doorway three seconds later, because the building had apparently developed judicial acoustics.

"May I ask one question?"

Baren looked suspicious.

"One."

“Is this private or adult guidance later?”

“Private now.”

“Private now.”

He appreciated the now.

Now did not steal later.

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

Toast was available.

He used it.

Then it was gone.

No one mourned it.

At 8:30 a.m., the task force discovered available and tried, briefly, to ruin it.

The leaving-rules protocol had generated questions from schools, hospitals, youth programs, survivor organizations, courts, and faith institutions. Adults wanted timelines. They wanted scripts. They wanted forms. They wanted safe ways to say goodbye and safer ways to remain reachable.

One draft section said:

Support adults should remain waiting in a stable posture until the protected person initiates contact.

Morro read it and said, “No.”

Lila, beside her in the consult room, said, “Too much pressure.”

“Waiting aims itself at the child.”

Dr. Rao joined the call.

“Availability must not become expectation.”

Morro pointed at the screen.

“That.”

The section was rewritten:

Support adults may remain available through approved channels without communicating expectation, disappointment, urgency, entitlement, or emotional need. Availability should be structured, bounded, and revocable. The protected person should not be made responsible for using, appreciating, or responding to availability.

Morro approved.

“Dry.”

Lila smiled.

“Safe.”

Morro looked toward Baren’s hallway.

Private now.

The adult version could move without stealing his sentence.

The protocol added examples:

A former teacher may send contact information to counsel, not directly to the child.

A journalist who became trusted may request future contact only through the guardian and only if the child asks.

A protective witness may remain assigned by court order but should have supervision and transition planning.

A parent may remain reachable without sending emotional updates.

A clergy member may not remain “spiritually available” in a way that creates pressure.

Crowe objected to the last one only to say it should be stronger.

No hovering in holy language, he wrote.

Morro approved internally but translated publicly:

Spiritual availability must not become ongoing moral pressure.

Crowe called the translation “less fun and more survivable.”

Morro accepted that as praise.

School reading began with migration again.

Baren had not finished the chapter because reproduction had appeared unexpectedly and been postponed by executive child order.

Ms. Rowe skipped to movement patterns.

Herds.

Tracks.

Seasonal routes.

Predators.

Food.

Water.

Baren listened.

“So available water matters.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Water does not chase them.”

“No.”

“It is there.”

“Yes.”

He looked up.

“No guidance.”

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“No guidance.”

Morro was not in the doorway.

She had learned to avoid migration chapters.

Mostly.

Baren read a paragraph about a fossil trackway showing many animals moving in the same direction. Then one track went sideways.

He liked that one.

“Sideways dinosaur.”

Ms. Rowe smiled.

“Yes.”

“Did it get lost?”

“We do not know.”

“Did it choose?”

“We do not know.”

“Good.”

“Good?”

“Adults know too much when they want story.”

Ms. Rowe said nothing.

He drew the sideways dinosaur track in his school folder.

School progress.

Not life progress.

Available.

At 10:00 a.m., the oversight hearing called a parent witness.

This was dangerous.

Everyone knew it.

Parents could clarify adult pressure.

Parents could also become emotional proxy wars with better sweaters.

The witness was not Serena.

Not Chronald.

A parent from another Mercy-linked program.

Her adult child had chosen not to testify. The parent had permission to speak only about her own experience and institutional communications, not her child’s feelings, statements, or story.

The hearing chair repeated the boundary twice.

The parent nodded.

Then honored it.

That alone felt revolutionary.

She testified that the program had told her participation would help her child “process leadership trauma” and “remain connected to opportunity.” She said she had signed forms she did not understand because the institution told her the alternative might isolate her child from support.

“I thought I was consenting to care,” she said. “I was consenting to access.”

Morro stood.

Then sat.

Mara wrote carefully.

Adult statement.

Adult witness.

Adult harm.

The parent continued:

“My child does not want me to tell their story. I am here because I signed paperwork. That is my story.”

The hearing room went quiet.

The chair thanked her without calling her brave.

Good chair.

Morro approved:

“Excellent restraint.”

Mara’s headline:

Parent Witness Tells Hearing: “I Thought I Was Consenting to Care. I Was Consenting to Access.”

Baren did not hear the testimony.

He was sorting pencils by sharpness and rejecting the idea that sharpest meant best.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole did not speak.

Baren looked at him.

“Saving geometry again?”

Cole nodded.

“For unknown geometry.”

“Good.”

After lunch, Lila asked if Baren wanted an adult update.

“Any adult caught?”

“No new arrests.”

“Any wall moved?”

“Parent witness spoke about paperwork. No child story.”

Baren looked up.

“Parent talked without kid story?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He thought.

“Can Serena do that?”

“If she needs to, with rules.”

“Can Chronald?”

“Yes.”

His face changed.

“Would he?”

Lila answered carefully.

“He is learning. The rules would be strict.”

Baren nodded.

“Parents have their own story. Not mine.”

Morro, who had been passing with coffee and was apparently doomed by timing, froze.

Baren looked at her.

“Ask.”

“May we use that?”

“Yes. Parent guidance.”

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

Parents and caregivers may have their own records, choices, failures, pressures, and harms to describe. They should not tell a child’s story without the child’s consent or legal authority. A parent’s story may be real and important without becoming a substitute for the protected child’s voice.

Baren reviewed it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Add paperwork.”

Lila added:

Parents should be given clear explanations before signing forms that affect a child’s participation, privacy, records, contact, or access to support. Consent to care must not be converted into access for institutional purposes.

Baren nodded.

“Safe.”

At 1:30 p.m., Mara arrived for visit.

No puzzle.

The puzzle was in the box.

Available.

She noticed and looked at Baren.

“Puzzle available?”

“Yes.”

“Do you want it?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

She sat.

He sat.

No fact yet.

She waited.

Good.

Baren said, “Fact?”

Mara smiled.

“Some turtles can feel vibrations through their shells.”

Baren considered.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

“Do shells make them safe or just aware?”

Mara thought.

“Both, maybe. But not always safe.”

He nodded.

“Adults would make shell doctrine.”

“Definitely.”

“No shell doctrine.”

“No shell doctrine.”

They sat.

Then Baren asked, “Are you available or waiting?”

Mara took a breath.

“Trying to be available.”

“Hard?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Waiting feels like doing something. Available feels like not pushing.”

“That is good.”

“Private?”

“Yes.”

She nodded.

“Then private.”

The visit lasted twelve minutes.

No puzzle.

No work.

One turtle fact.

Half trusted.

Mara left without asking when the next visit would be.

That was the point.

At 2:30 p.m., Victor Elysium’s lawyers requested access to certain protected records, arguing they might show alternative causation, independent institutional decision-making, and lack of reliance on Elysium tools.

The government objected.

Child counsel objected.

Morro objected with such speed that the filing system seemed to flinch.

But the issue was real.

Defendants had rights.

Protected records had walls.

Courts had to test both.

Judge Havel ordered a sealed relevance review by a special evidence master not connected to the care team.

“Good.”

Mara asked on secure channel, “You are okay with someone reviewing protected records?”

“No,” Morro said. “I am okay with lawful process that prevents defendants from claiming they were denied access while also preventing fishing expeditions through child records.”

Lila added, “Different reviewer. Narrow scope. No defense possession unless ordered. Redactions. Protective order.”

Mara wrote the public explainer:

Court Orders Narrow Review Process for Defense Requests Involving Protected Records

Dry.

Important.

The article explained that due process may require courts to review whether protected materials contain relevant defense evidence, but that does not mean defendants receive broad access to a child’s private records.

Baren was told because it touched protected records generally.

“Some adult defendants asked for protected records. The judge said another legal adult will review narrowly, not give them everything.”

Baren’s face tightened.

“My drawer?”

“No.”

“My room?”

“No.”

“My care records?”

“Not without very strict review, and this is about records connected to the broader case.”

“Do adults get to ask?”

“Yes.”

“Do they get everything?”

“No.”

“Does court look first?”

“Yes.”

He thought.

“Rules even for asking.”

Morro nodded.

“Yes.”

He relaxed slightly.

“Good.”

Then:

“Private records are not snacks.”

Morro closed her eyes.

Baren pointed.

“No.”

“Private,” Morro said, strained.

“Good.”

At 4:00 p.m., Serena requested a visit and Baren said no.

No reason.

Accepted.

Serena replied correctly.

Received. No response.

Chronald sent no update.

Bex sent production receipt to adult channel.

Not Baren.

Crowe sent no ocean fact.

Cole took a supervision call in another room.

Baren noticed.

“Cole has adult?”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Good.”

When Cole returned, Baren asked, “Useful?”

Cole said, “Annoying.”

“Useful?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

No further questions.

Protectors needed somewhere to put fear.

Sometimes that somewhere was a phone call Baren did not have to hear.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

Then asked if available could end.

Lila said, “What do you mean?”

“If someone is available forever, is that waiting wearing better clothes?”

Morro looked up from the lounge.

Good question.

Dangerous question.

Lila answered slowly.

“Yes, it can become that.”

“So availability needs review.”

“Yes.”

Baren nodded.

“Review tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

Morro asked, “May we use adult version?”

He thought.

“Yes. Leaving rules.”

The protocol gained:

Availability should be reviewed over time. An arrangement that was protective at one stage may become pressure, dependency, surveillance, or symbolic waiting if left unexamined.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Then he added:

“Available is not forever unless asked again.”

Morro looked at him.

“Public?”

“Adult.”

The protocol added:

Availability is not forever unless renewed for the protected person’s benefit.

Dry enough.

Safe.

Before bed, Baren opened the drawer.

One check.

Everything still there.

He added nothing.

The side table held the same objects.

The cow puzzle remained boxed.

The turtle fact remained unwritten.

The octopus fact remained near the table, portable but currently still.

Door half open.

Cole outside, after supervision, quieter.

Lila nearby.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Morro in lounge, revising leaving rules to include review dates so adult availability could not quietly harden into expectation.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can available sleep?”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Can waiting sleep?”

“I do not know.”

“Waiting watches.”

“Sometimes.”

“Available sleeps until asked.”

“That sounds right.”

“Private.”

“Private.”

He closed his eyes.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, courts reviewed records without handing them over.

Elsewhere, parents learned to tell their own stories without taking their children's.

Elsewhere, support adults learned that availability required limits.

Here, everyone available was allowed to sleep.

And because no one waited at him, Baren did too.

CHAPTER SIXTY-NINE

Available Sleeps

Available slept badly at first.

After machines and institutions were forced outward, the smaller question remained: could help remain help when no one was using it?

This was not its fault.

Adults had trained themselves to confuse stillness with failure. If no one called, maybe they should check. If no one asked, maybe they should offer. If no one used the support, maybe the support should remind the protected person it existed.

This was how availability became waiting.

This was how waiting grew teeth.

So the first night after Baren said available sleeps, the adults tried sleeping too.

Cole failed.

Not completely.

He slept for forty-three minutes in the chair outside Baren's door, woke abruptly, checked the hallway without moving from the chair, remembered his supervision call, and did not stand.

That counted.

Nurse Imani noticed and wrote nothing.

Lila slept on the couch in the consult room for three hours because her body had apparently filed an emergency motion without telling her.

Morro did not sleep enough, but she did not use the extra time to create a new protocol, which several experts later agreed was functionally equivalent to rest.

Mara slept at her apartment with her phone across the room and woke only twice to check whether she had missed a message she had not been promised.

Crowe slept after deleting an ocean fact about bioluminescent plankton because he suspected it wanted to become theology.

Serena slept badly after not receiving a visit request and did not send a message.

Chronald did not sleep, but he also did not write anything for Baren. Bex considered this a win and sent no update.

Available slept imperfectly.

Still better than waiting.

At 7:20 a.m., Baren woke and asked, “Did available sleep?”

Lila, at the doorway with hair that suggested constitutional damage, said, “Mostly.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Cole, outside, said, “Working on it.”

“Still watched.”

“True yes.”

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

No ritual.

Toast available.

Toast used.

Toast gone.

No one made it carry the morning.

The first availability review took place at 8:30 a.m.

Baren had allowed the concept to enter adult leaving rules, and once adults had rules, they needed review dates, forms, and at least one person asking whether the form was trauma-informed enough to justify existing.

Morro killed the form.

Not entirely.

Just enough.

The first draft was titled:

Protected Minor Support Availability Continuity Review Instrument

Baren saw the title because someone left it on the printer.

The printer had betrayed everyone.

He read it and said, “No.”

Morro snatched the paper.

“Agreed.”

Lila asked, “What should it be called?”

Baren looked at her.

“Do not ask me to name adult forms.”

“Fair.”

Morro crossed out the title and wrote:

Support Check

Lila blinked.

“That is almost normal.”

“I contain multitudes,” Morro said.

Baren looked suspicious.

“Too poetic.”

Morro crossed out nothing.

The Support Check had four questions:

Does this adult still need to be available?

Who benefits from the availability?

How does the protected person control contact?

When is the next review?

Baren reviewed the safe version.

“Good.”

Then added, “What if answer is no?”

Important.

Question five:

What happens if availability ends?

The answer had to include transition, no punishment, no guilt message, no final performance, no explanation owed by the protected person, and records of how to re-request contact later if appropriate.

Baren approved.

“Available can end without dying.”

Morro looked at him.

He looked back.

“Private now.”

“Private now,” she said.

The adult version became:

Ending availability should not be framed as abandonment, punishment, closure, or moral failure. It may be an appropriate transition when support is no longer needed in that form.

Dry.

Safe.

No mugs.

Good.

School reading returned to oceans because dinosaurs had begun to feel like work.

Ms. Rowe brought the tide pool book back but skipped the waiting-for-tide section because everyone had learned.

Instead, they read about hermit crabs.

This created immediate legal trouble in Baren's face.

"They use shells that are not theirs?"

"Yes," Ms. Rowe said.

"Do they steal?"

"Usually they use empty shells."

"Usually?"

"Sometimes they fight over them."

Baren frowned.

"Hermit crabs are property disputes."

Cole, outside, said, "Finally, relatable ocean life."

Morro was not in the doorway.

Lila was.

She smiled but did not write.

Baren studied the picture of a hermit crab wearing a shell.

"Shell is shelter but not body."

"Yes."

"Can they change shells?"

"Yes."

"If they grow?"

"Yes."

He looked at the page for a long time.

Then said, "No guidance."

Ms. Rowe nodded.

"No guidance."

He read the paragraph aloud.

Corrected **abdomen** after deciding the word was "too medical for a crab."

School progress.

Not life progress.

He drew a hermit crab wearing a house that looked suspiciously like the Bellwether Club.

Then he threw it away.

Good.

At 10:00 a.m., the oversight hearing entered the phase everyone feared: lawmakers trying to sound useful.

Some succeeded.

Most did not.

One lawmaker asked whether private governance networks should be banned outright.

The legal experts explained that private mediation, family dispute resolution, restorative practices, confidential counseling, and institutional review processes could be legitimate under proper safeguards.

Morro muttered, “Do not ban hammers because someone built a gallows. Regulate hands.”

Crowe, remote, said, “That is public.”

“No.”

“Adult concept.”

“Too sharp.”

Mara asked, “Can I soften?”

Morro sighed.

The article later read:

Experts warned against treating all private resolution or restorative processes as inherently improper. The issue is not the existence of private rooms, but whether those rooms are controlled by interested adults without independent safeguards, records, reporting pathways, or meaningful ability to refuse.

“Acceptable.”

Another lawmaker asked whether minors should ever participate in restorative processes.

Dr. Rao answered remotely.

“Yes, in carefully controlled circumstances, if participation is voluntary, supported, developmentally appropriate, revocable, not tied to benefits or punishment, not controlled by interested parties, and not needed to prove adult repentance. The question is not whether a child can ever speak. The question is whether the child is free not to.”

Morro stood.

“Excellent.”

Mara’s newsroom used the quote.

Baren was not told.

He was in math, deciding that percentages were decimals wearing campaign clothes.

Percentages were unwelcome.

Ms. Rowe introduced 50%.

Baren accepted that as one-half because it had obvious receipts.

25%.

One-fourth.

75%.

Three-fourths.

100%.

Whole.

He stared at 100%.

“Too confident.”

Ms. Rowe smiled.

“It means all of something.”

“Adults misuse that.”

“Probably.”

He looked toward the cow puzzle box.

“Puzzle was 100% for breakfast yesterday.”

“Yes.”

“Then not.”

“Yes.”

“Percent can change?”

“In different moments, yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Morro was not there.

This was fortunate.

Baren completed four problems and declined the fifth.

No reason.

Accepted.

School note:

Percentages introduced. Four completed. One declined for later.

Baren approved.

“Useful.”

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole spoke first.

“Triangles today?”

Baren said, “Triangles available.”

“Used?”

“Used.”

Morro whispered to Lila, “This room has its own legal system.”

Lila whispered back, “It is more humane than most.”

Baren looked at them.

“Whisper face.”

Morro said, “Private adult commentary.”

“About me?”

“About the room.”

“Room is near me.”

“Fair. Withdrawn.”

He accepted the withdrawal.

The sandwich disappeared.

No further proceedings.

At 1:00 p.m., the first Support Check happened.

Mara.

Baren had agreed.

Mara did not attend.

That was part of the point.

The check was conducted by Lila, Dr. Patel, and Morro. Baren participated only in the part that asked what he wanted.

“Do you want Mara available for puzzle visits?”

“Yes.”

“How often?”

“Not scheduled too much.”

“What does too much mean?”

He thought.

“More than I ask.”

“Do you want her to ask?”

“Sometimes through Lila. Not every day.”

“Do you want her to bring facts?”

“One sometimes.”

“Do you want work talk?”

“No.”

“Do you want a goodbye rule?”

“If I say done, done.”

Lila nodded.

“What if Mara is sad?”

Baren looked at her.

“She takes it to her own adult.”

Morro smiled faintly.

Good.

“What if you want no visits for a while?”

“Say no. No reason.”

“Yes.”

Baren thought.

“She can be available. Not waiting.”

The Support Check recorded the adult version:

Mara Vale may remain available for occasional child-initiated or guardian-screened puzzle/social visits under no-work conditions. Contact must remain revocable. Emotional impact on adult visitor must be handled outside protected minor relationship. Review in two weeks or earlier at Baren’s request.

Baren read the safe version.

“Good.”

“Anything to change?”

“Puzzle/social sounds weird.”

“What would you call it?”

“Visits.”

The form changed.

Visits.

Morro approved.

“Plain.”

Mara received the result through Lila.

She replied:

Understood. Available, not waiting. No response needed.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

At 2:30 p.m., Crowe had his Support Check.

This one was more complicated because Crowe had religious history, adult guilt, advisory usefulness, and a proven tendency to make ocean facts spiritually suspicious.

Baren participated briefly.

“Do you want Crowe available?”

“Yes.”

“For what?”

“Plain facts sometimes. Maybe talk if I ask. No Prayer Adult.”

“Visits?”

“Sometimes. Short.”

“Can he send advisories to adults?”

“Yes, not to me.”

“Can he be sad near you?”

“No.”

Lila smiled sadly.

“What if sadness happens?”

“Then useful first means he leaves and gets adult.”

Morro translated:

Crowe may remain available for limited, screened, non-spiritual social contact if requested. No pastoral role. No religious framing. No emotional processing with Baren. Adult advisory work remains outside Baren’s care environment. Review in two weeks.

Crowe received the result.

He replied:

Understood. No pastoral role. Available through rules. No response requested.

Then, after three minutes, sent another message:

Also plain ocean only.

Baren laughed when told.

“Trying Adult.”

At 3:30 p.m., Cole’s Support Check did not go as smoothly.

Cole argued he did not need one because he was assigned.

Morro told him assignment was not emotional immunity.

Cole said he was fine.

Nurse Imani laughed so hard she had to leave the room.

Baren was not present for the adult portion.

The check asked:

Does Cole still need to be outside the door?

Who benefits?

What transition planning exists?

Who supports Cole?

How does Baren control presence?

What signs indicate the arrangement is becoming pressure?

Cole hated every question.

That meant they were good.

Baren participated later.

“Do you want Cole outside your door?”

“Yes.”

“Always?”

He thought.

“At night yes. Day maybe chair near hall.”

“Do you want to be able to ask him to move?”

“Yes.”

“Do you worry he will be sad if you ask?”

Baren looked toward the hallway.

“Yes.”

Cole closed his eyes.

Morro said nothing.

Baren continued.

“He needs to not make face.”

Cole nodded once.

“I can work on that.”

“Adult?”

“I have supervision.”

“Use it.”

“Yes.”

The Support Check recorded:

Cole Mercer remains assigned as protective witness/security presence. Night hallway presence continues at Baren’s request. Day placement may vary. Baren may ask for distance without explanation. Mercer will address emotional responses in supervision and will not make Baren responsible for reassurance. Review weekly.

Cole read it.

“Fine.”

Morro said, “That is not an approved response.”

Cole sighed.

“Understood. Available, not waiting. Still assigned. Review weekly.”

Baren approved.

“Better.”

Serena’s Support Check was already mostly in place through visitation rules.

Still, the language changed.

Available through counsel.

Visits only if Baren agrees.

No gifts unless approved.

No photos unless Baren requests and court permits.

No emotional repair requests.

No public use.

Parent therapy encouraged.

Boundary both directions.

Review every two weeks.

Baren approved.

“Far scaffolding.”

The adult version did not use that phrase.

It said:

Maternal contact remains structured, optional, revocable, and clinically supported.

Baren read it and made a face.

“Old oatmeal.”

Morro said, “Safe oatmeal.”

“Fine.”

Chronald’s Support Check was simplest.

No direct contact.

Updates only if Baren asks.

Adult accountability through counsel and court.

No emotional statements routed to Baren.

Review in thirty days.

Baren read it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Early trying.”

Lila nodded.

“Still.”

At 5:00 p.m., the oversight hearing ended for the week.

Not the investigation.

Just the hearing.

The chair closed with a statement Morro did not hate.

That was news.

“This inquiry began with public attention on a protected child. It will continue with attention on adult systems, adult records, and adult responsibilities. That is where the work belongs.”

“Good.”

Mara’s headline:

Oversight Hearing Ends Week With Focus on Adult Systems, Not Protected Minor

Dry.

Baren was told the safe version.

“Adults finished the week of hearings. They said the work belongs with adult systems.”

“Good.”

“Do you want more?”

“No.”

He thought.

“Available can sleep after hearing?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Then the cow puzzle stayed in the box.

No visit.

No completion.

No issue.

Baren looked at the Support Check summaries before bed.

Mara.

Crowe.

Cole.

Serena.

Chronald.

He placed them in the drawer.

This was a choice.

Lila watched.

“Drawer?”

“Yes. These are rules about people near me.”

“Okay.”

He closed the drawer.

Opened it.

Still there.

Closed it.

Side table unchanged.

Door half open.

Cole outside, a little farther from the door than usual because day placement had already begun changing.

Baren noticed.

“Good distance.”

Cole nodded.

“Good?”

“Yes.”

Cole’s face stayed controlled.

Good.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can available be rules?”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Can rules be kind?”

“Yes.”

“Morro?”

From the lounge, Morro said, “Under limited circumstances.”

Baren smiled.

“Available sleeps.”

“Yes.”

“Waiting watches.”

“Sometimes.”

“Tonight?”

“Available.”

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, the hearing week ended with adults pointed toward adults.

Elsewhere, defendants prepared motions and task forces prepared bulletins.

Elsewhere, support adults read rules that told them how to matter without taking.

Here, availability finally had boundaries.

And because it had boundaries, it could rest.

CHAPTER SEVENTY

Rules That Rest

Rules slept better than people.

This was unfair but useful.

By morning, the Support Checks sat in Baren’s drawer like folded scaffolding.

Mara.

Crowe.

Cole.

Serena.

Chronald.

Each adult reduced, for once, not to feeling or history or usefulness, but to rules about distance, contact, review, and what they were not allowed to ask a child to carry.

It made the drawer heavier.

Not bad heavy.

Known heavy.

Baren opened it at 7:14 a.m., checked the stack, and closed it again.

One check.

Enough.

Cole sat slightly farther from the door than usual.

Not far.

Farther.

The chair was angled so Baren could see him if he looked, but Cole was not directly in the line of the doorway.

Good distance.

Baren had noticed the night before and approved. Cole had accepted without face-making. That mattered more than Cole wanted it to matter.

Nurse Imani knocked.

“Come in.”

She entered with the schedule.

Breakfast.

School reading.

Math optional.

Courtyard.

Visit optional.

Support Check review only if requested.

Adult briefing only if requested.

No public obligations.

Baren read it.

“Rules rested?”

“Yes,” Lila said from the doorway.

“Adults?”

“Somewhat.”

Morro appeared behind her, coffee in hand.

“Define somewhat.”

Baren looked at her.

“You slept?”

“Some.”

“Did you write rules at night?”

Morro paused.

“No new rules.”

“Edited?”

“Briefly.”

Baren considered.

“Trying Adult.”

“Under review.”

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

Toast had survived many legal eras and remained toast.

This was why Baren trusted it.

Mostly.

At 8:30 a.m., the task force attempted to rest and failed immediately.

Not because of crisis.

Because of summary.

Adults loved summaries after hearings. They wanted to gather what had happened, name themes, prepare next steps, circulate bullet points, and feel the week become manageable enough to print.

Morro distrusted summaries almost as much as endings.

A summary could become a lid.

The first draft arrived titled:

Key Lessons From Week One Oversight Proceedings

Morro responded:

No lessons. Findings and pending questions.

The title changed:

Findings and Pending Questions From Week One Oversight Proceedings

Better.

The draft listed:

Private governance mechanisms.

Adult records.

Worker-witness protections.

Former-minor choice.

Decision-support vendors.

Religious and restorative safeguards.

Campaign privacy testing.

Parent paperwork.

Support adult leaving rules.

Technology procurement.

Compensation.

International coordination.

Morro crossed out every sentence that began with **we learned**.

“We did not learn,” she said. “The harmed people already knew. The records confirmed.”

Lila wrote that down.

Morro looked at her.

“Adult room.”

“Yes.”

The summary became:

Records and testimony confirmed concerns long raised by harmed people, workers, dissenters, clinicians, and advocates.

Mara used it in her weekly analysis.

No child.

No protected minor as teacher.

No “case taught us.”

The adult world could be educated without making a child its schoolhouse.

Baren was not told.

He was reading about ocean currents.

Currents moved water without asking headlines for permission.

Good water.

Ocean currents caused only moderate adult danger.

Ms. Rowe explained that currents could carry nutrients, heat, animals, and sometimes objects across long distances.

Baren listened carefully.

“So movement can happen without deciding?”

“Sometimes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Can things get carried?”

“Yes.”

“Can they also swim?”

“Yes.”

He thought.

“Hard to know which.”

“Sometimes.”

Lila sat nearby, hands folded, not writing.

Baren noticed and allowed it.

Ms. Rowe continued.

Some animals used currents to travel.

Some were swept.

Some moved between current and choice.

Baren closed the book.

“Ocean is too court today.”

“Dinosaurs?”

“No. Math.”

Ms. Rowe accepted the pivot.

Percentages returned.

Baren did five problems.

Declined one.

No reason.

Accepted.

School note:

Percentages practiced. Five completed. One declined for later.

Baren approved.

“School progress.”

“Not life progress,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Good.”

At 10:00 a.m., Mara’s newsroom published the weekly analysis.

Headline:

Week One Hearings Confirm Private Governance Patterns Across Adult Systems

Morro approved the headline without insult, which Mara’s editor treated as emotional hazard pay.

The piece summarized adult records and hearing themes.

It quoted worker counsel.

It quoted Dr. Rao.

It quoted the procurement witness.

It quoted the parent witness.

It quoted the hearing chair.

It did not quote Baren.

It did not mention toast.

It did not mention puzzles.

It did not mention socks, drawers, side tables, or Support Checks except in general professional terms.

It ended:

The work now moves away from the protected child whose case first drew public attention and toward the adults, institutions, vendors, records, and practices that made such protection necessary.

Morro read it twice.

“Good.”

Mara, on the newsroom call, looked nervous.

“That sounded like an ending.”

“It sounded like relocation.”

“Acceptable?”

“Yes.”

Mara exhaled.

Relocation was safer than closure.

The work moved.

The child did not.

At 11:00 a.m., Baren asked for a Mara visit.

This was new.

Usually visits were offered through schedule or requested after lunch. Today he asked before the visit window.

“Puzzle?” Lila asked.

“No.”

“Fact?”

“Maybe.”

“Do you want me to ask if she is available?”

“Yes. Available, not waiting.”

Lila sent the request.

Mara replied eighteen minutes later, not immediately.

This was good.

Immediate replies could feel like waiting with shoes on.

Available at 1:30 or tomorrow. No pressure.

Baren read the response.

“Good.”

“Which do you want?”

“Tomorrow.”

Lila sent:

Tomorrow. No response needed.

Mara sent no response.

Baren nodded.

“She did good.”

“Yes.”

Morro looked pleased.

The Support Check had worked.

Not as theory.

As timing.

Rules rested because rules had something to do.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole, who had saved geometry all morning, said, “Rectangles remain available.”

Baren nodded.

“Used.”

Morro did not object.

The sandwich disappeared.

Then Baren asked, “Can rules be too available?”

Lila looked up.

“Yes.”

“How?”

“If adults keep showing you rules when you did not ask, the rules become pressure.”

“Then rules need drawer too.”

Morro’s hand twitched.

Baren looked at her.

“You may ask.”

“May we use a professional version?”

“Yes. Support rules.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Protective rules should be accessible without becoming constant reminders of harm or obligation. The protected person should know how to use the rules, but adults should avoid repeatedly displaying, invoking, or explaining them in ways that create pressure.

Baren approved.

“Rules can be drawer.”

Morro asked with her eyes.

“Private,” he said.

Morro nodded.

Rules could be drawer.

Known.

Reachable.

Not on the wall.

At 1:30 p.m., no Mara visit happened.

This was the point.

Baren played no puzzle.

Read no fact.

Watched no ocean video.

He went to the courtyard and looked at the sad maple.

A new leaf had fallen.

He ignored it.

Cole stood nearby, farther than before.

Good distance.

Baren said, "You are less door now."

Cole looked at him.

"Yes."

"Bad?"

"Different."

"Good different?"

Cole thought.

"Working different."

Baren nodded.

"You still available?"

"Yes."

"Not waiting?"

Cole took a breath.

"Working on it."

"Good."

They stood quietly.

The sad maple continued its leaf policy.

No one intervened.

At 2:30 p.m., Crowe sent a request through Lila.

Not to visit.

To retire his scheduled ocean facts unless Baren asked.

Good.

The message read:

Crowe asks to remain available for plain ocean or dinosaur facts only if Baren asks. No scheduled facts. No response needed.

Baren smiled.

“He learned.”

“Yes.”

“Tell him accepted. No response.”

Lila sent it.

Crowe did not respond.

Then, thirty seconds later, he started typing.

Then stopped.

Morro, watching the shared channel, whispered, “Fight it.”

No message came.

Baren later heard that Crowe almost responded but did not.

“Trying Adult.”

“Very,” Lila said.

At 3:00 p.m., the first institutional compliance plan arrived using the leaving rules correctly.

A private school proposed that a teacher who had supported a student during a misconduct investigation remain contactable through the student’s independent counselor for thirty days, then review. No direct messages. No emotional goodbye. No requirement that the student explain whether they wanted contact. No public mention.

Morro read it.

“Good.”

Lila smiled.

“Actually good?”

“Actually good.”

The school had also provided substitute support options in case the student did not want that teacher available anymore.

Better.

Dr. Rao approved.

The public guidance desk marked it as an anonymized example:

Supportive adults can remain available without direct pressure when contact is routed through independent support, reviewed over time, and paired with alternatives.

Baren was not told.

The wall moved again.

Without him.

Good.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena requested no visit because of therapy again.

Baren received the update.

“Good therapy?”

“She did not ask us to tell you details.”

“Good.”

“Do you want to send anything?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

Then:

“Actually, no response is good.”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

No message sent.

Serena’s boundary stood without needing approval from the child.

That was also progress.

Chronald sent production confirmation to adult channel.

Not relayed.

Bex sent no note.

Good.

At 5:00 p.m., Victor Elysium’s motion hearing was scheduled.

Not held.

Scheduled.

Two weeks out.

The public reacted as if scheduling were either proof of innocence or collapse of prosecution, depending on which kind of misunderstanding paid their rent.

Mara’s newsroom published a process explainer.

Baren was not told.

He was building a tower from paper cups.

Not symbolic.

He knocked it down himself.

Still not symbolic.

Cole looked like he wanted to say something about demolition.

Baren pointed.

“No.”

Cole nodded.

“Private cup event.”

“Better.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate most of it.

Again.

This trend concerned him.

“Maybe macaroni is improving or I am changing.”

Nurse Imani said, “Both possible.”

“Do not write.”

“I won’t.”

Morro whispered to Lila, “This entire room is now hostile to documentation.”

Lila whispered back, “Appropriately.”

After dinner, Baren asked for the cow puzzle box.

Lila brought it.

He opened it.

All pieces inside.

He did not start.

He looked at the pieces.

Then closed the box.

“Available.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Sleeping?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He returned the box to the shelf.

Before bed, the drawer got one check.

Support Checks still there.

Framework order.

Learning plan.

Dinosaur boots photo.

Leaf envelope.

Private notes.

Blank envelope.

All there.

Closed.

One check.

Side table held fewer things now because Baren had thrown away the breakfast card after dinner.

Not angry.

Done.

Ocean card stayed.

Shark drawing stayed.

Ordinary pencil stayed.

Parrotfish fact under shark stayed, apparently serving a sentence.

Octopus fact near table stayed.

Door half open.

Cole outside at good distance.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, leaving some sentences unwritten because rules, too, needed rest.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can tomorrow be just available?"

"Yes," Lila said.

"No plan?"

"There will be a schedule."

"Schedule can be available too."

"Yes."

"Not waiting."

"Not waiting."

He closed his eyes.

"Good."

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, summaries became findings and pending questions instead of lessons.

Elsewhere, support adults learned not to reply.

Elsewhere, institutions learned that rules could be reachable without becoming walls around the person they protected.

Here, the puzzle slept in its box.

The rules slept in the drawer.

The adults slept badly but better.

And Baren slept because available, finally, had stopped staring at him.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-ONE

Just Available

Just available lasted until 8:12 a.m.

That was not failure.

That was Tuesday.

Tuesday arrived wearing ordinary clothes and carrying adult filings under one arm, school worksheets under the other, and a damp smell from the courtyard because the sad maple had apparently negotiated with weather overnight.

Not rain.

Not enough for drama.

Just damp.

Morro distrusted damp.

“It encourages reflection,” she said.

Baren, eating cereal from the blue bowl, looked at her.

“Weather is not doing legal work.”

“It has a history.”

“Your history.”

Morro conceded this with her coffee.

“Fair.”

Cole sat at good distance outside the door, no longer directly framed by the hallway like a guard in a painting. The chair was turned slightly sideways. Still present. Less watching.

Baren approved the angle without saying so.

Lila noticed without making it a thing.

Nurse Imani noticed without making it a note.

Morro noticed and looked away before she noticed too much.

That was how just available worked.

Nothing stared.

Nothing leaned.

Nothing asked to be appreciated.

The cow puzzle box rested on the shelf.

The drawer stayed closed.

The schedule sat on the small table, face down because Baren had already reviewed it once.

Breakfast.

School.

Courtyard optional.

Visit optional.

Adult briefing optional.

No public obligations.

Support rules available.

Not waiting.

At 8:12 a.m., the first filing arrived.

A defense motion from Dahlia Voss.

Of course.

Dahlia had waited until the adults began resting rules before introducing a document that treated rest as evidence of overreach.

Her counsel filed a motion titled:

Emergency Petition to Preserve Future Autonomy Rights and Prevent Permanent Narrative Lock-In

Morro read the title and said, “She still thinks fonts are law.”

Lila took the filing.

The motion argued that Baren’s protection structure had become too restrictive, that adult gatekeepers were controlling future access, that records sealed until eighteen might be depriving him of formative truth, and that continued prevention of direct contact from certain family and trust representatives risked “foreclosing meaningful self-authorship.”

Morro closed her eyes.

“Self-authorship.”

Crowe, on remote call, whispered, “That phrase owns a scarf.”

Morro said, “Do not help.”

The motion did not ask for immediate contact.

It asked for preservation of Dahlia’s future ability to petition.

It asked the court to require that Baren be informed, at developmentally appropriate intervals, that alternative adult narratives existed.

It asked that the sealed eighteen-year package not be treated as the only future source.

It asked to appoint an “autonomy liaison.”

Lila said, “No.”

Dr. Rao, added to the call, said, “Absolutely not.”

Morro said, “A future-grooming officer with softer shoes.”

The room went quiet.

Accurate.

Mara, who had received the public docket alert, messaged:

Is this real?

Morro replied:

Painfully.

Baren was not told yet.

Because just available included not interrupting cereal with Dahlia.

School began with math.

Baren had requested it.

This surprised Ms. Rowe, who had learned not to show surprise around math because math interpreted attention as a warrant.

Percentages again.

50%.

25%.

75%.

100%.

Then 10%.

Baren accepted 10% because it was “one of ten, but wearing business clothes.”

Ms. Rowe wrote nothing funny.

Good.

He solved six problems.

Declined two.

No reason.

Accepted.

Then he asked, “Can adults take percent of a person?”

Ms. Rowe looked toward Lila.

Lila sat forward.

“What do you mean?”

“Like campaign measured absence. Percent liked father not showing kid. Percent liked privacy. Percent liked story.”

Morro, who had been passing the doorway with coffee, stopped so abruptly the coffee almost filed a complaint.

Lila answered carefully.

“Adults can measure public reactions to ideas about a person. That does not mean they own that part of the person.”

“Does measuring make it theirs?”

“No.”

“Does using the measuring make harm?”

“It can.”

He looked at his worksheet.

“Percent can steal if adult uses it wrong.”

Morro breathed in.

Baren looked at her.

“Ask.”

“May we use an adult version for campaign and data guidance?”

“Yes.”

Morro translated:

Measurement does not create ownership. Institutions, campaigns, vendors, or family systems should not treat measured public reaction to a person's privacy, absence, image, story, refusal, forgiveness, or future participation as permission to use that person.

Baren read it later.

“Good. Add kids.”

Lila added:

This is especially important when the person measured is a child, former minor, patient, student, worker, complainant, or dependent person.

“Good.”

School continued.

Math had tried to become law and, unfortunately, partly succeeded.

Medium useful had returned without asking.

Baren tolerated it.

For one sentence.

At 10:00 a.m., Judge Havel scheduled a sealed hearing on Dahlia's motion.

Not emergency.

Morro enjoyed that.

The court order said:

The petition is calendared in ordinary course. The court will not characterize future access, sealed records, or contact restrictions as emergencies absent specific evidence of imminent harm.

Morro read it twice.

“Good.”

Dahlia had tried to make the future urgent.

The court made it wait in line.

The order also appointed no autonomy liaison.

Instead, Judge Havel requested briefing from child counsel, clinical counsel, prosecution, defense, and the existing special evidence master on how future-access rights should be preserved without creating present pressure.

That was real.

Hard.

Not Dahlia's alone.

Lila sighed.

“She found a legitimate seam.”

“Bad actors often do.”

The sealed eighteen-year package existed because future Baren mattered.

But future Baren could not become a door through which present adults entered.

There had to be a bridge.

There had to be guards.

There had to be no shrine.

Dr. Rao said, “Future access should be information architecture, not emotional architecture.”

Morro pointed.

“Public-adjacent. Adult.”

Lila drafted the response framework:

Future Baren should have access to records about his life.

Present Baren should not be burdened by adult narratives before he wants them or is clinically ready.

No adult should preserve influence by planting recurring reminders.

Sealed records should be indexed neutrally.

A future access plan should include counsel, clinical support, choice, staged review, and refusal.

The existence of alternative narratives does not require delivery of manipulative narratives.

The future right to know cannot be converted into the present duty to receive.

Morro stopped.

“That last one.”

Lila looked at her.

“Yes.”

Baren would need to approve if used publicly because it came too close.

Not now.

He was in school.

The sentence waited.

Available.

Not waiting.

Trying.

Mara’s newsroom faced its own problem.

Dahlia’s motion was public enough to report.

Dangerous enough to distort.

The first headline draft from a junior editor read:

Dahlia Voss Claims Child’s Protectors Are Controlling His Future

Mara said, “No.”

The second:

Voss Seeks Future Autonomy Protections in Sump Case

Mara said, “Too much her framing.”

The third:

Court to Review Future Access Rules for Protected Minor Records

Mara paused.

Better.

Boring.

Less Dahlia.

More court.

The article explained that Voss had filed a petition, that the court refused emergency treatment, and that the legal issue involved balancing future access to personal records against present protection from pressure.

No speculation about Baren's wishes.

No "what should he know?"

No poll.

No expert panel asking whether children deserve truth, as if truth were a brick adults could throw through a nursery window and call sunlight.

Morro approved the article.

"Good."

Mara replied:

I wanted to set the headline on fire.

Morro wrote back:

Boring water first.

Mara accepted.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole, who had been quiet all morning, said, "Triangles remain future-accessible."

Baren stared at him.

Morro closed her eyes.

Lila looked at the ceiling.

Nurse Imani left the room.

Cole reconsidered his life.

Baren said, "No."

Cole nodded.

"Withdrawn."

"Bad geometry."

"Agreed."

Baren ate half the sandwich.

Then asked, "Did Dahlia do adult thing?"

Lila paused.

He had heard the name from the hallway earlier.

Not ideal.

Not disaster.

“Yes. She filed something in court.”

“What kind?”

“A request about future access to records and adult narratives.”

His face changed.

“She wants future me.”

Morro sat down across from him.

“Yes.”

No soft lie.

Good.

“Does she get?”

“No. She gets process. Not you.”

“Court?”

“Yes.”

“Rules even for future?”

“Yes.”

He looked at his plate.

“Do I have to decide now?”

“No.”

“Do I have to hear her now?”

“No.”

“Does eighteen me have to?”

“No. Future you can choose.”

He thought.

“What if future me is stupid?”

Morro blinked.

Lila almost smiled.

Nurse Imani returned at the exact wrong time and kept walking.

Baren continued.

“What if future me thinks adult sad is true?”

Lila said, “Then future you should have support, records, and time, not just sad adult words.”

Morro added, “Future access plans can be designed so information comes with context, not pressure.”

Baren nodded slowly.

“Future me gets lawyer cereal?”

Morro stared.

Cole whispered, “Strong product.”

Baren looked at him.

“Better geometry.”

Morro answered, “Future you can have counsel, clinical support, and plain records.”

“Lawyer cereal.”

“In professional terms, yes.”

He considered.

“Good.”

Then:

“The future right to know is not present duty to listen.”

Morro went still.

Lila closed her eyes.

Baren looked at them.

“You already had that.”

Lila nodded.

“Close.”

“Use it. Adult future rules.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes. Other kids. Future them too.”

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

A future right to know should not become a present duty to receive. Future-access plans for protected minors should preserve records, context, counsel, and support without creating recurring pressure, symbolic waiting, or emotional claims on the child before the child chooses to engage.

Baren approved the safe version.

“Good. Add no sad package.”

Morro translated:

Future materials should not be designed as emotional claims, redemption attempts, loyalty tests, or delayed persuasion.

Baren nodded.

“Safe.”

At 1:30 p.m., Mara did not visit because he had chosen tomorrow.

Good.

No request.

No replacement.

No adult tried to fill the slot.

Baren sat with the cow puzzle box.

He opened it.

Pieces available.

He took out three edge pieces.

Not the sky piece.

Placed them on the table.

Then put them back.

Lila watched from nearby.

No comment.

He closed the box.

“Future puzzle.”

“Yes.”

“Not waiting.”

“Yes.”

“Available.”

“Yes.”

He pushed the box away.

Good.

At 2:00 p.m., the support rules expanded to future records.

Dr. Rao chaired the clinical subcommittee.

She hated the phrase **truth delivery**.

“Truth is not a package delivery service,” she said.

Morro approved.

The future-access plan draft used:

Record Access Pathway

Dry.

Good.

The pathway required:

Neutral index of sealed materials.

No emotionally loaded cover letters from interested adults without separate labeling and review.

Clear categories: court records, medical/clinical records, educational records, family communications, institutional records, adult statements, contested claims, media records.

Right to decline.

Right to pause.

Right to partial access.

Right to counsel.

Right to clinical support.

Right to bring a chosen support person.

Right to receive summaries before originals.

Right to know who created each document and why.

Right to see corrections beside claims.

Right to refuse direct letters while still accessing factual records.

Review before eighteen and after eighteen without automatic delivery.

No countdown.

No birthday ceremony.

No “when you are ready” package from interested adults.

Morro underlined that twice.

Dahlia had wanted a future door.

The court would build an index.

Doors were theatrical.

Indexes were harder to seduce.

At 3:30 p.m., Baren requested courtyard.

Damp had become less damp.

The sad maple smelled like wet bark and municipal resignation.

Cole stood at good distance.

Baren sat on the bench.

“Future me is weird.”

Cole said, “All future people are.”

“Are you future Cole?”

“Unfortunately.”

“Was past Cole stupid?”

Cole thought.

“Yes.”

Baren nodded.

“Same.”

They sat.

After a minute, Baren asked, “Do you think future me will want Dahlia letter?”

Cole did not answer quickly.

Good.

"I think future you should get to decide with people who do not want anything from the answer."

Baren looked at him.

"That is good."

Cole looked alarmed.

"Private?"

"Private."

"Thank God."

Baren smiled.

"No Prayer Adult."

"Figure of speech."

"Still watched."

"True yes."

A leaf fell.

No one picked it up.

At 4:30 p.m., Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Five minutes.

Baren told her Dahlia wanted future him.

Serena's face tightened with something old and hot.

She put it elsewhere before it reached him.

Good.

"Court will handle it," she said.

"Do you want future me?"

She looked at him.

"Yes."

Wrong answer if left alone.

She continued.

"But wanting is mine to carry. You do not owe me future access. I can stay available through rules."

Baren watched her.

"Therapy?"

"Yes."

"Good therapy."

"Yes."

He thought.

"Do you want to write future letter?"

Serena's eyes filled.

"I might. But only if the rules allow it, and only if it is labeled as mine, not something you have to read."

"Good."

Timer buzzed.

He said, "Done."

She stood.

At the door, she said, "Future you does not owe present me."

Baren looked at her.

"Too good."

"I know."

"Therapy?"

"Yes."

"Tell therapy medium good."

"I will."

She left.

No extra.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald's counsel asked whether Chronald could submit a future statement to the Record Access Pathway.

Lila forwarded it to Morro.

Morro said, "Of course he can ask. Of course he wants."

The answer:

Not now.

Future statements from interested adults would be addressed after the court approved categories, labeling, review, and anti-pressure safeguards. No emotional letters accepted into sealed child materials without structure.

Chronald's counsel replied:

Understood.

Bex sent no commentary.

Good.

Adult wanting stayed adult.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate less than half.

No comment.

After dinner, Lila gave him the safe update.

"Court will review Dahlia's request in ordinary time. You do not have to decide anything now. Adult lawyers will argue about record access rules."

"Lawyer cereal."

“Yes.”

“Future me gets not-sad index.”

“Yes.”

“Can index have boring names?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He looked at Morro.

“No birthday ceremony.”

“Absolutely not.”

“No countdown.”

“No.”

“No sealed cake.”

Morro looked offended.

“I would resign.”

“Good.”

He seemed relieved.

Not happy.

Relieved.

Different.

Before bed, drawer check.

One.

Support Checks still there.

Framework order.

Learning plan.

Dinosaur boots photo.

Leaf envelope.

Private notes.

Blank envelope.

He added nothing.

Then he asked for a new folder.

Lila brought one.

Plain.

No color choice.

No label.

He wrote on it:

FUTURE — NOT NOW

He placed nothing inside.

Then put it in the drawer.

Morro watched from the doorway.

Her face did not move.

Baren closed the drawer.

Opened it once.

Future — Not Now was still there.

Closed it.

Side table unchanged.

Door half open.

Cole at good distance.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, already drafting future-access rules that would make no one cry at a podium, if there was any justice left in stationery.

Before sleep, Baren said, “Future can be available.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Not waiting.”

“Yes.”

“Not birthday.”

“Yes.”

“Not Dahlia.”

“Not Dahlia’s.”

“Not mine yet.”

“Not yet.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, Dahlia tried to dress future pressure as autonomy.

Elsewhere, courts converted urgency into scheduling.

Elsewhere, adults began building an index instead of a shrine.

Here, the future went into a folder with nothing inside it.

Not empty.

Available.

Not now.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-TWO

The Index

The index was less beautiful than a sealed letter.

That was the point.

Letters wanted candles.

Letters wanted trembling hands and pauses before opening.

Letters wanted a person to sit at the edge of a bed, older now, wiser now, wounded in a cinematically acceptable way, and finally learn what adults had saved for him.

Indexes wanted tabs.

Indexes wanted dates.

Indexes wanted creator, category, source, custody, dispute status, access level, summary available, original available, and whether any interested adult had attempted to make the document emotionally contagious.

Morro loved indexes.

Not romantically.

She did not love anything romantically before noon.

But professionally, structurally, and with the deep suspicion of someone who knew beauty often arrived to destroy chain of custody.

The Record Access Pathway draft now included an index template so boring that even the font appeared to regret ambition.

Record ID.

Creator.

Date Created.

Category.

Interested Party?

Factual/Opinion/Mixed.

Contested?

Corrections Available?

Recommended Access Stage.

Support Needed?

Notes.

No photographs in the index.

No excerpts designed to hook.

No teaser phrases.

No “when you are ready.”

No “for your eyes someday.”

No “your mother wanted you to know.”

No “Dahlia preserved this because she believed in your future.”

Absolutely not.

Morro wrote **NO BAIT** across the margin of the first draft.

Lila looked over.

“Too blunt?”

“Not blunt enough.”

Dr. Rao joined the call and approved the concept.

“Future access indexes should not be emotionally baited.”

Morro pointed.

“Public.”

The guidance draft gained:

A future-access index should identify what exists without emotionally baiting the protected person into access. Descriptions should be neutral, accurate, and sufficient for informed choice, not written to create urgency, guilt, fear, loyalty, or curiosity pressure.

Baren was still asleep when the line was written.

That mattered.

Adults had begun doing good work while the child slept.

That was called improvement.

Baren woke at 7:31 a.m. and did not ask about the index.

He asked about pancakes.

This caused more disruption than a federal subpoena.

“Pancakes?” Nurse Imani asked.

“Yes.”

Morro appeared in the doorway as if breakfast requests triggered her jurisdiction.

“Pancakes are an event food.”

Baren narrowed his eyes.

“They are flat bread circles.”

“They imply weekend.”

“It is Wednesday.”

“Exactly.”

Baren considered this.

“Pancakes can be Wednesday.”

Nurse Imani nodded.

“Pancakes can be Wednesday.”

Morro looked betrayed by carbohydrate law.

Cole, at good distance two, said, “Circles entering evidence.”

Baren pointed.

“No geometry before syrup.”

Cole bowed his head.

“Withdrawn.”

Pancakes arrived.

Small.

Three.

Butter present, not shiny.

Syrup on the side because syrup was a liquid with ambition.

Baren poured a little.

Ate one pancake.

Half of another.

Stopped.

“Pancakes can be Wednesday.”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Do not write.”

“No.”

Morro stared at her coffee.

The future folder stayed in the drawer.

No one invited it to breakfast.

School writing returned after pancakes.

Ms. Rowe brought a harmless prompt and then immediately apologized to the room with her eyes because no prompt was harmless anymore.

Make a list of five things in your room.

Baren approved.

“Index?”

“List,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Difference?”

“An index helps find things. A list just names things.”

He thought.

“Adults lie with both.”

“Yes.”

Good teacher.

He wrote:

pencil drawertablesocksdoor

Then he stopped.

“Five.”

“Yes.”

He looked at the list.

“Door is half.”

“It can still be a thing.”

“Good.”

Ms. Rowe asked, “Do you want to add details?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

School note:

List completed. Five items. No details requested.

Baren approved.

Morro was not in the doorway.

Lila had again blocked her with the invisible power of child-lawyer eyebrows.

At 9:30 a.m., the index committee made its first mistake.

A well-meaning clinician proposed that future materials include emotional temperature labels.

Potentially comforting.

Potentially distressing.

Potentially identity-relevant.

Morro said, “No.”

The clinician looked startled.

“Warnings can help.”

“Warnings can help. Predictions can steer.”

Dr. Rao nodded.

“Use content advisories, not emotional forecasts.”

Lila said, “Tell him what is in the room, not what he is supposed to feel when he enters.”

Morro wrote:

CONTENT ADVISORY, NOT FEELING PROPHECY.

Public.

Adult.

The pathway changed.

Instead of **potentially comforting**, the label read:

Contains statement from parent.

Instead of **potentially distressing**, it read:

Contains contested allegation involving institutional conduct.

Instead of **identity-relevant**, it read:

Contains information about family history.

The feeling belonged to future Baren.

The index only got facts.

Baren reviewed the safe explanation later.

“Adults wanted to label how future me might feel?”

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Corrected.”

“Good. Feelings are not titles.”

Morro placed both hands flat on the table.

“May we use—”

“Yes. Future rules.”

The guidance kept the usable part:

Feelings are not titles. Future-access materials should describe content neutrally rather than forecasting how the protected person will feel. Content advisories may warn about subject matter; they should not prescribe comfort, distress, identity meaning, or emotional importance.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Then:

“Do not label pancakes comforting.”

“No.”

At 10:30 a.m., Mara’s newsroom received a leak.

Not from Dahlia.

From someone trying to hurt Dahlia by helping too much.

The leak contained a partial copy of a proposed future letter attributed to Dahlia, written in the polished voice of someone who believed manipulation was more ethical if formatted as grief.

Mara did not open the whole file.

She stopped at the first line:

My dear Baren, if this reaches you, it is because lesser adults failed to trust the part of you I always saw—

Mara closed it.

“No.”

Her editor looked up.

“No?”

“No.”

“Authentic?”

“Maybe.”

“Newsworthy?”

“Yes.”

“Usable?”

“No.”

They called counsel.

They called Morro.

Morro’s reply arrived in three words:

Do not publish.

Mara already knew.

The newsroom published instead:

Newsroom Declines to Publish Purported Future Letter Involving Protected Minor

The article said a document had been received, that its authenticity had not been verified, and that publication would risk amplifying an interested adult’s attempted future claim on a protected minor. The newsroom had provided the material to court officers under seal.

No excerpts.

Not even the first line.

Especially not the first line.

“Correct.”

Baren was not told during school.

Leakage did not get to choose the time.

At noon, lunch was soup.

Again.

Baren looked at the bowl.

“Kitchen is testing me.”

Nurse Imani said, “Possibly.”

He ate none.

“Not now.”

Soup left.

No guilt.

No replacement demanded.

After lunch, Lila asked if he wanted the adult update.

“Any adult caught?”

“No new arrests.”

“Any wall moved?”

“Yes. Future index rules improved.”

“Any Dahlia?”

Lila paused.

“Yes. Someone leaked what may be part of a future letter. It was not published. It was sent to court.”

Baren went very still.

Morro sat down.

No one crowded.

Baren asked, “Did adults read it?”

“Mara saw a small part and stopped. Court officers will handle it under seal.”

“Did you read?”

“No,” Lila said.

Morro said, “No.”

“Does it go in future folder?”

“Not unless the court decides how interested-adult statements are handled. It may be excluded, sealed separately, or labeled.”

“Was it trying to get me?”

Lila answered honestly.

“Yes.”

Baren looked at the drawer.

“Not now means not through news.”

“Yes.”

Morro added, “Not now means not through leaks.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Then:

“Leaked future is still present.”

Morro closed her eyes.

Baren looked at her.

“Yes. Adult rules.”

The pathway gained:

Attempts to leak, preview, quote, summarize, or publicize future-access materials convert future information into present pressure. Courts and responsible institutions should treat such attempts as potential violations of protective purpose, even when framed as transparency or concern for autonomy.

Baren approved the safe version.

“Good. Leak is sneaky waiting.”

Morro did not ask.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited because Baren requested her after the update.

This time there was no puzzle.

No fact at first.

She entered carefully, like someone whose usefulness had nearly become a wound.

Baren sat in the common room.

“You saw line?”

Mara nodded.

“One line.”

“Stopped?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because it was written to pull.”

He looked at her.

“Did it pull?”

“Yes.”

“What did you do?”

“Closed it. Called adults. Did not publish.”

“Good.”

She swallowed.

“I am sorry it came to us.”

“Did you send it?”

“No.”

“Then not yours.”

“Still my newsroom.”

“Yes.”

“Trying Adult.”

“Yes.”

He looked toward the cow puzzle box.

“Fact.”

Mara took a breath.

“Some octopuses can open jars.”

Baren stared.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Already suspicious because octopus.”

“Fair.”

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

He thought.

“Jar is not drawer.”

“No.”

“Good.”

The visit lasted eight minutes.

He did not ask about the line.

She did not offer.

Available held.

At 2:30 p.m., Judge Havel issued a preservation order regarding the leak.

The order prohibited publication by parties, required submission of copies to the special evidence master, directed investigation into source and chain of custody, and warned that future-access materials were subject to protective purpose regardless of whether physically inside the sealed package yet.

Morro admired that last part.

“Protective purpose follows the thing.”

Lila said, “Public?”

Morro looked toward Baren’s hallway.

Adult concept.

But close.

They waited until safe update.

Baren listened.

“Court said leak materials are protected even if not in future folder yet?”

“Yes.”

“Because what they are trying to do?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Purpose sticks.”

Morro made a small sound.

Baren pointed.

“Adult rules.”

The court guidance draft gained:

Protective handling may depend not only on where a document is stored, but on what it is designed or likely to do. Materials created as future claims, interested-adult statements, or delayed persuasion attempts should not evade protection merely because they are leaked, copied, or held outside the official sealed file.

Baren approved.

“Good. Purpose sticks is clearer but too sticky.”

“No stickers,” Morro said.

At 3:30 p.m., Crowe requested permission to send no facts for two days.

Lila showed Baren.

“He asks not to send facts?”

“Yes.”

“Good. Facts can sleep.”

Reply:

Accepted. No response needed.

Crowe did not respond.

Heroic.

Morro sent him a private adult message:

That was correct.

Crowe responded:

Thank you—

Then deleted it.

Then sent nothing.

Morro smiled.

Terrifyingly.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena requested a visit.

Baren said yes.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

She entered looking like she had learned of the leak and placed her anger in a locked cabinet.

Good.

Baren asked, “Did you ever write future letter?”

She answered carefully.

“I have written things in therapy. They are not for you unless rules later say and you choose.”

“Good.”

“Nothing from me should reach you through a leak.”

“Good.”

“Nothing from anyone should.”

“Good.”

She paused.

“I am angry.”

He looked at her.

“At me?”

“No. Not at you.”

“Where anger goes?”

“Therapy. Counsel. Adults.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

No extra.

At the door, she said, “Not now means I protect not now too.”

Baren considered.

“That is good.”

“Too good?”

“Medium.”

“I will take medium.”

She left.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald’s counsel submitted a notice disavowing any involvement in the leak and supporting investigation.

Morro read it.

“Self-serving.”

Lila nodded.

“Still useful.”

“Yes.”

Bex separately provided a campaign archive search showing no copy of Dahlia’s purported letter in campaign systems.

Not absolution.

Baren was not told.

He had enough Dahlia for one day.

Dinner was grilled cheese because soup had failed lunch.

Straight cut.

Cole said nothing.

Baren looked at him.

“No geometry?”

“Not now.”

Baren smiled.

“Good.”

After dinner, Baren asked for the future folder.

Lila brought it.

He opened the drawer.

Removed **FUTURE** — **NOT NOW**.

Inside sat the safe Record Access Pathway summary.

Only that.

He looked at it.

Then placed a blank sheet behind it.

“What is that?” Lila asked.

“Space.”

“For what?”

“Future me can write first if he wants.”

Morro, in the doorway, looked like she had been struck by a procedural comet.

Baren saw.

“Private.”

Morro nodded slowly.

“Private.”

He closed the folder.

Put it back.

Opened the drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Before bed, side table check.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish fact under shark.

Octopus fact near table, now suspicious because jar fact existed.

No new cards.

Good.

Door half open.

Cole at good distance two.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, rewriting leak protocols with the focused fury of a woman who believed even manipulation deserved filing numbers before execution.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can adults protect not now?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Even if they want later?”

“Yes.”

“Can later wait without staring?”

“Yes.”

“Can future me write first?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

He closed his eyes.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, a leaked future tried to become present.

Elsewhere, a newsroom closed the jar before the octopus got out.

Elsewhere, courts learned that purpose could stick to a document even outside the file.

Here, the future folder held a summary and a blank page.

The first word, if it ever came, would not belong to Dahlia.

It would belong to whoever Baren became.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-THREE

The First Word

The blank page changed the drawer.

It gave the black path its first object: not a prophecy, not a record, not a statement — space.

Not loudly.

Blank pages rarely announced themselves. That was how they survived adults.

The future folder had held one safe summary and nothing else. That had been correct. Then Baren added a blank sheet behind it, and suddenly the folder had a direction that did not belong to Dahlia, Chronald, Serena, the court, the trust, the campaign, the church, the lab, the vendors, the donors, the panels, the witnesses, the experts, or the future-access committee.

A blank page did not say, read me.

It said, perhaps someday you may write.

That was different.

Morro spent the next morning pretending not to think about the blank page.

She failed.

Baren noticed during breakfast.

“You have blank-page face.”

Morro looked up from coffee.

“I have several faces.”

“That one is folder.”

Cole, at good distance two, said, “Confirmed.”

Morro ignored him with appellate dignity.

Baren ate cereal from the blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

No future.

No Dahlia.

No leaked letter.

Just cereal and a judge trying not to be emotionally outmaneuvered by paper.

After three bites, Baren said, “Blank page is not assignment.”

Lila, who had been reviewing the day’s schedule, looked up.

“No.”

“Not homework.”

“No.”

“Not letter waiting.”

“No.”

“Just paper.”

“Yes.”

Morro inhaled.

Baren pointed without looking.

“Ask.”

Morro set down her coffee.

“May we use an adult version for future-access rules?”

“Yes.”

The Record Access Pathway gained:

A protected person should not be required to respond to future-access materials. If response tools are provided, they should be framed as optional means of agency, not assignments, therapeutic tasks, gratitude exercises, forgiveness prompts, or proof of maturity.

Baren reviewed the safe version.

“Good.”

Then added, “Blank page does not stare.”

Morro looked pained.

“Private?”

“Private.”

She nodded.

The cereal remained cereal.

The blank page remained unstarling.

At 8:40 a.m., the leak investigation produced its first ugly answer.

The purported Dahlia letter had not been leaked by Dahlia’s counsel.

Not directly.

It had passed through a former trust consultant, then a crisis communications subcontractor, then an anonymous account that sent it to three newsrooms, two influencers, and one nonprofit that called itself **Children Deserve Truth Now**.

Morro read the nonprofit name and said, “There is always a now.”

Lila looked grim.

Mara’s newsroom was the only outlet that had refused to quote from the letter.

One influencer had not refused.

A thirty-second video appeared at 8:47 a.m.

It showed the first line of Dahlia’s letter in large text over soft piano music.

The caption read:

What are they afraid he’ll hear?

Morro went still.

This was not anger.

Anger moved.

This was something older and more dangerous.

The court’s preservation order had already warned against publication. The influencer was not a party, but the source chain touched people under protective obligations.

Judge Havel issued an emergency takedown referral and ordered the parties to identify anyone who had distributed the material after notice.

Mara’s newsroom published no link.

No screenshot.

No description of the line.

Only:

Court Responds After Purported Future Letter Material Circulates Online

The article explained that quoting or amplifying protected future-access materials could convert future information into present pressure and potentially interfere with protective orders.

“Good.”

Then she turned to Lila.

“Baren needs to know enough.”

Lila nodded.

Not everything.

Enough.

School was delayed by twenty minutes.

This was not ideal.

It was honest.

Baren sat on the common room couch while Lila explained.

“Part of the leaked future letter appeared online. The court is acting. We are not showing it to you. We are not repeating it. It is being treated as a violation of the protective purpose.”

Baren’s face went small and still.

Not childlike.

Smaller than childlike.

Protected.

Cole stood, then remembered good distance and stopped.

That mattered.

Baren looked at Lila.

“Did it reach me?”

“No.”

“Did other people see?”

“Yes.”

“Does that make it mine?”

“No.”

“Does future folder change?”

“No.”

“Did blank page get ruined?”

Lila’s throat moved.

“No.”

Morro said, “Absolutely not.”

Baren looked at her.

“Because?”

“Because someone else trying to force words into the world does not take away your right to choose your own later.”

He thought.

Then nodded.

“Good.”

Nurse Imani asked, “Do you want school now, later, or not now?”

“Not now.”

Accepted.

No reason.

School moved.

The schedule bent.

The child did not.

At 10:00 a.m., the adult world began fighting over the leaked line without being allowed to repeat it.

This was good.

Hard.

Some commentators framed the leak as whistleblowing.

Others framed it as emotional abuse.

Some called it censorship that outlets would not publish.

Others called for criminal charges before knowing the order.

Morro hated almost everyone for slightly different reasons.

The legal explainer had to be precise.

She helped draft it with Mara’s counsel:

Protected future-access materials are not ordinary public documents merely because someone leaks them. Courts may restrict parties, counsel, agents, contractors, and others subject to protective orders from distributing materials designed for future review by a protected person. News organizations retain independent editorial judgment, but responsible reporting can describe the legal issue without quoting materials that would undermine the protective purpose.

Morro approved the paragraph.

It did not solve the internet.

Nothing solved the internet except outages, and those were usually temporary miracles.

But it created a record.

Records were not nothing.

They were adult memory with a spine.

At 10:30, Baren requested the cow puzzle.

Not school.

Puzzle.

Lila brought the box.

He opened it.

Pieces inside.

No picture.

Available.

He dumped the pieces onto the table.

This was new.

Usually he sorted.

Today he dumped.

The sound made everyone look.

Then everyone looked away too late.

Baren did not seem angry.

He started finding edges.

Cole remained at good distance.

Morro stayed in the lounge.

Lila sat nearby but not close.

Nurse Imani kept the desk.

The first edge went down.

Then another.

Then a corner.

He built the frame.

No sky yet.

No cow.

Just boundary.

After ten minutes, he said, "Frame first."

Lila nodded.

"Okay."

"No guidance."

"Okay."

He worked until lunch.

The frame held.

Inside empty.

Good enough.

Lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole said nothing.

Baren looked at him.

"Geometry?"

"Not now."

Baren nodded.

"Good."

He ate half.

Then asked, "What if people online think letter is truth?"

Lila answered, "Some will."

"Can court stop thinking?"

"No."

"Can court stop use?"

"Some use. Not all."

"Can records answer later?"

"Yes."

He looked at the puzzle frame.

"Frame can hold empty."

Morro, in the lounge, made a sound like a swallowed objection.

Baren looked toward her.

"Private."

Morro nodded.

"Private."

He ate one more bite.

"Truth online is not same as truth in folder."

Lila said, "Correct."

He looked at her.

"That can be public."

The guidance desk issued a shorter correction:

Material circulating online should not be treated as a substitute for protected record access. Future-access systems should preserve context, source, chain of custody, corrections, dispute status, and support. Viral exposure is not informed access.

Baren approved.

"Good."

Then:

"Viral is a sick word."

Morro said, "Accurate, unfortunately."

At 1:30 p.m., Mara did not visit.

She asked through Lila whether today should be no visit unless Baren requested.

Baren read the message.

Given today's leak issue, I will stay available and not visit unless Baren asks. No response needed.

He nodded.

"Good."

"No response?" Lila asked.

“No response.”

Mara received nothing.

And did not send a second message.

The Support Check survived stress.

Rules that only worked on quiet days were decoration.

These rules worked while the internet was trying to shove a letter through a sealed door.

At 2:00 p.m., school resumed lightly.

Ms. Rowe did not bring future tense.

Good teacher.

She brought a worksheet on sorting objects by category.

Baren looked at it.

“This is index school.”

“It is sorting,” Ms. Rowe said.

“What categories?”

“Shape, size, color.”

“No feelings?”

“No feelings.”

“Good.”

He sorted circles, squares, triangles, and rectangles.

Cole maintained silence despite obvious temptation.

Heroic.

Baren finished the worksheet.

Then wrote at the bottom:

No feeling titles.

Ms. Rowe looked at him.

“School or life?”

“Both.”

“Do you want it in the school folder?”

“Yes.”

School folder.

Not drawer.

Not public.

Not guidance.

A sentence could have two homes and still not belong to adults.

At 3:00 p.m., the court identified the nonprofit account that had amplified the letter.

Children Deserve Truth Now was not much of a nonprofit.

It was three people, a donation page, a post office box, and a borrowed rhetoric engine.

Its board included a former youth leadership consultant connected to Civic Horizon Lab.

There.

Not proof of conspiracy.

Proof of pathway.

Morro read the disclosure.

“Now has donors.”

Mara’s newsroom investigated carefully.

No doxxing.

No child-centered framing.

No “shadow group exposed.”

The article:

**Advocacy Account That Amplified Protected Future-Letter Material
Has Consultant Link to Reviewed Vendor Network**

Dry.

Specific.

Receipts.

The machine had tried to use truth language to breach not now.

The machine had also left invoices.

Machines often did.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena requested no visit.

Therapy.

But she sent, through counsel, one procedural message for Lila only:

If Baren becomes aware of online material, please confirm I did not authorize or endorse any future-letter leak from any source. No need to tell him unless clinically appropriate or requested.

Good mothering sometimes looked like not needing the child to know you had done it.

Baren was not told.

Chronald’s counsel sent a similar statement.

Also not relayed.

Dahlia’s counsel denied responsibility in sixteen paragraphs and somehow used the word autonomy four times.

Morro refused to count them as separate thoughts.

At 5:00 p.m., Baren returned to the puzzle frame.

He added one cow.

Not the whole cow.

Half cow.

Then removed it.

Placed it back in the pile.

“Not today.”

Lila nodded.

“Okay.”

He left the frame.

Empty inside.

Nurse Imani asked if he wanted it moved before dinner.

“No.”

“Okay.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

He ate three bites.

Stopped.

No questions.

After dinner, he asked for the future folder.

Lila brought it.

He opened the drawer.

Removed **FUTURE — NOT NOW**.

Opened it.

Safe summary.

Blank page.

He looked at the blank page for a long time.

Then picked up the ordinary pencil from the side table.

Morro stood in the doorway and looked away so violently it became visible.

Baren noticed.

“You can stay.”

Morro turned back.

He wrote one word on the blank page.

Not large.

Not dramatic.

A small word in pencil.

me

He looked at it.

Then closed the folder.

No one spoke.

He put the folder back in the drawer.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

“First word,” he said.

Lila nodded.

“Yes.”

“Mine.”

“Yes.”

Morro’s voice came out rough.

“Yes.”

Baren looked at her.

“Private.”

“Private.”

Before bed, the puzzle frame stayed on the common table.

Empty.

Boundaried.

Available.

Side table changed because the ordinary pencil had been used and returned.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Parrotfish under shark.

Octopus fact near table.

No new fact.

Door half open.

Cole at good distance two.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, writing nothing about the word **me**, which cost her more discipline than most injunctions.

Before sleep, Baren asked, “Can one word be enough?”

Lila said, “Yes.”

“Can it stay pencil?”

“Yes.”

“Can future me erase?”

“Yes.”

“Can future me write more?”

“Yes.”

“Can no one else write there?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, leaked words fought for attention and lost some of their force to boring process.

Elsewhere, courts followed the source chain through truth slogans and consultant invoices.

Elsewhere, adults learned that a future letter could become present harm the moment someone tried to make it public.

Here, the first word in the future folder was not a confession, not forgiveness, not accusation, not prophecy, and not proof of healing.

It was smaller than all of that.

It was enough.

me

CHAPTER SEVENTY-FOUR

Me

The word stayed overnight.

Pencil did that.

Ink made promises.

Pencil made marks.

A pencil word could remain, fade, smudge, be erased, be written over, be circled, be ignored, or survive accidentally for years because no one bothered it.

Baren liked pencil.

By morning, **me** was still there.

He checked once.

Opened drawer.

Took out **FUTURE — NOT NOW**.

Opened folder.

Safe summary.

Blank page that was no longer blank.

Small pencil word.

me

He looked at it.

No one leaned.

No one asked what it meant.

No one said breakthrough.

No one cried.

No one turned it into a sign of readiness, authorship, identity restoration, empowered narrative reclamation, or whatever phrase would have gotten a consultant paid twice.

Lila sat nearby with hands folded.

Cole was at good distance two.

Nurse Imani was at the desk.

Morro stood by the lounge entry with coffee and the expression of a woman preventing a thousand memos from being born.

Baren closed the folder.

Put it back in the drawer.

Opened once.

Still there.

Closed.

“Still mine,” he said.

“Yes,” Lila said.

Morro nodded.

Cole said, “True yes.”

Breakfast was pancakes again.

Wednesday had apparently weakened the kitchen’s resistance, and Thursday finished the job.

Morro objected less.

This was concerning.

“Pancakes again?” Baren asked.

Nurse Imani said, “Available.”

“Not waiting?”

“Not waiting.”

“Syrup?”

“On the side.”

“Good.”

He ate one pancake and declared the second “later but not promised.”

Nurse Imani covered it.

No one called it leftovers.

Leftovers carried obligation.

This was simply pancake still available.

Morro did not ask to use that.

Progress had strange shapes.

At 8:30 a.m., the court held a sealed status conference on the leaked future letter.

Baren did not attend.

Morro attended remotely as special master.

Lila attended as child counsel.

The evidence master attended from a room with a wall so blank it looked chosen by fear.

Dahlia's counsel attended with a face designed to express outrage without liability.

Counsel for the trust consultant attended and looked like he regretted every invoice since 2017.

Counsel for the crisis communications subcontractor claimed confusion.

Judge Havel did not enjoy confusion.

"Confusion," she said, "is not a chain-of-custody defense."

Morro approved so hard she almost smiled.

The court established that the letter draft originated from a trust archive copy outside the official sealed package. It had been circulated years earlier among "future transition planning" consultants.

Future transition planning.

Morro wrote:

GROOMING WITH CALENDAR FEATURES

Then crossed it out.

The crisis communications subcontractor had accessed the letter during preparation of a "public response scenario map" after Dahlia's arrest.

The map included possible narratives:

Suppressed Truth

Stolen Autonomy

Child Shielded From Chosen Adult

When He Turns Eighteen

The Letter They Fear

Judge Havel stopped the presentation.

"Who commissioned this map?"

The subcontractor's counsel requested a moment.

The judge said, "Denied. Answer."

The answer was not Dahlia's current counsel.

It was an old trust communications account paid through a family governance reserve.

Family governance.

Again.

Soft words.

Hard invoices.

The court ordered production of the full scenario map, source chain, fund authorization, and all distribution records.

Morro wrote:

The future was marketed before it arrived.

She stared at the sentence.

Adult.

Public someday.

Not today.

Baren did school writing while adults handled the leak.

Ms. Rowe brought a prompt that had been revised by everyone twice and therefore had lost most of its personality.

Write one sentence about something you choose.

Baren read it.

"Suspicious but okay."

He wrote:

I choose pancakes on Thursday.

Ms. Rowe smiled.

"Good sentence."

"School?"

"School."

"Not life?"

"Not unless you want."

"School."

She wrote:

Sentence completed using subject, verb, object, and time phrase.

Baren approved.

"Grammar receipts."

"Yes."

He underlined **I** once.

Then looked at it.

Different from **me**.

"I and me are different?"

Ms. Rowe nodded.

"Yes. They work differently in a sentence."

"I does?"

"Yes."

"Me receives?"

"Usually."

He thought.

Morro was not in the doorway.

Lucky.

"I can do and me can receive?"

"Grammatically, yes."

Baren considered this with more interest than any adult expected.

"Grammar is rude but useful."

Ms. Rowe laughed once.

Then apologized with her eyes.

Baren allowed it.

School note:

Reviewed pronouns I/me in sentence roles.

No adult guidance.

No public.

No doctrine.

Just grammar.

Rare mercy.

At 10:00 a.m., Mara's newsroom received the court-safe summary of the sealed status conference.

Not the letter.

Not excerpts.

Not emotional bait.

Process.

Source chain.

Scenario map.

Family governance reserve.

Crisis communications distribution.

Vendor link.

The headline wrote itself and was then made worse on purpose.

First draft:

The Letter They Feared Was a Strategy

Mara said, "Too good. Too close."

Second:

Court Probes Whether Future-Letter Leak Was Part of Public Response Strategy

Boring.

Pointed.

The article explained that future-access materials appeared to have been used in scenario planning designed to shape public perception around autonomy and suppression. It noted that the court had ordered production of records and that no protected minor materials would be quoted.

Mara added one line:

A future letter can be evidence of present strategy when adults use it to influence the present.

Adult concept.

Public.

No child sentence.

The article traveled less than the leaked line.

That was fine.

Truth with receipts often traveled slower than piano captions.

It also lasted longer.

At noon, lunch was the remaining pancake and grilled cheese.

This was unconventional.

Baren approved.

"Breakfast and lunch can overlap."

Morro said, "Do not tell brunch."

Cole said, "Brunch is a governance failure."

Baren nodded solemnly.

"Public?"

Morro nearly choked on coffee.

"No."

"Good."

After lunch, Lila gave the safe update.

"The court found the leaked letter may have been used in public response planning. Adults have to produce records."

Baren listened.

"So letter was not just letter."

"Correct."

"Future was marketed?"

Morro became statue.

Baren looked at her.

“You had that?”

Morro sighed.

“Yes.”

“Good adult sentence.”

“May it be public?”

“Yes. Adult leak rules.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Future-facing letters, packages, or statements may become present conduct when adults use them for public response planning, donor strategy, litigation pressure, media framing, or influence campaigns. The fact that a document is addressed to a future person does not prevent it from functioning as present strategy.

Baren read it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Future should not be advertisement.”

Morro put a hand over her eyes.

Baren said, “Yes, adult.”

The guidance added only what adults needed:

Future access should not be designed or used as advertisement, leverage, reputation repair, donor reassurance, loyalty testing, or delayed persuasion.

“Good,” Baren said.

Then he ate the last pancake.

Correct order.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

No puzzle.

One fact.

She sat across from Baren.

“Fact?”

“Some animals use decoys to distract predators.”

Baren frowned.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Which animals?”

“Certain birds, insects, and octopuses use different kinds of distraction or deception.”

“Octopus again.”

“Yes.”

“Octopus is suspicious.”

“Deeply.”

He thought.

“Letter was decoy?”

Mara answered carefully.

“Maybe. Or bait. Or both.”

“Adults used future to distract from present.”

“Yes.”

“Did your article say?”

“In adult words.”

“Good.”

He looked at the cow puzzle box.

“Not puzzle.”

“Okay.”

They sat.

Then he asked, “Did you want to publish line?”

Mara did not answer quickly.

Good.

“A part of me wanted to know it. A part of the newsroom wanted the proof.
But publishing it would have helped the person who wrote it.”

Baren nodded.

“Curiosity can help wrong adult.”

“Yes.”

“Private.”

“Private.”

The visit lasted ten minutes.

No fact checking.

No puzzle.

No letter.

Mara left without asking if tomorrow existed.

Good.

At 2:30 p.m., the task force finalized the **No Bait Index**.

They did not call it that publicly.

Morro wanted to.

Lila said no.

Dr. Rao said no.

Mara said it would make people read it.

That was also a reason for no.

The official title:

Neutral Indexing Standards for Protected Future-Access Materials

No one would put it on a shirt.

The standards prohibited:

Emotional teasers.

Loaded descriptions.

Speculation about meaning.

Countdown language.

Birthday triggers.

Ceremonial delivery.

Mandatory response pages.

Undifferentiated “truth packages.”

Interested-adult letters placed beside court summaries without labels.

Visual hierarchy that made adult letters appear central.

Music.

Morro added music personally.

Someone objected that legal standards rarely mention music.

Morro replied, “They should when piano captions are part of the harm.”

The final version said:

No audiovisual, design, or presentation choices should be used to heighten emotional pressure.

Adequate.

The standards required:

Source labels.

Interest labels.

Dispute status.

Corrections.

Custody record.

Access stage.

Support recommendations.

The right to stop.

The right to skip.

The right to return.

The right to write first or not at all.

Baren approved the safe summary.

“Write first or not at all is good.”

“Yes.”

“Public?”

“It is in adult words.”

“Good.”

At 3:30 p.m., Cole’s chair moved again.

Good distance three.

Only a foot.

Baren noticed.

“Can you still hear?”

“Yes.”

“Can you still come?”

“Yes.”

“Can I not see you unless I look?”

“Mostly.”

Baren looked from bed to hallway.

“Good.”

Cole’s face did not do sadness.

It did effort.

Effort was allowed.

Baren said, “Good job not making face.”

Cole nodded once.

“Supervision was annoying.”

“Useful?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

No further emotion assignment.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

She had heard about the leak’s source chain through counsel and looked tired in a way that did not ask Baren to help.

Good.

Baren said, “Future should not be advertisement.”

Serena’s mouth tightened.

“No.”

“Did adults ever make me advertisement?”

She sat with that.

“Yes.”

No lie.

No collapse.

“Did you?”

“Yes. Sometimes by allowing others to frame our family. Sometimes by not stopping it. Sometimes by wanting people to understand me through you.”

He watched her.

“Useful answer.”

“Sad answer.”

“Useful first.”

“Yes.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

At the door, he added, “Me is in folder.”

She turned.

Her face changed.

She did not ask.

She did not cry.

She did not say proud.

She said, “That belongs to you.”

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

She left.

Morro, when told, said nothing for a full minute.

Then, “Correct mothering.”

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald requested permission to be notified if false claims about his involvement in the leak reached Baren.

Lila denied the phrasing.

Morro rewrote it:

Chronald may correct records through counsel.

Baren will not receive defensive reputation updates unless necessary for his protection or requested.

Adult accusations stay adult unless they affect the child.

Chronald’s counsel accepted.

Bex sent a separate archive certification.

Still watched.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he asked for the future folder again.

Lila brought it.

He opened it.

Safe summary.

Blank page with **me**.

He looked at the word.

Then added a second word below it.

I

He looked at both.

me

I

Receiver.

Doer.

Maybe.

Maybe not.

He closed the folder.

Put it back.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro, at the doorway, asked nothing.

Baren looked at her.

“Good.”

She nodded.

“I am in agony.”

“Private agony.”

“Yes.”

Before bed, Baren asked Ms. Rowe’s grammar question again.

“I does?”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

“Me receives?”

“Yes, usually.”

“Can same person be both?”

“Yes.”

He thought.

“Good.”

Door half open.

Cole at good distance three.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, adding **no mandatory response pages** to three separate standards because the second word in the folder had nearly killed her.

Before sleep, Baren said, “First word was me.”

“Yes.”

“Second was I.”

“Yes.”

“No sentence yet.”

“No sentence needed.”

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, the future-letter leak became evidence of present strategy.

Elsewhere, indexes learned not to bait.

Elsewhere, adults were told that future access could not be advertising with better stationery.

Here, the future folder held two pencil words.

One received.

One acted.

No one else had written either.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-FIVE

No Sentence Yet

No sentence yet survived breakfast.

This was impressive because adults were sentence machines.

They woke with clauses already forming. They moved through rooms turning silence into explanations, explanations into plans, plans into policies, policies into drafts, drafts into circulated versions, circulated versions into meetings, meetings into action items, and action items into slow forms of weather.

Baren had written two words in the future folder.

me

I

No sentence.

No object.

No verb tying him to anything.

No direction.

No adult.

No future demand.

Just two pencil words on a page that belonged to him.

By morning, they were still there.

He checked once.

Drawer open.

Folder out.

Safe summary.

Page.

me

I

He looked.

Closed.

Back in drawer.

Open once.

Still there.

Closed.

Done.

Morro watched from the lounge entry with a face that suggested she had spent the night fighting grammar and grammar had countersued.

Baren looked at her.

“You want sentence.”

Morro lifted her coffee.

“I want many things I am not entitled to.”

“Good answer.”

“Thank you.”

“Still watched.”

“Correct.”

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

No pancakes.

No cereal.

No future.

Toast remained useful because toast did not ask whether I would ever do anything.

Toast simply existed until eaten.

Excellent model.

At 8:30 a.m., the leak investigation widened again.

This time into design.

Not law.

Not custody.

Not communication.

Design.

The scenario map produced from the crisis communications subcontractor contained mockups for future-release campaigns.

Morro read the list aloud and hated every item equally.

Letter Reveal.

Suppressed Truth Timeline.

Autonomy Countdown.

The Adults Who Kept Him From Knowing.

When Baren Turns Eighteen.

The Future He Was Denied.

Each mockup included suggested colors, pacing, music mood, social-media copy, and donor segmentation.

Music mood was listed as:

restrained sorrow / unresolved hope

Morro pushed back from the table.

“No.”

Crowe, remote, whispered, “Restrained sorrow has committed many crimes.”

Morro said, “Public?”

“Please.”

“No.”

Mara’s newsroom received the court-safe summary and stopped just short of publishing the mockup names. They described them generally.

The article:

Court Records Suggest Future-Letter Material Was Considered for Narrative Campaign Planning

No screenshots.

No campaign names.

No music descriptions.

Morro approved.

The guidance desk updated the Neutral Indexing Standards:

Design choices can create pressure. Color, layout, typography, sequencing, music, countdowns, reveal formats, and social media framing should not be used to convert future access into performance, persuasion, or public anticipation.

Baren was told only the safe version after school began.

“Adults made design plans around future-letter material. Court is handling it.”

He looked at Lila.

“Design can pull.”

“Yes.”

“Like syrup?”

Morro, unfortunately present, blinked.

Baren continued.

“Syrup moves slow but gets everywhere.”

Cole, at good distance three, whispered, “Strong.”

Baren looked at Morro.

“Adult design rules. Not breakfast.”

The guidance kept the usable part:

Persuasive design may operate slowly and diffusely, shaping attention and expectation before a protected person ever chooses access.

Morro looked at Baren.

“I made it less syrup.”

“Good.”

School writing began with pronouns again because Ms. Rowe was either brave or reckless.

She wrote:

Imemine

Baren stared at the third word.

“Mine.”

“Yes.”

“Possessive.”

“Yes.”

“Like drawer.”

“Exactly.”

He looked at the page.

I do.

Give it to me.

This is mine.

He considered each sentence as if it were a witness with questionable incentives.

“I do is dangerous.”

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“Can be.”

“Give it to me can be rude.”

“Yes.”

“This is mine can be good.”

“Yes.”

He wrote three sentences:

I choose later. The folder belongs to me. The words are mine.

Then he stopped.

He looked at the page longer than usual.

Lila, nearby, did not speak.

Morro had been banned from doorway presence during pronouns by a look so severe it probably had bar membership.

Baren asked, “School folder or drawer?”

Ms. Rowe answered, “You decide.”

He thought.

“Copy for school. Original drawer.”

Ms. Rowe made a copy.

School copy went into school folder.

Original page went to Baren.

He placed it into the drawer, but not inside **FUTURE — NOT NOW.**

Next to it.

Different.

Lila noticed.

Morro, from the hall, did not.

Good.

Baren opened the drawer once.

Both there.

Closed.

“Pronouns are separate.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

At 10:00 a.m., Judge Havel issued a design-preservation order.

This was new enough that everyone pretended it was normal.

The order required production of design files, mockups, campaign boards, music references, audience-testing notes, design briefs, and subcontractor communications related to future-access materials or protected-minor narratives.

Morro read the order with something close to admiration.

“Good judge.”

Lila said, “She caught the room.”

“Good judges catch the room.”

Mara asked on secure chat, “Public?”

Morro thought.

Adult.

General.

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Protective review should include not only text but presentation. A document’s effect may depend on design, sequencing, format, release plan, audience testing, and surrounding narrative materials.

Baren approved safe version later.

“Words wear clothes.”

Morro sat perfectly still.

Baren pointed.

“Adult design rules.”

The guidance kept the usable part:

Words wear clothes. Protective review should consider whether design and presentation alter the pressure, meaning, or use of future-access materials.

Morro whispered, “Thank you.”

Baren said, “Do not be weird.”

“Withdrawn.”

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole said, “Rectangles wear fewer clothes.”

The room stopped.

Baren blinked.

Morro placed her coffee down.

Lila closed her eyes.

Nurse Imani said, “No.”

Cole nodded.

“Withdrawn with prejudice.”

Baren looked at him.

“Bad geometry again.”

“Severe.”

Lunch continued.

No one mentioned rectangles wearing clothes.

Not even privately.

Some mercy was mandatory.

After lunch, Lila gave Baren an adult update.

“No new arrests. Court is investigating who used future-letter materials in design and public response plans. Adults are reviewing not only words but how words are presented.”

“Because words wear clothes.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

“Do you want more?”

“No.”

He looked toward the drawer.

“Does future folder need clothes?”

“What do you mean?”

“Plain folder okay.”

“Yes.”

“No special color.”

“No.”

“No ribbon.”

“No.”

“No cover.”

“No.”

“No music.”

“Absolutely no music.”

Morro said this too quickly.

Baren smiled.

“Good.”

Then he asked, “Can future me change folder?”

“Yes.”

“Can future me make it fancy?”

“Yes.”

Morro appeared distressed.

Lila said, “It would be his choice.”

Morro recovered.

“Correct.”

Baren nodded.

“Future me can have bad taste.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

She brought no fact.

Baren noticed.

“No fact?”

“No fact today.”

“Why?”

“Because design leak day felt like enough information.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

They sat.

The cow puzzle remained in its box.

Baren did not request it.

Mara did not look at it.

Progress had become less visible.

That was the best kind.

Baren asked, “Do your articles wear clothes?”

Mara smiled.

“Yes.”

“Headlines?”

“Yes.”

“Pictures?”

“Yes.”

“Do you choose boring clothes?”

“We try.”

“Why?”

“So the article does not pull harder than the record.”

He thought.

“That is good.”

“Private?”

He considered.

“Adult journalism maybe.”

Mara asked, “May I use the idea without your words?”

“Yes. Journalism adult.”

Her newsroom later added an editor’s note to its internal standards:

Presentation should not create emotional pressure beyond what the verified record supports.

No child attribution.

Good.

At 2:30 p.m., Crowe broke his no-facts period by not breaking it.

He sent Lila a message for adults only:

I am not sending the bioluminescent plankton fact because it wants to be about invisible light. Please congratulate my restraint privately or not at all.

Lila showed Morro.

Morro responded:

Not at all.

Crowe sent a thumbs-up.

Then deleted it.

Then sent nothing.

Trying Adult.

Advanced level.

Baren was not told because Crowe had asked for adults only and Baren did not need to manage Crowe’s restraint.

At 3:00 p.m., the task force revised the Record Access Pathway to include **presentation neutrality**.

The standards now required that future-access materials be available in plain format by default.

No dramatic packaging.

No ordering that placed emotional letters before factual records.

No “final message” framing.

No sealed-envelope theater unless the protected adult later requested physical originals.

No surprise presentation.

No forced reading room.

No recording of the access event.

No anniversary notifications.

No countdown.

No audience.

No institutional representative present unless requested and approved.

Morro underlined **no audience** three times.

Lila saw.

“Personal?”

“Professional.”

“Both?”

“Correct.”

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren told her words wear clothes.

She smiled carefully.

“That is true.”

“Did my words ever wear your clothes?”

Serena did not rush.

“Yes.”

“How?”

“When I explained you through my fear, my grief, my pride, or what I wanted people to understand.”

He watched.

“Useful answer.”

“Sad answer.”

“Where sad goes?”

“Adults.”

“Good.”

She paused.

“Your words should wear your clothes.”

Baren considered.

“That is almost too good.”

“I know.”

“Therapy?”

“Yes.”

“Therapy is dangerous.”

“It is helping.”

“Same.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, "Done."

She stood.

No extra.

At the door, she said nothing.

At 5:00 p.m., Chronald's team produced the campaign design files.

The absence strategy had clothes too.

No image of Baren.

No name.

But layouts showing an empty chair at a family table.

A child's bedroom door half open.

A small pair of shoes in soft focus.

A father's hand not holding another hand.

Rejected campaign copy:

A father who chose silence to protect what mattered most.

Some love refuses the spotlight.

Privacy is his promise.

Morro read the file and said a word that made Crowe cross himself through habit, then apologize to no one.

Lila looked pale.

The absence had clothes.

The absence had lighting.

The absence had been dressed for voters.

Bex had preserved it.

Good.

Terrible.

Mara's article was spare:

Campaign Files Show Visual Testing of Family-Privacy Themes Without Child's Image

No images shown.

No copy quoted except in court summary paraphrase.

Baren was not told that night.

Enough.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate most.

Then asked for the drawer.

Lila brought no drawer because drawers did not travel.

He went to it himself.

Opened.

Future folder.

Pronoun page.

He removed the future folder.

Opened it.

Safe summary.

Blank page with:

me

I

He added a third word.

mine

Then closed it.

No sentence.

Three words now.

Receiver.

Doer.

Possessor.

Maybe.

He returned the folder.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro stood in the lounge, absolutely motionless.

Baren looked at her.

“Do not explode.”

“I am trying.”

“Private.”

“Private.”

Before bed, side table check.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish fact under shark.

Octopus fact near table.

No design.

No clothes.

Door half open.

Cole at good distance three.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, learning that even the best index could not compete with three pencil words and should not try.

Before sleep, Baren said, “Me receives.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“I does.”

“Yes.”

“Mine keeps.”

“Yes.”

“No sentence yet.”

“No sentence needed.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, words were found wearing campaign clothes, donor clothes, autonomy clothes, grief clothes, and restrained-sorrow piano.

Elsewhere, courts learned to subpoena design.

Elsewhere, adults learned that even a future letter could be dressed as a weapon.

Here, the future folder held three pencil words.

me

I

mine

Still no sentence.

Still enough.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-SIX

Mine

Mine was the most dangerous word so far.

Not because Baren said it.

Because adults heard it.

Adults heard **mine** and immediately wanted to know what it covered.

The folder?

The words?

The future?

The story?

The records?

The body?

The drawer?

The right to know?

The right not to know?

The right to write first?

The right to erase?

The right to be wrong later?

The right to keep a thing private even after someone else decided it was important?

Adults had an ancient weakness for scope.

Morro had it worse than most because scope was where jurisdiction hid.

She woke with scope questions already forming and punished herself by making coffee without writing any of them down.

Baren checked the drawer once.

Future folder.

Safe summary.

Page.

me

I

mine

No sentence.

Pronoun page beside the folder.

Support Checks below.

Framework order.

Learning plan.

Dinosaur boots photo.

Leaf envelope.

Private notes.

Blank envelope.

Everything still there.

He closed the drawer.

Opened once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro stood near the lounge entrance with her coffee.

Baren looked at her.

“You want to ask what mine means.”

Morro did not lie.

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Accepted.”

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

No future.

No scope.

Cole sat at good distance three and looked like a man who had been warned by supervision not to turn possession into protection.

Good.

Nurse Imani reviewed the schedule.

Breakfast.

School.

Courtyard optional.

Mara visit optional.

Adult briefing optional.

No public obligations.

Drawer rules available.

Not waiting.

Baren nodded.

“Mine can be not explained.”

Lila smiled softly.

“Yes.”

Morro placed her coffee down very carefully.

Baren looked at her.

“Ask for adult version?”

“May I?”

“Yes.”

The Record Access Pathway gained:

A protected person's assertion of ownership, privacy, or personal connection to records, words, objects, or future access does not require immediate explanation. Adults should not treat "mine" as an invitation to define scope, demand meaning, or convert the assertion into a legal, therapeutic, narrative, or public exercise.

Baren read the safe version later.

"Good. Mine is not a deposition."

Morro's pen stopped moving.

Baren sighed.

"Yes. Adult."

The guidance kept the usable part:

"Mine" is not a deposition. Questions about scope may be necessary in legal settings, but they should be limited, purposeful, developmentally appropriate, and not used to pressure a protected person to explain why something matters.

Morro whispered, "Thank you."

Baren pointed his spoon.

"Cereal zone."

"Withdrawn."

At 8:30 a.m., the campaign design files became adult weather.

Not because Baren knew.

Because the adults did.

The visual tests around family privacy had shown no image of Baren, no name, no direct reference, and no explicit child content.

That was the problem.

Absence had been dressed.

A half-open bedroom door.

An empty chair.

A father's hand reaching toward nothing.

Shoes without feet.

A breakfast table set for one fewer person than expected.

Soft light.

No music in the file, but notes suggesting "quiet sincerity" and "earned restraint."

Morro hated **earned restraint** so much she refused to say it twice.

Mara's newsroom prepared a second analysis.

The headline was bad at first.

How a Campaign Sold a Child Without Showing Him

Morro said, "Too sharp. Also maybe true. Still no."

Second:

Campaign Files Raise Questions About Use of Absence in Family-Privacy Messaging

Approved.

The article explained that visual absence can function as representation when the campaign, records, polling, and audience testing show viewers are meant to understand who is absent.

It did not show the images.

It did not quote the rejected lines in full.

It did not ask readers whether the ads would have moved them.

No engagement trap.

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Non-display can still be use. A protected person's absence, silhouette, empty chair, unnamed relationship, implied room, or symbolic object may function as representation when context, design, testing, or accompanying materials invite the audience to identify or emotionally rely on that person.

Baren was told the safe version after school.

Not before.

Adults finally understood breakfast boundaries.

Mostly.

School began with grammar again because pronouns had become surprisingly productive, which made them dangerous but also useful.

Ms. Rowe wrote:

my

mine

Baren frowned.

“My is before thing.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Mine can stand alone.”

“Yes.”

He liked that.

“Mine stands alone.”

Morro was not in the doorway.

Lila had issued a morning advisory titled **No Hallway Grammar Hovering**.

Morro had complied under protest.

Baren wrote:

my pencil

my folder

my choice

Then:

The pencil is mine.

The folder is mine.

The choice is mine.

He looked at the sentences.

“My choice is before. Choice is mine stands.”

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“That is how the grammar works.”

“Can adults make my into theirs?”

“Sometimes they try.”

“Grammar?”

“Not grammar.”

“People.”

“Yes.”

He wrote one more sentence:

My words are mine.

Then stopped.

School folder or drawer?

He thought.

“Copy for school. Original drawer.”

Ms. Rowe copied it.

School copy filed.

Original went next to the pronoun page.

Not in future folder.

Baren opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro, from safely far away, appeared to be suffering at a sustainable level.

Good.

At 10:00 a.m., Judge Havel issued a temporary order about implied representation.

Campaign counsel objected immediately because campaign counsel were paid to object to the existence of oxygen if oxygen created exposure.

The order did not decide liability.

It preserved records.

It required production of all visual tests, implied-reference materials, audience-testing notes, and communications concerning unnamed or absent family members, especially where the campaign tested whether viewers inferred a specific child or protected person.

Morro read the order and nodded.

“Non-display can be evidence.”

Lila said, “But not automatically use.”

“Correct.”

Mara’s explainer said the same:

The court did not rule that every symbolic image is unlawful or that campaigns cannot discuss family privacy. The order preserves evidence on whether specific visual strategies were designed, tested, or understood as references to a protected minor without direct display.

Dry.

Adult.

Baren did not know yet.

He was drawing a pencil that looked like a spear and then erasing the spear point because “pencil should not get ideas.”

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole said nothing.

Baren looked at him.

“Geometry?”

Cole answered carefully.

“Triangles are implied rectangles under pressure.”

Silence.

Deep silence.

Morro stared at him.

Lila stared at him.

Nurse Imani placed one hand on the table.

Baren considered.

“No.”

Cole nodded.

“Withdrawn permanently.”

“Go to supervision.”

“Scheduled.”

Lunch continued under heightened geometry restrictions.

After lunch, Baren received the safe adult update.

“Campaign files showed adults tested family privacy images without showing you directly. Court ordered adults to preserve and produce records about implied references.”

Baren listened.

“Empty chair?”

Lila hesitated.

“Yes. That kind of thing.”

His face tightened.

“Door?”

“Yes.”

“Shoes?”

“Yes.”

Morro added, “No images shown publicly in the update. We are not showing you the files unless you ask and it is approved.”

“Good.”

He looked toward his half-open door.

“My door is mine.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Can campaign have door?”

“They can have a door. Not your door.”

“Can they make people think my door?”

“That is the issue.”

He nodded slowly.

“Mine can be stolen without taking.”

Morro closed her eyes.

Baren saw.

“Yes. Adult implied-use rules.”

The guidance kept the usable part:

Personal meaning can be appropriated without physically taking the object or displaying the person. Context, design, timing, testing, and surrounding messages can turn ordinary objects or absences into implied references.

Baren approved.

“Good. Add not all doors.”

Lila added:

This does not mean every ordinary object is protected or symbolic. The concern arises when records or context show an object, absence, or setting is being used to invoke a specific protected person.

“Good.”

Then Baren said, “My door is not campaign.”

Morro did not ask.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

She arrived with one fact and no article face.

Mostly.

Baren noticed the article face hiding under the no article face.

“Article face.”

“Small.”

“About empty?”

“Yes.”

“No work.”

“I know.”

“Fact.”

Mara sat.

“Some animals use empty nests or shells to confuse predators or competitors.”

Baren stared.

“Too close.”

“Yes. I apologize. Bad fact.”

“Try again.”

Mara thought.

“Sea otters sometimes hold hands while resting so they do not drift apart.”

Baren considered.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

“Do they have consent?”

Mara blinked.

“I do not know.”

“Then halfway-halfway.”

“Fair.”

He looked toward the cow puzzle box.

“No puzzle.”

“Okay.”

They sat.

He asked, “Did your article show empty chair?”

“No.”

“Good.”

“Did it say empty chair?”

“In general terms, not the campaign image.”

“Good.”

“Is that okay?”

He thought.

“Adult readers need know without seeing.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

The visit lasted nine minutes.

No puzzle.

One replacement fact.

Halfway-halfway.

Mara left without making empty chairs worse.

At 2:30 p.m., the task force created a new category.

Implied Use.

Morro disliked the neatness.

Lila liked the clarity.

Dr. Rao asked for safeguards.

The category applied when a protected person was not named, shown, quoted, or directly described, but was invoked through objects, absences, relationships, timing, audience knowledge, or contextual cues.

Examples:

A bedroom door known to belong to a child.

A missing chair in a family campaign ad.

A toy associated with a protected minor.

A birthday without a name.

A parent speaking of privacy while polling records show the audience identified the child.

A foundation displaying a “future leader” silhouette tied to a specific child’s story.

A school using a nameless case study recognizable to classmates.

A church sermon about “the child we failed” in a congregation that knows who.

Morro added:

A protected person should not have to be visible to be used.

Baren reviewed the safe version.

“Yes. Public.”

The guidance desk included it:

A protected person should not have to be visible to be used. Implied use should be assessed through context, records, audience knowledge, testing, timing, and whether the communication benefits from identifiable absence.

Baren nodded.

“Good. Identifiable absence is old oatmeal but okay.”

Morro said, “Legal oatmeal.”

“Fine.”

At 3:30 p.m., Baren requested courtyard.

The sad maple had dried.

Mostly.

Cole stood at good distance, not too close, not theatrical.

Baren sat on the bench.

“My door is mine.”

Cole said, “Yes.”

“Your chair?”

Cole looked at his chair through the window.

“Assigned.”

“Is it yours?”

“No.”

“Good.”

Baren thought.

“Good distance is mine?”

Cole paused.

“Yes.”

“Also yours?”

“Yes.”

“Both?”

“Yes.”

“Hard.”

“Yes.”

They sat.

A leaf fell.

No one touched it.

The leaf was its own problem.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren asked, “Did campaign use empty?”

She took a breath.

“I have been told records show they tested images and language about absence.”

“Did you know?”

“Not those files. But I knew public privacy could become message.”

“Did you stop?”

“No.”

Useful answer.

Sad answer.

He nodded.

“My door is not campaign.”

“No. It is not.”

“My words are mine.”

“Yes.”

“Do not say proud.”

She closed her mouth.

Good.

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

At the door, she said, “Your door is yours.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Not too good.

Good.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald’s counsel submitted a declaration.

Not emotional.

For once.

It admitted that campaign advisors tested privacy messaging connected to family absence. It denied that Chronald approved direct reference to Baren. It acknowledged that he did not prohibit all implied references until late. It produced communications showing Bex had objected to “making absence do child work.”

Morro read that phrase.

“Bex.”

Lila said, “Useful.”

“Still watched.”

“Yes.”

Mara’s newsroom reported the declaration.

No images.

No quotes beyond the phrase after court release.

Making absence do child work entered public discussion.

Adult phrase.

Adult record.

Baren was told only if he asked.

He did not.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he asked for the drawer.

Opened.

Future folder.

Pronoun pages.

He took the future folder out.

Opened.

Safe summary.

Page:

me

I

mine

He picked up the ordinary pencil.

Paused.

Then wrote:

not yours

Small.

Under the others.

me

I

mine

not yours

Morro put both hands behind her back like she was physically restraining jurisprudence.

Baren looked up.

“Private.”

“Yes,” Morro said.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Before bed, side table check.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish under shark.

Octopus fact near table.

Door half open.

His door.

Cole at good distance three.

His distance too.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, revising implied-use standards and not writing down the four words now sitting in the future folder because privacy was apparently a form of endurance training.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Can mine say no?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Can not yours be enough?"

"Yes."

"Even without explaining?"

"Yes."

"Even if adult asks scope?"

"Yes. Unless court really needs, then careful."

He nodded.

"Mine is not deposition."

"Correct."

He closed his eyes.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, absence entered evidence.

Elsewhere, campaigns learned that empty chairs can have fingerprints.

Elsewhere, courts began asking whether a person had been used without being shown.

Here, Baren's door stayed half open because he wanted it that way.

And in the drawer, pencil said what no adult was allowed to improve:

me

I

mine

not yours

CHAPTER SEVENTY-SEVEN

Not Yours

Not yours was not angry.

That surprised the adults.

They had expected anger because adults often mistook boundaries for anger when the boundary inconvenienced them. Anger was easier for adults to understand. Anger could be processed, de-escalated, apologized to, therapized, reframed, or criticized depending on which chair the adult occupied and whether there was funding.

Not yours was different.

Not yours did not throw anything.

Not yours did not explain.

Not yours did not prove harm.

Not yours did not say never.

Not yours did not say hate.

Not yours simply placed a fence around meaning and refused to decorate the fence for visitors.

By morning, the four words were still in the future folder.

me

I

mine

not yours

Baren checked once.

Drawer open.

Folder out.

Safe summary.

Page.

Words.

Still pencil.

Still his.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro watched from the lounge with the expression of someone who had discovered a legal doctrine and been forbidden from naming it, publishing it, teaching it, footnoting it, or even enjoying it too visibly.

Baren saw.

“You are having forbidden doctrine face.”

“I am having coffee.”

“No.”

Morro considered fighting this.

Lost.

“Yes.”

“No doctrine.”

“Accepted.”

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No card.

No implied use.

No future.

No door.

Just cereal.

Cole sat at good distance three. His chair no longer aimed at the doorway like a warning. It faced the hall at an angle that allowed presence without display.

Baren approved the chair with one glance.

Cole did not smile.

Good.

At 8:30 a.m., the implied-use category began causing adult panic.

Institutions disliked being told that not showing someone might still count as using them.

Campaigns disliked it most because campaigns had built entire civilizations out of implication.

Foundations disliked it because unnamed inspirational children were one of their strongest renewable resources.

Schools disliked it because case studies were easier when everyone pretended the class did not know who the case was about.

Faith institutions disliked it because sermons had long relied on saying “a child” while everyone in the room supplied the name.

Media disliked it quietly because silhouette ethics were profitable.

Morro read the objections with her usual tenderness.

One campaign lawyer wrote:

This standard risks chilling ordinary references to family, privacy, and parental experience.

Morro replied in draft:

Good. Chill harder.

Lila crossed it out.

The public response became:

The concern is not ordinary discussion of family, privacy, or parental experience. The concern arises when records, context, audience knowledge, testing, timing, or design show that an unnamed person's absence or symbolic substitute is being used to create value, influence, credibility, sympathy, pressure, or institutional benefit.

Baren reviewed the safe version later.

"Good. Not all empty."

"Yes."

"Only used empty."

"Yes."

He nodded.

"Empty can be stolen too."

Morro's eyes closed.

Baren sighed.

"Yes. Adult."

The guidance added only what adults needed:

Empty can be used. A blank space, absent figure, unnamed room, or omitted identity may still carry identifiable meaning when adults intentionally rely on what the audience knows or suspects.

"Good," Baren said. "Not stolen. Used. Stolen is too much sometimes."

"Precision accepted."

School began with reading.

No pronouns.

Everyone needed a break from pronouns.

Ms. Rowe brought the ocean book and opened to kelp forests.

Baren liked kelp immediately because it looked like underwater trees that had refused zoning.

"Kelp is sea forest?"

"Yes."

"Does it have roots?"

"Not true roots. It has a holdfast that anchors it."

"Holdfast."

He liked the word.

Dangerously.

Morro was not in the doorway.

Good.

Ms. Rowe explained that kelp could create habitat, slow currents, shelter animals, and grow quickly under the right conditions.

Baren listened.

“Holdfast is not root.”

“Correct.”

“It holds but does not drink from dirt.”

“Yes.”

“Adults will ruin that.”

“Probably.”

He read a paragraph aloud.

Then wrote **holdfast** on his worksheet because the word deserved suspicion.

“School folder,” he said.

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“School folder.”

Not drawer.

Not future.

A word could be interesting without becoming law.

This was good news for language.

At 10:00 a.m., the court held a short hearing on campaign materials.

Chronald did not appear.

Good.

His counsel appeared.

Bex appeared remotely under subpoena.

Campaign counsel attempted to argue that implied family imagery was constitutionally protected political speech.

Judge Havel agreed that political speech had strong protection.

Then asked whether the issue before her was banning speech or preserving evidence and determining whether campaign conduct violated court orders, privacy restrictions, or other legal duties.

Campaign counsel became less musical.

Morro enjoyed this.

Bex testified that her objection to “making absence do child work” began after audience-testing data showed viewers correctly inferred that family-privacy messaging involved Baren even when he was not named.

The hearing chair asked, “Was the absence valuable because viewers supplied the protected child?”

Bex answered, “Yes.”

Clean.

Ugly.

Mara's newsroom reported:

Campaign Aide Says Privacy Messaging Gained Value When Viewers Supplied Protected Child's Absence

No images.

No dramatized copy.

No empty chair graphic.

Baren was told only the safe version after lunch.

Adults had learned pacing.

Somewhat.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole remained under geometry probation.

He said nothing.

Baren looked at him.

"Good silence."

Cole nodded.

"Hard."

"Supervision."

"Already scheduled."

"Good."

After lunch, Lila gave the safe update.

"Campaign adult testified that privacy messaging became valuable because people supplied your absence even when you were not shown."

Baren looked toward his door.

"My absence is mine too."

"Yes."

Morro leaned forward before she could stop herself.

Baren looked at her.

"Ask."

"May we use an adult version?"

"Yes."

The guidance kept the usable part:

A protected person's absence may itself be protected from exploitation when adults intentionally invite others to supply that person's identity, story, relationship, or emotional meaning. Privacy is not permission to monetize absence.

Baren reviewed it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Privacy is not a costume.”

Morro gripped her pen.

Baren thought.

“Yes. Adult.”

The guidance added only what adults needed:

Privacy should not be used as a costume for implication. Claims of restraint, silence, or non-display should be tested against records showing whether adults used the protected person’s absence to create emotional or strategic value.

Morro whispered, “Legal oatmeal with cinnamon.”

Baren looked at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

No fact.

She had requested no fact because the day already contained kelp, absence, and campaign testimony.

Baren accepted.

They sat in the common room.

The cow puzzle box remained closed.

Baren said, “Absence can be mine.”

Mara nodded.

“Yes.”

“Articles use absence?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Not naming someone can protect them. But sometimes not naming someone makes readers more curious or lets them fill in the person.”

“Do you do that?”

“We try not to. Sometimes we have to check ourselves.”

“Do you use empty?”

“We avoid empty chairs.”

“Good.”

She paused.

“Sometimes blank space protects.”

Baren thought.

“Sometimes blank space pulls.”

“Yes.”

“Hard.”

“Yes.”

No article.

No fact.

Visit lasted nine minutes.

Mara left with no response required.

At 2:30 p.m., the task force drafted a bulletin titled:

Privacy, Absence, and Implied Representation

Morro approved the title because it was boring enough to deter merchandise.

The bulletin stayed narrow:

Privacy cannot be used as a shield and a lever at the same time.

Non-display is not automatically exploitation.

But when adults test, design, market, narrate, or benefit from an audience identifying an unnamed protected person, the absence itself becomes part of the use.

Professionals should review:

What does the audience know?

What did the adult intend?

What did records show?

Was the absence tested?

Was restraint praised as virtue?

Did the communication benefit from viewers supplying the protected person?

Could the same message work if the audience did not know who was missing?

Who gained?

Who had choice?

Who could say no?

Baren read the safe version.

“Good.”

Then asked, “Could the same message work if the audience did not know who was missing?”

“Yes,” Lila said. “That helps test implied use.”

Baren nodded.

“Good question.”

Morro said, “Adult-born, unfortunately.”

“Good. Adults can have one.”

Morro bowed her head.

“Grateful.”

At 3:30 p.m., courtyard.

The sad maple had begun looking less sad, which everyone agreed not to mention.

Some trees deserved privacy during improvement.

Baren sat on the bench.

Cole at good distance.

“Is your absence yours?” Baren asked.

Cole thought.

“Yes.”

“Did prison take absence?”

Cole did not answer quickly.

Morro was not there.

Lila was nearby but not close.

Cole said, “Sometimes. People used where I was not to decide what I was.”

Baren nodded.

“Not yours?”

“Not theirs.”

“Still watched.”

“Yes.”

They sat.

The tree dropped no leaf.

Good.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren asked, “Did you use my absence?”

She answered without collapsing.

“Yes.”

“When?”

“When I let people talk about protecting you in ways that made me look like a better mother without asking whether your absence was being used.”

He listened.

“Useful answer.”

“Sad answer.”

“Where sad goes?”

“Adults.”

“Good.”

She added, “Your absence is yours.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Timer buzzed.

“Done.”

She stood.

No extra.

No proud.

No private mothering turned into public repair.

Trying Adult.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald’s adult channel produced something new.

Not a statement.

A correction list.

Campaign materials that had implied Baren without naming him.

Dates.

Design IDs.

Testing groups.

Audience inference percentages.

Responsible staff.

Approval status.

Whether Chronald saw them.

Whether Bex objected.

Whether materials were killed, revised, or stored.

Morro read the table.

“Good if complete.”

Lila nodded.

“Receipts.”

Bex’s cover note said:

Absence inventory attached.

Morro looked at the title.

“Absence inventory.”

Adult concept.

Mara’s newsroom reported the filing.

No table shown.

No images.

Just the existence of an inventory and what categories it covered.

Baren was told only one sentence:

“Campaign adults made an inventory of materials that may have used your absence.”

He nodded.

“Good. Adult mess. Adult inventory.”

“Yes.”

“No need see.”

“No.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

Future folder.

Pronoun page.

Support Checks.

Orders.

He took the future folder out.

Opened it.

Safe summary.

Page:

me

I

mine

not yours

He picked up the ordinary pencil.

Wrote beneath them:

also absence

Then stopped.

Looked at it.

Not a sentence.

Still enough.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro made no sound.

This was her greatest ruling.

Before bed, Baren asked, "Can something be mine even if it is not there?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Can not being there be choice?"

"Yes."

"Can not being there be used wrong?"

"Yes."

"Can I take absence back?"

Lila thought.

"You can make rules around it. You can say it is not theirs."

He nodded.

"Good."

Door half open.

His door.

His absence.

His room.

Cole at good distance three.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, rewriting privacy guidance to include absence without making absence into a ghost adults could chase.

Before sleep, Baren whispered, "Not yours."

Lila said, "Correct."

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, empty chairs gained fingerprints.

Elsewhere, campaigns inventoried absence.

Elsewhere, adults learned that privacy could not be costume, shield, lever, and advertisement all at once.

Here, the future folder held five pencil lines.

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

Not a sentence.

Not yet.

Not owed.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-EIGHT

Used Empty

The absence inventory arrived in three formats.

Spreadsheet.

PDF.

Appendix.

Morro distrusted the PDF immediately.

“PDFs are where spreadsheets go to become less accountable,” she said.

Lila looked up from the table.

“That is not always true.”

“No. But often enough to search.”

The campaign’s **Absence Inventory** had been produced by Chronald Sump’s counsel under court order, certified by Bex Alton, cross-referenced with design files, audience-testing reports, consultant notes, and media-buy drafts.

It was ugly in the way useful things were ugly.

Rows.

Dates.

Design IDs.

Approval status.

Audience inference scores.

Associated copy.

Internal objections.

Final disposition.

Preserved assets.

Destroyed drafts.

Recovered drafts.

Unknown custody.

Morro hated the unknown custody column most.

Unknown custody was a polite way to say someone had dropped a thing into darkness and hoped darkness did not keep receipts.

Darkness often did.

The inventory classified materials into categories:

Direct Child Reference — prohibited.

None approved.

Good.

Family Privacy Messaging — adult public issue.

Many.

Implied Child Absence — under review.

Too many.

Symbolic Object / Room / Door — under review.

Worse.

Fatherhood Restraint — tested, mostly rejected.

Bad phrase.

Silence as Virtue — tested.

Worse phrase.

Non-Display Strategy — active internal debate.

There.

Morro circled it.

“Non-display strategy.”

Lila leaned closer.

“That is the category.”

“Yes.”

Bex’s attached declaration said, in the dry exhaustion of a person trying to become useful without becoming heroic:

The campaign repeatedly tested whether voters perceived Mr. Sump’s refusal to display his son as evidence of paternal restraint, sacrifice, seriousness, or moral protection. Although no final public advertisement using the tested child-absence imagery was released to my knowledge, the polling and message testing were used in internal strategy discussions. I objected after it became clear that absence itself had become campaign value.

Morro read it twice.

“Good if complete.”

“Still watched,” Lila said.

“Always.”

Baren was not told before breakfast.

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

No campaign.

No absence.

No inventory.

His future folder remained in the drawer with five pencil lines:

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

No sentence.

No adult had asked for one.

That was the morning's first victory.

School began with oceans.

Ms. Rowe brought the kelp chapter back because holdfast had survived the prior day without becoming doctrine, which meant it could be trusted a little.

Baren read about kelp forests sheltering animals.

Sea otters.

Fish.

Urchins.

Small creatures with names adults could pronounce only with confidence they had not earned.

He stopped at a picture of an empty shell lodged in kelp.

"Used empty," he said.

Ms. Rowe looked at him.

"Used empty?"

"Shell empty but still useful."

"Yes."

"Could hide something."

"Yes."

"Could be home later."

"Yes."

"Could trick."

"Sometimes."

He looked toward the doorway.

Morro was not there.

Good.

He wrote **used empty** on his worksheet.

Then crossed it out.

Then wrote **empty shell**.

"School," he said.

Ms. Rowe nodded.

“School.”

Lila did not ask.

Good.

Some phrases could be born and die quietly on worksheets.

Adults had to learn not to rescue every sentence.

At 10:00 a.m., the court held the implied-use conference.

Not trial.

Not ruling.

Conference.

Lawyers loved making meaningful events sound like office furniture.

Judge Havel sat without visible patience.

Campaign counsel argued that preserving all implied-use materials risked expanding the case beyond recognition.

Judge Havel asked, “Beyond whose recognition?”

Campaign counsel paused.

Morro, watching remotely, whispered, “Careful.”

The judge continued.

“The court is not presently deciding liability. The court is preserving evidence relevant to whether protected persons were used, directly or indirectly, in violation of existing orders, privacy duties, fiduciary obligations, or other legal standards. If your position is that indirect use cannot matter, say so plainly.”

Campaign counsel did not say so plainly.

Good.

Bex testified again.

Her voice remained level.

“I did not initially understand non-display as use,” she said. “I understood display as use. Name as use. Image as use. Direct quote as use. Later, the testing showed the audience supplied the child. Then non-display was doing work.”

The judge asked, “What kind of work?”

“Trust work. Fatherhood work. Moral restraint work. Sympathy work.”

Morro wrote:

ABSENCE WAS LABOR

Then crossed it out.

Too sharp.

Baren-adjacent.

Later maybe.

The judge ordered a supplemental inventory identifying not only whether materials showed or named Baren, but whether internal records showed expected audience inference, emotional function, strategic value, or institutional benefit from his absence.

Morro approved.

The court had learned to ask what empty did.

Mara's newsroom published carefully.

Headline:

Court Orders Supplemental Review of Campaign Materials That Relied on Implied Child Absence

Dry.

Good.

The article explained the distinction between ordinary privacy language and implied-use strategy. It quoted Bex only where the court record allowed:

"Non-display was doing work."

Adult phrase.

Adult witness.

Public.

The article did not show an empty chair.

Did not mention Baren's door.

Did not ask readers what image came to mind.

Did not use absence to report on absence.

Morro sent one word:

Mara sent back:

I will frame this and not show anyone.

Morro replied:

Do not frame things.

Lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Geometry probation continued.

Cole sat in silence.

Baren studied him.

"You have geometry face."

Cole nodded.

"Severe."

"Keep."

"Keeping."

"Good."

Lila gave the safe update after lunch.

“Court ordered adults to inventory not just whether campaign materials showed you, but whether your absence was doing work for adults.”

Baren listened.

“Used empty.”

Lila looked at him.

“What?”

“Empty can work.”

“Yes.”

“Did adults say?”

“Bex said non-display was doing work.”

Baren nodded.

“Good adult.”

“Useful adult.”

“Still watched.”

“Yes.”

He looked toward his door.

“My empty is not job.”

Morro, passing with coffee, stopped.

Baren looked at her.

“Ask.”

“May we use an adult version?”

“Yes.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

A protected person’s absence should not be made to perform emotional, reputational, political, spiritual, institutional, or financial labor for adults. Non-display should be reviewed when records show that absence was expected to do work.

Baren read it.

“Good.”

Then:

“Empty is not employee.”

Morro’s face changed.

Baren sighed.

“Yes. Adult.”

The guidance added only what adults needed:

Empty is not employee. A person’s absence does not become available labor merely because adults avoid direct display.

Morro whispered, “This is why doctrines are born.”

Baren pointed.

“No doctrine.”

“Doctrine withdrawn unborn.”

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

No fact.

She had article face.

She admitted it before Baren had to accuse her.

“Article face,” she said.

“Self-caught.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

She sat.

The cow puzzle box remained closed.

Baren asked, “Did your article use empty?”

“No images. No empty chair. No symbolic room.”

“Good.”

“We quoted Bex.”

“Adult quote.”

“Yes.”

“Non-display doing work.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Mara paused.

“Do you want a fact?”

“Not today.”

“Okay.”

They sat without fact.

This was harder than facts.

Facts were small bridges.

No fact meant they had to trust the floor.

After seven minutes, Baren said, “You can go.”

Mara nodded.

“Okay.”

She left without asking if she had done well.

She had.

At 2:30 p.m., the absence inventory expanded into institutions.

Campaign first.

Then foundation.

Then church.

Then school.

Then media.

Once the category existed, records began crawling toward it.

A private school admitted it had used a nameless “resilience case” in a staff training where the child was identifiable to several employees.

A church admitted a sermon about “the unnamed child at the center of our repentance” had been delivered to a congregation that knew exactly whom the bishop meant.

A foundation admitted its annual report had used a silhouette labeled **future leadership protected by silence**, tied internally to Baren’s case.

Morro read that one and said, “I need a walk.”

She did not take one.

She wrote.

The public bulletin expanded:

Implied use is not limited to campaigns. Schools, faith institutions, nonprofits, media outlets, courts, employers, and advocacy groups should assess whether unnamed stories, symbolic objects, silhouettes, empty rooms, anonymized examples, or absent figures are identifiable to the audience and used for institutional benefit.

Baren reviewed the safe version.

“Good. Add class.”

“Class?” Lila asked.

“If class knows, anonymous is fake.”

The bulletin added:

An example is not meaningfully anonymous if the relevant audience can identify the person.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Then:

“Fake anonymous is costume.”

Morro looked at him.

He looked back.

“Yes. Adult.”

The bulletin added:

Anonymity should not function as costume. If context makes identity apparent, institutions should treat the material as identifiable and seek appropriate consent, safeguards, or exclusion.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Nothing in hand.

Five minutes.

Baren asked, "Did people use empty me at church?"

Serena's face tightened.

"I have been told some did."

"Did you?"

"I sat in rooms where people said 'a child' and everyone knew."

"Did you stop?"

"No."

Useful answer.

Sad answer.

Where sad went was now understood.

Adults.

He nodded.

"Fake anonymous."

"Yes."

"Not yours."

"No."

Timer buzzed.

He said, "Done."

She stood.

At the door, she said, "If people say 'a child' and mean you, I will not let that pass as protection."

Baren considered.

"Medium good."

She accepted medium.

Left.

No extra.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald's adult channel produced the supplemental absence inventory early.

This worried Morro.

Fast compliance could be helpful.

Or curated.

The inventory included a column Bex had added herself:

Could message function without audience knowledge of child?

Many answers were no.

That column mattered.

Mara's newsroom reported it without publishing the table.

Adult systems were learning to ask whether empty was doing work.

Elsewhere.

Not in Baren's room.

Mostly.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

Future folder.

Page:

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

He picked up the pencil.

Thought.

Then wrote:

empty too

Now six lines.

No sentence.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro said nothing.

Lila said nothing.

Cole, from good distance three, said nothing.

Nurse Imani at the desk said nothing.

Silence did the correct job.

Before bed, Baren asked, "Can empty be protected?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Can empty be used?"

"Yes."

“Can empty be mine?”

“Yes.”

“Can adults tell difference?”

“Sometimes. With records.”

“Good.”

He turned toward the wall.

“My empty is not job.”

“Correct.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, the absence inventory moved through campaigns, schools, churches, foundations, and media rooms.

Elsewhere, adults learned that anonymity could be fake and silence could be dressed.

Elsewhere, empty was finally asked what work it had been made to do.

Here, the future folder held six pencil lines.

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

empty too

No sentence.

No explanation.

Not a deposition.

Enough.

CHAPTER SEVENTY-NINE

No Bait

Dahlia arrived in court through counsel and a filing that smelled like expensive paper even through the electronic docket.

She did not attend in person.

Detention had limited her appetite for dramatic entrances, though not eliminated her taste for future architecture.

Her petition had been stripped by Judge Havel of emergency clothing and placed on the calendar like everything else that wanted the court's time.

Ordinary course.

Three weeks after filing.

No rush.

No candle.

No scarf.

Morro considered this one of civilization's finer achievements.

The hearing was sealed in part, public in part, and boring by design.

The public portion would address general standards.

The sealed portion would address Baren-specific materials.

Baren would not attend.

His lawyer would.

His clinician would.

His special master would.

His future would have representation without becoming present theater.

At breakfast, Baren asked, "Dahlia day?"

Lila looked up.

"Yes. Court day."

"Do I go?"

"No."

"Do I decide today?"

"No."

"Do adults decide about rules?"

"Yes."

"Lawyer cereal?"

"Very much."

He nodded.

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No future folder at table.

No bait.

Toast was not bait because toast did not promise later meaning.

It promised crumbs.

And delivered.

The public portion began at 9:00 a.m.

Judge Havel opened with a warning.

"This hearing concerns future-access procedures for protected records. It is not a forum for litigating the protected minor's identity, wishes, future emotional state, or relationship to interested adults."

Morro approved the first sentence and spiritually laminated it.

Dahlia's counsel rose.

He argued that protection, if too complete, could become deprivation. He argued that future autonomy required preserving more than sterile records. He argued that human beings did not encounter truth as indexes. They encountered truth through voice, memory, relationship, and contested meaning.

Morro hated how not entirely wrong he was.

Bad actors did this.

They smuggled legitimate concerns in velvet bags.

Dahlia's counsel continued.

"If this court permits only institutional summaries and legal categories, the child's future self may be deprived of the very materials necessary to understand how others saw him, loved him, failed him, or tried to protect him."

Morro wrote:

HE WANTS THE BAIT CALLED HUMANITY

Lila, seated beside her, saw it.

Did not smile.

Because the argument was dangerous precisely because it knew where the truth lived.

Judge Havel asked, "Counsel, are you asking that interested-adult statements be delivered automatically at eighteen?"

"No, Your Honor."

"On a birthday?"

"No."

"With ceremony?"

"No."

"Through direct contact?"

"No."

"Then what exactly do you seek?"

Counsel adjusted.

"A requirement that the protected person be affirmatively informed, at appropriate intervals, that these human materials exist and that suppressing them may impair his self-understanding."

There.

Affirmatively informed.

At intervals.

The future knocking politely every year.

Lila rose.

"No."

One word.

Enough for the room.

Then she added law because courts required more than correct monosyllables.

Lila argued cleanly.

Future access rights mattered.

Records about a protected person should not be destroyed, hidden indefinitely, or curated solely by institutions.

But access had to belong to the protected person, not to the adult who wrote the most emotional letter.

She described the Record Access Pathway.

Notice of existence.

Neutral index.

Summary first.

Originals by category.

Interested-adult statements separate.

Content advisories, not feeling prophecies.

No automatic delivery.

No ceremony.

No countdown.

No bait.

No repeated reminders framed as care.

No design pressure.

No direct adult claim.

No obligation to respond.

No single irreversible truth event.

No treating future access as advertisement, leverage, redemption, donor reassurance, litigation pressure, or delayed persuasion.

Judge Havel asked, "Is there a risk that an index sanitizes the record?"

Lila answered, "Yes. That is why the index must identify contested materials, interested parties, corrections, source, custody, and available originals. But an index gives choice. Bait takes it."

Morro wrote:

INDEX GIVES CHOICE. BAIT TAKES IT.

She looked at Baren's empty chair.

There was no empty chair.

She looked at the table instead.

Dr. Rao testified next.

She was precise.

Precision made her kind.

“Protected minors may later want information that would be harmful or coercive if delivered earlier. Future access planning should preserve the person’s ability to choose later without making later stare at them throughout childhood.”

Dahlia’s counsel asked, “Isn’t withholding human narrative also a form of influence?”

“Yes,” Dr. Rao said.

The room listened harder.

“That is why no one here proposes destruction or indefinite withholding. The question is architecture. Does the system preserve access while minimizing pressure? Or does it preserve adult claims by embedding reminders, ceremonial delivery, or emotionally loaded materials into the child’s developmental environment?”

Counsel asked, “Who decides what is emotionally loaded?”

“Initially, trained reviewers under court supervision. Later, the protected person.”

“Isn’t that paternalistic?”

“All child protection is vulnerable to paternalism,” Dr. Rao said. “That is why review, counsel, records, and staged choice matter. But the alternative cannot be allowing interested adults to pressure a child in the name of preventing pressure.”

Morro wrote:

THE ALTERNATIVE CANNOT BE THE HARM WE ARE NAMING

Adult.

Public.

Maybe.

Mara watched from the press room.

The public feed had no protected details.

Good.

Her headline drafts fought her.

Dahlia Loses Future Claim

Too early.

Too dramatic.

Court Weighs Autonomy and Protection in Future Records Fight

Better.

Still scarf-adjacent.

Final:

Court Reviews Future-Access Rules for Protected Minor Records

Dry.

Morro would approve.

The article explained competing legal principles without centering Dahlia’s emotional framing.

Future autonomy.

Present protection.

Records.

Indexes.

Interested-adult statements.

No automatic delivery.

No direct quotes from sealed materials.

No speculation about Baren's future wishes.

One paragraph mattered:

The question before the court is not whether the protected person may someday access records. All parties addressing the approved framework acknowledged some form of future access. The dispute is whether adult-authored materials should be preserved as optional records or allowed to function as recurring claims on the child's present attention.

Morro read it during recess.

Approved.

"Good."

Mara replied:

No scarf?

Minimal scarf.

Baren spent the morning in school.

Math.

Percentages.

Then writing.

Ms. Rowe asked whether he wanted a prompt.

"No."

"Free write?"

"No."

"Reading?"

"No."

"Worksheet?"

"Yes."

Sorting.

Shapes.

Colors.

No feelings.

He completed the worksheet and wrote at the bottom:

A circle is not a promise.

Ms. Rowe looked at it.

Baren shrugged.

“Shape fact.”

“School folder?”

“Yes.”

School folder.

Not drawer.

Lila did not ask.

Morro was in court and therefore unable to injure herself over the sentence.

This was healthy for everyone.

At noon, Lila returned for lunch update.

Grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole remained under geometry probation and therefore allowed the sandwich to exist unclassified.

Baren looked at Lila.

“Did Dahlia try?”

“Yes.”

“What did she want?”

“She wanted the court to make future access more like recurring notice of adult statements.”

“Knocking future.”

“Yes.”

“Court?”

“Still hearing. But the judge asked hard questions.”

“Does future folder change?”

“No.”

“Does me page change?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He took a bite.

“Bait?”

Lila nodded.

“That is the word adults are using.”

“What is bait?”

“Something designed to make you bite before you choose freely.”

“Like syrup?”

Cole made a noise.

Baren looked at him.

“No.”

Cole nodded.

“Withdrawn internally.”

Baren thought.

“No bait is good.”

“Yes.”

He looked at the drawer.

“Future can have food but no bait.”

Morro was absent, which saved the room.

Lila smiled.

“Private?”

“Private.”

Good.

The sealed portion began at 1:30 p.m.

No press.

No public feed.

Dahlia’s purported future letter.

The leaked line.

The scenario maps.

The design mockups.

Chronald’s potential future statement.

Serena’s possible therapy writings.

Trust archives.

Court summaries.

Corrections.

Interested-adult labels.

The special evidence master had prepared a sample index using neutral entries.

Dahlia’s letter did not appear as:

Dahlia Voss’s Loving Letter to Baren

No.

It appeared as:

Record F-017. Creator: Dahlia Voss. Date: unknown/reconstructed. Category: Interested-Adult Statement. Status: contested. Source: trust archive copy. Chain of custody: under investigation. Related materials: crisis communications scenario map; leaked excerpt; protective order violation inquiry. Content advisory: contains claims regarding future

relationship, adult motives, and disputed events. Access stage: optional interested-adult statements after neutral index and summary access. Corrections available: yes.

Morro nearly wept from dryness.

Dahlia's counsel objected that the description prejudiced the future reader.

Judge Havel asked, "Which part is inaccurate?"

Counsel argued that "interested-adult statement" sounded suspect.

Judge Havel replied, "It is an interested-adult statement."

Counsel argued that mentioning the leak and scenario map would contaminate the letter's emotional context.

The judge said, "The context is part of the record."

Morro wrote:

CONTEXT IS NOT CONTAMINATION WHEN IT IS TRUE

Lila saw.

Nodded once.

Serena's possible future writing was treated differently.

Not better because she was mother.

Different because source, purpose, custody, and use differed.

No submitted letter yet.

Therapy writings not in court file.

No automatic inclusion.

If later submitted, they would be labeled:

Interested-parent statement.

Optional.

Separate.

No delivery without Baren's future choice.

No claim of truth status.

No emotional priority.

Serena's current compliance and therapy could be noted elsewhere if relevant, but her sadness would not make the letter central.

Chronald's future statement request was categorized similarly:

Interested-parent statement.

Not accepted yet.

No emotional delivery.

No automatic access.

Could be submitted later under rules.

Campaign records separate from personal statements.

Good.

Adults could want.

The system did not have to hand their want to the child.

At 3:00 p.m., Judge Havel ruled from the bench on the framework.

Written order to follow.

But the ruling was clear.

Dahlia's petition was denied as to recurring affirmative reminders, autonomy liaison, emotional delivery requirements, and any structure that would require Baren to receive interested-adult narratives at intervals.

Denied.

Denied.

Denied.

Morro wrote the word three times and then stopped because enjoying denial too much was unseemly.

The court approved the Record Access Pathway in principle.

Neutral index.

Staged access.

Independent counsel.

Clinical support.

Separate interested-adult category.

No ceremony.

No automatic birthday delivery.

No countdown.

No bait.

No design pressure.

No required response.

No public use.

No treating leaks as access.

No allowing interested adults to convert future rights into present pressure.

Judge Havel said:

"The future protected person may have a right to know. Interested adults do not have a right to be awaited."

Morro stopped writing.

Lila looked at the judge.

Dr. Rao closed her eyes briefly.

That was the line.

Adult.

Court-born.

Public in written order if retained.

Not Baren's.

Good.

Baren was in the courtyard when Lila returned.

Cole at good distance.

Sad maple doing neutral tree.

Lila sat on the bench, leaving space.

"Court update?"

"Yes."

"Dahlia?"

"She does not get recurring reminders. No autonomy liaison. No birthday ceremony. No forced letter. Future records will use an index and support."

Baren listened.

"No bait?"

"No bait."

"Future folder okay?"

"Yes."

"Me page okay?"

"Yes."

"Dahlia letter?"

"Separate, contested, optional later if future you chooses through the pathway."

"Not now?"

"Not now."

He nodded.

"Good."

Lila added, "The judge said interested adults do not have a right to be awaited."

Baren looked at her.

"That is good adult."

"Yes."

"Court can keep."

"Yes."

He looked at Cole.

"Available is not awaited."

Cole nodded.

"True yes."

The tree did nothing symbolic.

Everyone appreciated it.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena requested no visit.

Therapy.

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

No message.

Chronald sent no message.

Good.

Dahlia’s counsel issued a public statement claiming partial victory because future access had been preserved.

Morro read it.

“Of course.”

Mara’s newsroom did not frame it as victory.

Headline:

Court Rejects Recurring Notice Proposal, Approves Neutral Future-Access Framework

Dry.

Accurate.

The article noted that future access was preserved, but adult-authored materials would be separated, labeled, and optional.

No clips.

No letter.

No bait.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate most.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

Future folder.

Safe summary.

Page:

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

empty too

He picked up the ordinary pencil.

For a long time, he did nothing.

Then he wrote:

not awaited

Seven lines.

No sentence.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro, told later, sat down.

“Court line,” Lila said.

“He chose it.”

“Yes.”

“Private?”

“Yes.”

Morro nodded.

“Then private.”

The court could keep its version.

Baren could keep his.

Different rooms.

Before bed, Baren asked, “Can future be mine and not awaited?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Can adults want and not get?”

“Yes.”

“Can Dahlia wait and it not matter?”

“Yes.”

“Can I not wait?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, Dahlia’s petition lost its teeth.

Elsewhere, the court approved indexes over candles.

Elsewhere, future access survived without becoming a future leash.

Here, the drawer held a folder that no longer had to be empty to stay safe.

No bait.

No ceremony.

No waiting child.

CHAPTER EIGHTY

The Index Holds

The written order arrived at 8:04 a.m.

This was rude.

Court orders should not arrive before breakfast unless someone was on fire, missing, or attempting to turn a child into a legal metaphor with immediate effect.

No one was on fire.

Morro objected to timing in principle while opening the order immediately.

Lila poured coffee.

Nurse Imani blocked the hallway.

Baren slept.

Judge Havel's order was fifty-two pages.

Beautifully ugly.

Morro scanned the headings first.

I. Procedural Posture

Good.

II. Protected Minor Future Access Interests

Good.

III. Present Protection From Future-Oriented Pressure

Better.

IV. Interested-Adult Statements

V. Neutral Index and Staged Review

Very good.

VI. Prohibition on Ceremonial, Automatic, or Designed Delivery

Morro whispered, "There you are."

VII. Leaked Materials and Protective Purpose

Good.

VIII. Continuing Jurisdiction

Necessary.

The order approved the Record Access Pathway.

It denied Dahlia's request for recurring affirmative notice.

It denied appointment of an autonomy liaison.

It denied automatic delivery of interested-adult materials.

It denied birthday-triggered disclosure.

It denied any process requiring Baren to respond, acknowledge, forgive, reject, or explain.

It preserved his future access rights.

It preserved records.

It required neutral indexing.

It required source and interest labels.

It required context for leaks, scenario maps, design mockups, and disputed materials.

It required any interested-adult statement to be segregated from factual records unless future Baren specifically chose to view that category.

It allowed future Baren to write first.

Or not at all.

Morro read that line three times.

The protected person may choose to access, pause, decline, return, summarize, review originals, respond, write first, or not respond at all.

She put the order down.

Lila looked at her.

“Good?”

“Good.”

Baren still slept.

The index had held while he did nothing.

That was the point.

Breakfast was pancakes.

Again.

This had become suspicious.

Baren looked at Nurse Imani.

“Kitchen is campaign.”

“No,” Nurse Imani said.

“Testing pancakes.”

“No.”

“Polling?”

“No.”

“Audience inference?”

“You asked for pancakes twice and we had batter.”

He considered.

“Receipts?”

She produced the kitchen slip.

PANCAKE BATTER — USE BY TODAY.

Baren nodded.

“Good.”

Morro, from the lounge, said, “Excellent documentation.”

Baren pointed.

“Breakfast zone.”

“Withdrawn.”

He ate one pancake.

Half of another.

Syrup on the side.

The written order waited in the adult folder.

Not breakfast.

After breakfast, Lila asked, “Do you want court update?”

“Yes.”

“Short or lawyer cereal?”

“Medium cereal.”

“Court approved the future-access rules. No birthday ceremony. No forced letters. No recurring reminders. No bait. Future you can use the index, summaries, support, or originals if you choose. You can pause, decline, return, write first, or not respond.”

Baren listened.

“Dahlia?”

“No recurring notice. No autonomy liaison. Her materials, if preserved, are separate, contested, optional, and labeled.”

“Good.”

“Do you want to see safe summary later?”

“Yes. Drawer later.”

“Okay.”

He ate the rest of the half pancake.

“Index holds.”

Lila smiled.

“Yes.”

Morro stopped moving.

Baren looked at her.

“Court adult. Public if needed.”

The phrase entered no guidance because the order already existed.

Sometimes adults could resist.

School began with reading.

Ms. Rowe brought a book about maps.

Not law maps.

Geography maps.

Rivers.

Mountains.

Roads.

Symbols.

Legends.

Baren was suspicious but interested.

“What is legend?”

“Key,” Ms. Rowe said. “It explains symbols.”

“Legend sounds like adults lying.”

“On maps, it is supposed to help.”

“Supposed.”

“Yes.”

He studied a map showing water in blue, roads in red, parks in green.

“Map is not place.”

“Correct.”

“Can help find.”

“Yes.”

“Can also hide.”

“Yes.”

Good teacher.

He read one paragraph.

Then said, “Index is map?”

Lila looked up.

“Yes. Sort of.”

“Not place.”

“No.”

“Not truth whole.”

“No.”

“Helps find.”

“Yes.”

“Can hide if bad.”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“No guidance.”

“No guidance,” Lila said.

Ms. Rowe wrote:

Read map passage. Discussed legend/key and map symbols.

School.

Enough.

At 10:00 a.m., the leaked future letter source chain produced sanctions.

Not final punishment.

Interim sanctions.

The trust consultant was ordered to preserve devices and communications.

The crisis communications subcontractor was barred from further contact with protected materials.

The “Children Deserve Truth Now” account was referred for investigation into funding, coordination, and knowing receipt.

Parties and agents were reminded that materials designed for future access remained subject to protective purpose even outside formal sealed files.

Judge Havel added:

Leakage is not access. Virality is not consent. Public curiosity is not a support plan.

Morro sat back.

“Good judge.”

Mara’s newsroom reported the sanctions.

No link to the video.

No quote from the letter.

No emotional framing.

Headline:

Court Sanctions Consultant Network Over Circulation of Protected Future-Letter Material

Dry.

Good.

The article traveled moderately.

The leaked piano video still traveled more.

But now every repost carried a risk note from platforms that had received court notices.

Not enough.

Something.

Records moved slower than violins.

They also left tracks.

At noon, lunch was soup.

Baren looked at it.

“No.”

Soup left.

No replacement was offered immediately.

Good.

Then Nurse Imani asked, “Alternative available: grilled cheese or remaining pancake.”

“Grilled cheese.”

Straight cut.

Cole remained silent.

Baren gave him one permitted line.

Cole said, “Rectangles comply.”

“Accepted.”

Morro whispered, “A low point for geometry.”

Lila whispered, “Still better than yesterday.”

After lunch, Baren asked for the safe written-order summary.

Lila brought it.

Two pages.

Plain.

No design.

No bold except headings.

No music.

No countdown.

No “when you are ready.”

He read slowly.

Future access exists.

Not now.

Index first.

Summaries.

Originals.

Interested-adult statements separate.

No automatic letters.

No birthday event.

No required response.

Write first or not.

Pause.

Decline.

Return.

Support.

Leaks do not count.

Public curiosity does not decide.

He nodded.

“Drawer.”

He opened the drawer.

Removed **FUTURE — NOT NOW.**

Placed the order summary inside, after the pathway summary, before the pencil page.

Then stopped.

Moved the pencil page to the front.

Lila saw.

Said nothing.

The folder order became:

Pencil page.

Pathway summary.

Court order summary.

Blank sheet behind.

Baren closed it.

Returned it.

Opened once.

Still there.

Closed.

“Mine first,” he said.

“Yes,” Lila said.

No public.

Morro was told later and aged six years privately.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara requested visit.

Through Lila.

Message:

Available today or tomorrow. No fact unless asked. No response needed if not wanted.

Baren chose today.

Mara arrived at 2:00.

Not early.

Good.

She sat.

Baren said, "Index holds."

"I heard."

"Article?"

"Yes."

"Did you use letter?"

"No."

"Did you use court?"

"Yes."

"Good."

"Fact?"

"Do you want one?"

"Yes."

"Some maps used to have blank spaces not because nothing was there, but because the mapmaker did not know or did not want to show it."

Baren thought.

"Trust fact?"

"Yes."

"Halfway."

"Accepted."

"Blank can mean not known."

"Yes."

"Or not shown."

"Yes."

"Or protected."

"Yes."

"Or used empty."

"Yes."

"Maps are dangerous."

"Yes."

"No map doctrine."

"No map doctrine."

Visit lasted ten minutes.

Mara left available.

Not waiting.

At 3:00 p.m., the index standards spread.

Courts in two other jurisdictions requested copies of the neutral indexing order.

A hospital system asked whether the staged-access framework could apply to adolescent patients whose parents had submitted contested letters to medical files.

A university asked whether student disciplinary records involving identifiable anonymized examples required similar indexing.

A faith network asked for guidance on future letters in survivor archives.

Morro read the requests.

“Good.”

Then frowned.

“Also dangerous.”

Lila nodded.

“Replication can flatten context.”

The guidance desk added one plain rule:

Do not copy future-access frameworks mechanically. The principles may transfer, but each protected person’s age, wishes, records, legal posture, safety, culture, disability, family context, and support structure matter.

Baren reviewed the safe version.

“Good. No cookie cutter.”

Morro looked at him.

He sighed.

“Yes. Adult.”

The guidance kept the usable part:

No cookie-cutter protection. A framework that prevents pressure in one case can create pressure in another if copied without attention to the protected person.

Baren approved.

“Good. Cookies are bait sometimes.”

Morro refused to ask.

Growth.

At 4:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren told her, “Court said future me can write first or not.”

Serena’s eyes filled but did not spill.

“Good.”

“Dahlia does not get awaited.”

“Good.”

“You?”

She took a breath.

“I do not get awaited either.”

“Good.”

“I can be available through rules.”

“Yes.”

“Not waiting at you.”

“Yes.”

Timer buzzed.

“Done.”

She stood.

At the door, she said, “I will let the index hold.”

Baren considered.

“Medium good.”

She smiled.

“I accept.”

Left.

No extra.

At 5:30 p.m., Chronald’s counsel sent a compliance notice accepting the Record Access Pathway for any future statement he might later request to submit.

The notice included one sentence:

Mr. Sump acknowledges that any future statement from him, if accepted at all, would be optional, interested-parent material and not part of factual record delivery.

Morro read it.

“Good if meant.”

Lila nodded.

“Early trying.”

“Still.”

Bex attached nothing.

No unnecessary note.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he opened the future folder.

Pencil page first.

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

empty too

not awaited

He took the pencil.

Wrote:

write first

Then looked at it.

Eight lines.

No sentence.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro did not explode.

Barely.

Before bed, Baren asked, "Can index hold if I never open?"

Lila said, "Yes."

"Can it hold if I open?"

"Yes."

"Can it hold if I read one thing and stop?"

"Yes."

"Can it hold if I write first?"

"Yes."

"Can it hold if I write nothing?"

"Yes."

He nodded.

"Good index."

"Yes."

Door half open.

Cole at good distance three.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in lounge, reading the order again because good legal ugliness deserved respect.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, the index became a model but not a mold.

Elsewhere, leaked bait became sanction material.

Elsewhere, courts began learning that future access could be preserved without making a child wait for adult letters.

Here, the future folder held eight pencil lines.

No sentence.

But the first page was his.

CHAPTER EIGHTY-ONE

Far Scaffolding

Far scaffolding sounded sad until it worked.

Then it sounded like engineering.

Serena had become far scaffolding by doing three things no one had trusted her to keep doing:

She came through rules.

She left when time ended.

She took her want somewhere else.

This did not make her repaired.

This did not make motherhood clean.

This did not rewrite the rooms where she had allowed Baren's absence to become usefulness for adults who knew better and adults who claimed not to.

It made her safer today.

Today mattered.

Morro distrusted redemption arcs because they moved too smoothly. They took a person who had done harm, handed them one good speech, one tear, one sacrificed object, one beautiful line near a doorway, and then asked everyone to accept plot as evidence.

Serena did not get plot.

She got five minutes.

Sometimes no minutes.

Therapy.

Counsel.

Rules.

Review.

No gifts.

No photos.

No public mothering.

No emotional invoices presented to a child.

Far scaffolding.

At breakfast, Baren asked, "Serena day?"

Lila checked the schedule.

"She requested afternoon. You can decide later."

"Good."

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

No card.

No mother.

No future folder.

No court order.

Just toast.

Cole sat at good distance three, which had begun to feel less like absence and more like air.

That was the goal.

Nurse Imani asked if Baren wanted school before or after drawer check.

"Before."

Everyone noticed.

No one commented.

He had not checked the drawer first.

Not because the drawer mattered less.

Because it could wait.

Available.

Not waiting.

The drawer survived.

So did everyone else, barely.

School began with grammar.

Ms. Rowe brought verbs.

This was reckless.

Baren looked at the worksheet.

"I knew verbs would come."

"They usually do."

"Verbs make I do things."

“Yes.”

He studied the list:

am

choose

keep

wait

write

read

stop

He pointed at **wait**.

“No.”

Ms. Rowe crossed it out.

He approved.

He pointed at **am**.

“Dangerous.”

“Yes.”

He pointed at **choose**.

“Useful.”

“Yes.”

He pointed at **stop**.

“Good.”

He wrote:

I choose.

Then stopped.

He stared at the sentence.

Two words.

Subject.

Verb.

A sentence now.

Not in the future folder.

On a school worksheet.

He looked at Lila.

“School.”

“Yes.”

“Not drawer.”

“Okay.”

He wrote another:

I stop.

Then:

I keep.

Then he stopped.

No sentence with **am**.

Not yet.

School note:

Verb practice completed. Student wrote three short sentences.

Baren approved.

Morro was not in the doorway because Lila had placed an actual chair in her path and called it “environmental boundary support.”

Morro respected the chair.

Mostly because she respected furniture with purpose.

At 10:00 a.m., Chronald’s transition conference began.

Not visit.

Not apology.

Not father-son anything.

Adult transition.

Chronald’s counsel, Lila, Morro, Dr. Patel, Bex, and a court liaison attended.

Chronald appeared by secure video from the residence where he was recovering physically and losing publicly with the quiet difficulty of a man who had spent most of his life mistaking cameras for oxygen.

He looked older.

This was not moral evidence.

Injury aged people.

Consequences aged people.

Lack of applause aged people.

All three had happened.

Morro opened.

“This conference concerns adult accountability channels, not emotional access.”

Chronald nodded.

“I understand.”

Morro waited.

He did not add anything.

Good.

Lila laid out the rules.

No direct contact unless Baren requested and the care team approved.

No public statements about fatherhood, privacy, sacrifice, restraint, silence, or protection.

No use of absence.

No implied objects.

No family imagery.

No future letters submitted until the court finalized interested-parent statement procedures.

No messages routed to Baren for reassurance.

Adult accountability updates through counsel only.

If Baren asked, safe summaries.

Chronald listened.

Then said, "I would like to comply."

Morro said, "Compliance is not a feeling."

Chronald nodded.

"I will comply."

Better.

Bex looked down.

Not relief.

Documentation.

Chronald added, "I will not ask him to carry my wanting."

The room went still.

Morro did not like good sentences from late adults.

They complicated contempt.

"Who wrote that?" she asked.

Chronald looked at her.

"No one."

Morro looked at Bex.

Bex shook her head.

Morro looked back.

"Then keep it out of public."

"Yes."

Sad.

Late.

Still watched.

Baren did not attend Chronald's transition conference.

He was in math.

Fractions.

One-half.

One-fourth.

Three-fourths.

One whole.

Then mixed numbers.

He disliked mixed numbers because they looked like numbers that could not decide whether they had finished being two things.

Ms. Rowe said that was not wrong.

He appreciated that.

He solved four problems and declined one.

No reason.

Accepted.

Then asked, "Can adults be mixed numbers?"

Ms. Rowe looked at Lila.

Lila said, "They can be more than one thing."

"Bad and useful?"

"Yes."

"Late and trying?"

"Yes."

"Parent and not safe?"

"Yes."

He nodded.

"Mixed numbers are annoying."

"Yes."

No guidance.

No public.

School note:

Fractions and mixed numbers introduced. Four completed. One declined.

Safe.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole's geometry probation had been reduced to supervised release.

He said, "Triangles return under conditions."

Baren considered.

"Accepted."

Morro, from the lounge, said, "Probation violation pending."

Cole nodded.

"Fair."

After lunch, Lila gave Baren the safe Chronald update.

"Chronald agreed to adult rules. No direct messages unless you ask and it is approved. No public fatherhood language. No future letter yet. Updates through counsel."

Baren listened.

"Did he want?"

"Yes."

"Did he give me want?"

"No."

"Good."

"He said he will not ask you to carry his wanting."

Baren looked at the table.

"That is good adult."

"Yes."

"Still early trying."

"Yes."

"Still watched."

"Yes."

He nodded.

"Good."

Then:

"Want is heavy."

Morro closed her eyes in the lounge.

Baren looked toward her.

"Private."

"Private."

At 1:30 p.m., Serena's visit request came due.

Baren said yes.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

She entered looking calm in a way that suggested rehearsal, therapy, and fear had formed a temporary alliance.

Baren sat at the common table.

No puzzle.

No folder.

Just table.

He said, "Chronald had rules."

Serena nodded.

"I heard there was a conference."

"He wants."

"Yes."

"You want."

"Yes."

"Want is heavy."

Serena did not reach for the sentence.

Good.

"It is mine to carry," she said.

"Good."

He looked at her.

"Are you far scaffolding?"

"I am trying to be."

"What if I do not need scaffolding later?"

"Then I leave that role."

"What if I need different?"

"Then adults review."

"What if I never want close?"

Her face changed.

Pain.

Then placement.

"Then I stay far if allowed, or not available if that is safer."

Useful answer.

Sad answer.

He nodded.

"Good."

Timer buzzed.

Done.

She stood.

At the door, she said, "I will not make you explain distance."

Baren considered.

"That is good."

"Medium?"

“Medium good.”

She accepted medium and left.

No extra.

Morro, told later, said, “Correct.”

Then added, “Unpleasantly correct.”

At 2:30 p.m., the Support Checks were updated.

Mara: available for visits, no work, no scheduled facts unless requested, review in two weeks.

Crowe: available for plain facts if asked, no pastoral role, no emotional processing, adult advisory elsewhere, review in two weeks.

Cole: protective presence continuing with distance adjustments, supervision required, Baren may request more or less distance, review weekly.

Serena: far scaffolding, visits optional, therapy continuing, no emotional burden, review biweekly.

Chronald: adult accountability channel only, no direct emotional access, no public use, review monthly.

Morro: not listed.

Baren noticed.

“Where is Morro?”

Everyone froze.

Morro, from the lounge, said, “I am court function.”

Baren looked at Lila.

“Is she scaffolding?”

Lila answered carefully.

“Yes. Also court function.”

Morro looked offended by also and touched by scaffolding, which created a facial emergency.

Baren said, “She needs leaving rules too.”

Silence.

Correct silence.

Morro set down her coffee.

“Yes,” she said.

The room changed.

Because Morro had said yes.

Not argued.

Not defined jurisdiction.

Not hidden behind appointment orders.

Yes.

Lila added a Support Check category.

Morro: special master/court-appointed adult. Contact tied to court function and care-team coordination. No emotional access entitlement. Transition planning required when court role ends or changes. Baren may know how to contact through counsel if appropriate. Morro's emotional responses handled outside relationship.

Baren reviewed it.

"Good."

Then:

"Morro cannot become furniture."

Morro closed her eyes.

"May I—"

"Yes. Adult support rules."

The guidance kept the usable part:

Court-appointed, professional, or crisis-response adults should not become emotional furniture in a protected person's life simply because they were consistently present during crisis. Their roles require review, transition, and boundaries like any other support relationship.

Baren approved.

"Good."

Morro whispered, "I am not a chair."

Cole, from the hall, said, "Under review."

At 4:00 p.m., Crowe requested a short video check-in to ask whether he should remain available for facts at all.

Baren approved.

Crowe appeared on screen.

No sweater symbolism.

No ocean object.

Plain background.

"Do you want me available for facts?" Crowe asked.

Baren thought.

"Sometimes."

"Do you want me to ask first?"

"Yes."

"Do you want religious things?"

"No."

"Do you want me to tell you if I am sad?"

"No."

"Do you want me to go do adult sadness elsewhere?"

“Yes.”

Crowe nodded.

“I can do that.”

“Good.”

Crowe paused.

Then did not say more.

Baren smiled.

“Trying Adult.”

Crowe nodded once and ended the call.

No blessing.

No lingering.

No pastoral aftertaste.

Morro said, “He may survive.”

At 5:30 p.m., Mara’s Support Check produced a change.

Mara requested that visits be limited to twice weekly unless Baren asked otherwise, because she did not want her own attachment to become silent pressure.

Lila brought the request to Baren.

He read it.

“Mara made distance?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

“Do you agree?”

“Yes.”

“No response needed?”

“Tell her accepted. No response.”

Lila sent.

Mara did not respond.

Morro said, “She is learning leaving.”

“Trying Adult,” Baren said.

“Yes.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

Future folder.

He did not open it.

Instead, he moved the Support Checks above the future folder.

Then stopped.

Moved the future folder back on top.

Then placed Support Checks directly beneath it.

“Future first, people near second,” he said.

Lila nodded.

“Okay.”

He opened the future folder.

Lines:

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

empty too

not awaited

write first

He picked up the pencil.

Added:

want elsewhere

Nine lines.

No sentence.

He closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

Morro's face did something almost human.

Before bed, Baren asked, “Can people want and still be safe?”

Lila said, “Sometimes.”

“How?”

“They carry it somewhere else. They follow rules. They let you choose distance. They do not make their want your assignment.”

“Far scaffolding.”

“Yes.”

“Morro scaffolding?”

From the lounge, Morro said, “Temporarily.”

“Good.”

“Under court order.”

“Still scaffolding.”

Morro paused.

“Yes.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, parents learned wanting was not access.

Elsewhere, support adults gained exit plans.

Elsewhere, scaffolding became a rule instead of a mood.

Here, Baren slept with the drawer closed.

The people near him had rules.

The future had an index.

The wanting had somewhere else to go.

CHAPTER EIGHTY-TWO

Adult Work Elsewhere

The first sign that the work had moved elsewhere was that the hallway got quieter.

Not safe quiet.

Not abandoned quiet.

Working quiet.

The kind of quiet that happens when a room stops being the center of every emergency and becomes a room again.

By 8:00 a.m., no one had asked Baren to review guidance.

No one had brought him a court update before cereal.

No one had mentioned Dahlia.

No one had said future.

No one had said implied use.

No one had even said support check, though Morro had almost said transition protocol and been stopped by toast.

The adult work had not ended.

It had relocated.

Morro had a separate office now.

Not far.

Down the hall.

Still accessible through Lila.

Still court-connected.

Still terrifying.

But not in the lounge all day.

This had required a Support Check, two chair adjustments, and one argument in which Morro claimed proximity was efficient and Lila replied that efficiency was not the only god.

Baren had approved the office by asking one question:

“Can she come if asked?”

“Yes.”

“Can she not hover?”

Morro said, “Define hover.”

Baren said, “You.”

Morro accepted the office.

At breakfast, the lounge felt different.

More air.

Less judge.

Baren looked toward the empty coffee spot.

“Morro elsewhere.”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Bad?”

“No.”

“Good?”

“Maybe.”

“Available?”

“Yes.”

“Not waiting?”

“Trying.”

He nodded.

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough.

No soup.

No judge.

The cereal appeared comfortable with this.

Adult work elsewhere had many rooms.

Courtrooms.

Conference rooms.

Procurement offices.

Campaign archives.

Church basements.

University counsel suites.

Hospital policy committees.

Newsrooms.

Labor offices.

Therapy rooms.

Secure evidence rooms.

Platform trust desks.

A storage facility outside Baltimore where Civic Horizon Lab had apparently kept old design boards because consultants believed in retention until retention became discovery.

The search of that facility produced three more boxes.

Morro received notice in her new office.

She did not bring it to Baren.

The boxes contained public-trust lab materials from other cases.

Other children.

Other former minors.

Other workers.

Other parents.

Other “future leaders.”

Other “anonymous resilience narratives.”

The machine was wider.

Everyone had known.

Now they had boxes.

Boxes mattered.

The task force opened a separate docket branch.

Not Baren’s care docket.

Adult systems docket.

Baren’s name appeared only in cross-reference under sealed origin.

Good.

Mara’s newsroom published:

New Records Expand Review of Private Governance Practices Beyond Sump Case

Morro approved.

No Baren photo.

No child-centered headline.

No phrase “the boy who started it all.”

Mara had killed that phrase with her bare editorial hands.

Good.

School began with independent reading.

This was new.

Ms. Rowe placed three books on the table.

Ocean.

Dinosaurs.

Maps.

Baren could choose or not.

He chose maps.

Not because of index.

Because the cover had a compass and “compass looks like adult lost but confident.”

Ms. Rowe accepted.

He read silently for twelve minutes.

Silently.

No adult sentence.

No public principle.

At the end, Ms. Rowe asked, “Want to tell me what you read?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

School note:

Independent reading: map book, twelve minutes. Student declined summary.

Baren approved.

“Good.”

Lila looked almost teary.

Baren pointed at her.

“No.”

She nodded.

“No.”

Independent reading had happened and no one had harvested it.

Adult work elsewhere.

At 10:30 a.m., Cole’s chair moved again.

Good distance four.

Now he sat at the hall corner rather than directly outside the door during daytime.

Night presence remained closer.

Baren tested it by saying, "Cole."

Cole appeared within three seconds.

"Too fast," Baren said.

Cole paused.

"Want slower?"

"Normal fast."

"What is normal fast?"

"Not emergency fast."

Cole returned to the corner.

Baren called again.

Cole waited one breath before appearing.

"Better."

Cole nodded.

"Training."

"Annoying?"

"Yes."

"Useful?"

"Yes."

"Good."

This became no record except Cole's supervision note, which Baren did not have to read.

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole was too far for geometry.

This was a loss and a gain.

Baren ate half.

Then asked, "Any adult update?"

Lila said, "Separate adult work expanded to other cases. Your room is not the center."

He nodded.

"Good."

"Do you want more?"

"No."

Then:

"Other kids?"

"Protected."

"Names?"

“No.”

“Good.”

He looked at the plate.

“Adult work elsewhere.”

“Yes.”

“That can be public.”

The guidance desk did not need it.

Mara’s newsroom already used the same concept in adult words:

Investigations are now proceeding through adult-system dockets rather than the protected minor’s care process.

Baren approved the safe version later.

“Old oatmeal. Good.”

At 1:30 p.m., no visit.

Mara was unavailable because she was reporting on the storage facility.

Crowe was unavailable because he was in adult supervision with someone who apparently specialized in clergy guilt, which Morro called “hazardous waste management” and then refused to put in writing.

Serena had therapy.

Chronald had counsel.

Morro had office.

Cole had hall corner.

Nurse Imani had desk.

Lila had folder.

Baren had time.

Time was strange when adults stopped filling it to prove they cared.

He stood in the common room for several minutes.

Then asked for the cow puzzle.

Lila brought the box.

He opened it.

No dumping.

He selected three pieces.

Put two together.

Wrong.

Tried again.

Wrong.

Put them back.

Closed the box.

“Not puzzle.”

“Okay.”

No one asked what it meant.

It meant not puzzle.

Adult work elsewhere.

At 2:00 p.m., Judge Havel issued an order separating the adult-system investigation from Baren’s protective docket.

Morro read it in her office and said, “Correct.”

The order created:

Adult Systems Evidence Track.

Protected Minor Care Track.

Future Access Track.

Worker-Witness Protection Track.

Former-Minor Voluntary Participation Track.

Public Guidance Track.

Information could cross only through defined channels.

No adult-system filing could use Baren’s care records to dramatize urgency.

No protected care event could be referenced publicly without approval.

Adult cases would proceed without requiring child updates unless directly necessary.

Morro admired the architecture.

Not beautiful.

Functional.

Like a courthouse drainage system.

Essential and rarely praised.

Mara’s newsroom reported:

Court Separates Adult-System Investigation From Protected Minor Care Docket

Dry.

Good.

Baren was told safe version.

“Court made separate tracks so adult work does not keep coming through your room.”

He nodded.

“Tracks are map.”

“Yes.”

“Good map?”

“We think so.”

“Can map hide?”

“Yes.”

“Who watches map?”

“Morro, court, counsel, others.”

“Good.”

Then:

“My room is not track.”

Lila said, “Correct.”

At 3:30 p.m., Serena requested no visit and sent no message.

Chronald sent no message.

Mara sent no message.

Crowe sent no message.

Morro did not wander in.

Cole stayed at corner.

The quiet held.

Baren became suspicious.

“Is everyone dead?”

Nurse Imani looked up.

“No.”

“Quiet.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Adults are working elsewhere.”

He nodded.

“Feels weird.”

“Yes.”

“Good weird?”

“Maybe.”

He sat with that.

Good weird was still weird.

No one tried to turn it into comfort.

At 4:00 p.m., Baren asked to see Morro’s office.

This created procedural panic in Morro’s office, where no one had considered that relocation might invite inspection.

Lila asked, “Why?”

“Need know where available is.”

Fair.

Morro’s office was small.

Temporary.

Filing cabinet.

Desk.

Coffee.

Two chairs.

No child objects.

No photos.

No symbolic cow.

No emergency quote board.

Good.

Baren stood at the doorway.

“Boring.”

Morro said, “Thank you.”

“Can you work here?”

“Yes.”

“Can you come if asked?”

“Yes.”

“Can you not come if not asked?”

Morro paused.

“Yes.”

“Good office.”

He did not enter.

He turned and left.

Inspection complete.

Morro sat down after he left and did not write anything for thirty-seven seconds.

A personal record.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

Future folder.

Support Checks.

Orders.

He did not write in the future folder.

He did not open it.

He moved nothing.

Checked once.

Closed.

“Enough.”

Lila nodded.

“Enough.”

Morro was not in the lounge.

Good.

Cole at hall corner.

Good distance four.

Door half open.

Good.

Before bed, Baren asked, “Can adult work stay elsewhere?”

Lila answered, “That is the plan.”

“Plans can fail.”

“Yes.”

“Then review.”

“Yes.”

“Can my room be just room?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, boxes opened.

Elsewhere, dockets split.

Elsewhere, adult systems finally had to carry their own weight.

Here, Baren’s room was not a command center, hearing room, symbol chamber, evidence vault, campaign wound, church lesson, donor mirror, or future stage.

It was a room.

Half-open door.

Drawer.

Bed.

Side table.

A child inside.

Enough.

CHAPTER EIGHTY-THREE

The Future Could Wait

The sentence waited because adults had finally stopped waiting for it.

That helped.

Baren did not open the future folder for two days.

This was not regression.

This was not avoidance.

This was not denial.

This was not evidence of pressure, healing, fear, dissociation, autonomy, immaturity, maturity, identity integration, resistance, or any other phrase adults might have fed into a report if left unsupervised.

He did not open the future folder because he did not open the future folder.

The drawer still existed.

The folder still existed.

The page still existed.

The words still existed:

me

I

mine

not yours

also absence

empty too

not awaited

write first

want elsewhere

But Baren did not look.

Available.

Not waiting.

Morro did not ask.

Lila did not offer.

Nurse Imani did not mention.

Cole did not glance.

Ms. Rowe did not prompt future tense.

The first adult to almost ruin it was Crowe.

By accident.

He sent a screened message:

Plain fact available if wanted. No response needed.

Good.

Then added:

No pressure.

Bad.

Lila looked at the message.

Morro, in her office, said, "Delete last sentence."

Crowe was asked to revise.

He replied:

Plain fact available if wanted.

Better.

Baren read it.

"No response."

"Correct," Lila said.

"Fact later maybe."

"Okay."

No message sent.

Crowe survived.

Barely.

Breakfast was toast.

Edges off.

Butter present, not shiny.

Baren ate all of it.

This caused no adult reaction visible to the naked eye.

School began with verbs again.

Ms. Rowe brought a worksheet with simple sentences.

I run.

I read.

I write.

I am.

Baren stared at **I am**.

"Still dangerous."

"Yes," Ms. Rowe said.

"Can skip?"

"Yes."

He completed:

I read.

I choose.

I stop.

Then paused.

He copied **I am** onto his paper.

No predicate.

Just:

I am

He looked at it.

No period.

Ms. Rowe said nothing.

Lila said nothing.

The room understood that punctuation could be a cliff.

Baren placed the pencil down.

“School?”

Ms. Rowe answered carefully.

“Only if you want.”

He stared.

Then added a period.

I am.

The sentence sat there.

Small.

Complete.

Possibly too complete.

Baren looked at it with suspicion.

“Too much?”

Lila said, “You decide.”

He thought.

“Copy for school. Original drawer.”

Ms. Rowe copied it.

School copy filed.

Original page handed to him.

He did not put it in the future folder.

He placed it next to the pronoun pages.

Not future.

Not now.

Not public.

Just grammar.

Morro was not told until later.

When told, she went into her office and closed the door.

No one checked on her for seven minutes.

Kindness.

At noon, Baren asked for the adult update.

Lila said, "Adult systems continue elsewhere. No new Baren decisions needed."

"Dahlia?"

"Contained in future-access track."

"Chronald?"

"Adult accountability channel."

"Serena?"

"Therapy, optional visits."

"Morro?"

"Office."

"Cole?"

"Good distance."

"Mara?"

"Available tomorrow if asked."

"Crowe?"

"Fact available if wanted."

He nodded.

"Good."

Lunch was grilled cheese.

Diagonal.

Cole, from hall corner, called faintly, "Triangles remain distant."

Baren smiled.

"Accepted."

Geometry had survived relocation.

At 1:30 p.m., Baren requested Mara tomorrow.

Not today.

Lila sent:

Tomorrow requested. No response needed.

Mara did not respond.

At 2:00, he requested Crowe's fact.

Lila sent:

Fact requested. Plain.

Crowe sent:

Some deep-sea fish make their own light through bioluminescence.

Baren read it.

“Trust fact?”

“Yes,” Lila said.

“Halfway.”

“Accepted.”

“Own light?”

“Yes.”

“Adults will ruin.”

“Probably.”

“No guidance.”

He looked at the sentence again.

“Fact can stay outside.”

“Okay.”

No card.

No drawer.

No table.

Just fact.

Crowe did not send a second message.

Trying Adult.

At 3:00 p.m., Serena visited.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

Baren said, “I wrote I am.”

Serena’s face changed.

Then she controlled it.

“Does it belong to you?”

“Yes.”

“Then good.”

“Do not say proud.”

“I won’t.”

“Do you want to?”

“Yes.”

“Where want goes?”

“Adults.”

“Good.”

Timer buzzed.

Done.

She stood.

At the door, she said, "I am glad you have your words."

Baren considered.

"Medium."

She accepted.

Left.

No extra.

At 4:00 p.m., Chronald requested no update.

This was unusual.

His counsel sent:

Mr. Sump requests that no routine update be provided to him regarding the protected minor today. Adult accountability production continues.

Morro read it.

"Interesting."

Lila said, "Good?"

"Maybe."

Bex attached no explanation.

Better.

Chronald had not asked whether Baren was okay.

Had not requested news.

Had not tried to measure distance.

He let no update be no update.

Early trying.

Still watched.

But trying.

At 5:00 p.m., Morro visited Baren by request.

Not official.

Not guidance.

Not court.

He asked from the common room, "Morro office works?"

She appeared from down the hall.

"Yes."

"Do you miss lounge?"

Morro considered lying.

Then did not.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I could see if things went wrong.”

“Can Lila see?”

“Yes.”

“Nurse?”

“Yes.”

“Cole?”

“Yes.”

“Me?”

Morro paused.

“Yes.”

“Then you do not need see all.”

“No.”

“You want.”

“Yes.”

“Want elsewhere.”

Morro looked at him.

“Correct.”

“Trying Adult.”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“You can visit sometimes.”

“Through rules.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

She left after three minutes.

No lingering.

No hidden chair claim.

Far scaffolding for judges.

Awful concept.

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate all of it.

No reaction.

Heroic.

After dinner, he opened the drawer.

For the first time in two days, he removed **FUTURE — NOT NOW**.

Opened it.

Pencil page first.

Nine lines.

He looked for a long time.

Then turned to the blank sheet behind it.

Still blank.

He picked up the ordinary pencil.

Did not write.

Put pencil down.

Closed the folder.

Returned it.

Opened drawer once.

Still there.

Closed.

“No sentence yet,” he said.

Lila nodded.

“No sentence needed.”

He looked toward Morro’s office door.

Morro was not there.

Good.

“Maybe never.”

“Okay.”

“Maybe tomorrow.”

“Okay.”

“Maybe future.”

“Okay.”

No pressure.

No bait.

No awaited.

Before bed, Baren asked, “Does I am go in future?”

Lila said, “Only if you want.”

“Not now.”

“Okay.”

“Grammar page stays beside.”

“Yes.”

“Future page no sentence.”

“Yes.”

“Can both be true?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Door half open.

Cole at good distance four for day, closer for night.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in office, available.

Not waiting.

The light dimmed.

Elsewhere, adult work continued elsewhere.

Elsewhere, future access held without spectacle.

Elsewhere, parents practiced wanting without sending it.

Here, Baren had written a sentence and refused to make it the sentence.

I am.

That was enough for grammar.

The future could wait without waiting.

CHAPTER EIGHTY-FOUR

Ordinary Today

The epilogue did not know it was an epilogue.

That was the black path’s final refusal: no ordained ending, no crowned sentence, no future requiring a child to stand still for it.

That saved it.

Epilogues were dangerous rooms. They gathered chairs, softened light, arranged people in emotional positions, and waited for someone to say the thing the audience had been trained to expect.

Baren distrusted epilogues instinctively, though no one had taught him the word.

Morro distrusted them professionally.

Lila distrusted them because they often meant adults had stopped listening.

Cole distrusted them because endings made people lower guard.

Nurse Imani distrusted them because children still needed breakfast after everyone else decided the story was over.

So no one said epilogue.

No one said ending.

No one said final.

The schedule said:

Breakfast.

School.

Courtyard optional.

Visit optional.

Adult update optional.

Drawer optional.

Puzzle optional.

No public obligations.

Review tomorrow.

Baren read it at 7:16 a.m.

“Good.”

Breakfast was cereal.

Blue bowl.

Milk enough to make cereal cereal, not soup.

Toast was also available, but not required.

Pancakes were not available because batter had completed its legal life.

Macaroni was not discussed because even reliable disappointment deserved mornings off.

Cole sat at night distance still, because it was early and the day had not fully decided whether it needed good distance four.

Nurse Imani stood at the desk.

Lila sat with the schedule.

Morro was in her office, door open, coffee visible, body elsewhere enough to count.

The drawer remained closed.

The future folder slept inside.

The grammar pages slept beside it.

The Support Checks slept beneath.

The cow puzzle box sat on the shelf.

Available.

Not waiting.

Baren ate cereal.

Three bites.

Four.

Five.

Stopped.

No one counted out loud.

Good.

He looked toward Morro's office.

"She alive?"

Morro called, "Barely."

"Good."

Cole said, "Court functioning."

Baren nodded.

"Good."

No one laughed too much.

That was care.

The adult world had not stopped.

It had simply stopped arriving through his breakfast.

That morning, in rooms Baren did not enter, the Adult Systems Evidence Track opened hearings in three jurisdictions.

Civic Horizon Lab produced storage inventories.

The Bellwether Club submitted worker-access logs.

The campaign filed an amended absence inventory.

The church network produced sermon review policies.

The private school consortium circulated anonymized-case safeguards with the phrase **if the room knows, it is not anonymous** in a footnote that made Morro smile despite herself.

Elysium's lawyers continued fighting.

Dahlia's lawyers continued dressing defeat as preserved principle.

Victor Elysium's motion to dismiss remained pending.

The Old Court prosecutions moved into discovery.

Rosa's labor protections became model language in a worker-witness bill no one named after her because she had specifically not asked to become a statue with mop accessories.

Former-minor advisors were paid.

Some declined payment.

Then were asked again later in a non-annoying way because declining once under pressure did not always mean no forever.

Some spoke.

Some did not.

Some withdrew.

Withdrawal was honored without commentary.

The Record Access Pathway spread carefully, with warnings against copying it like a recipe.

The No Bait Index held.

The future-letter leak investigation produced subpoenas.

Children Deserve Truth Now changed its name twice, then appeared in discovery anyway because payment processors had less romance than ideology.

Mara reported.

Dryly.

Mostly.

Crowe advised religious institutions to stop confusing confession with access.

Dr. Rao chaired clinical standards that used the phrase **no child assigned repair function** so often it became boring.

Boring meant it might work.

Morro read summaries in her office.

She did not bring them into the lounge unless asked.

No one asked.

Good.

School began with reading.

Ms. Rowe brought three books again.

Ocean.

Dinosaurs.

Maps.

Baren chose dinosaurs.

Feathers again.

The furious chicken ancestor returned.

He read silently.

Seven minutes.

Then aloud.

One paragraph.

He stumbled on **paleontologist**, corrected himself, and said, "Long word trying too hard."

Ms. Rowe smiled.

"Corrected?"

"Yes."

He read the next sentence.

Dinosaurs had not all looked the way older books showed them.

New evidence changed the picture.

He paused.

“Still true.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“No guidance.”

He continued reading.

That was new.

He did not stop at the line.

He let it be true and kept going.

Lila noticed.

Did not mark it.

Morro was in her office and did not burst through the wall.

Progress everywhere.

After reading, Ms. Rowe offered writing.

Baren accepted.

The prompt:

Write one ordinary sentence.

He looked at it suspiciously.

“Ordinary can become trap.”

“Yes,” Ms. Rowe said.

“Can change?”

“Yes.”

He changed it to:

Write one sentence.

Then he wrote:

The dinosaur had feathers.

He looked at it.

“School.”

“School,” Ms. Rowe agreed.

School note:

Reading completed. One factual sentence written.

Baren approved.

No future.

No drawer.

No life.

A dinosaur had feathers.

That was enough.

At 10:30 a.m., Lila asked if Baren wanted the adult update.

He thought.

“Short.”

“Adult work continues elsewhere. No decisions needed from you today. The future-access order is holding. Support Checks are active. No one gets direct access without rules.”

“Any adult caught?”

“No new arrests.”

“Any wall moved?”

“Some institutional policies changed.”

“Other kids?”

“Protected. Former minors by choice.”

“Workers?”

“Protected better.”

“Rosa?”

“Good mop provisions are in the worker-witness policy.”

Baren smiled.

“Good.”

“Do you want more?”

“No.”

Adult update ended.

It did not sneak back in wearing concern.

Lila closed the folder.

Baren looked at her.

“You are good at stopping.”

“Learning.”

“Trying Adult.”

“Yes.”

At noon, lunch was grilled cheese.

Straight cut.

Cole had moved to good distance four for daytime.

His voice came from the hall corner.

“Rectangles remain available if needed.”

Baren considered.

“Accepted.”

Morro, from her office, called, "I object to remote geometry."

Baren called back, "Overruled."

The room stopped.

Morro appeared in the office doorway.

Lila looked at Baren.

Cole looked at the floor.

Nurse Imani turned away because her face was not under control.

Baren realized what he had said.

Then shrugged.

"Joke."

Morro looked at him for a long moment.

Then bowed her head.

"Accepted."

No one made it a symbol.

No one said he had reclaimed authority.

No one said legal confidence.

No one said future lawyer.

No one even said it was funny more than once.

Good.

It had been a joke.

A joke could survive if adults did not force it to carry furniture.

After lunch, Baren asked for the cow puzzle.

Lila brought the box.

He opened it.

Pieces.

No picture.

He sorted edges.

Slowly.

Not all.

He made one corner.

Then another.

Then left the rest.

"Available corner," he said.

No one asked.

Morro was in her office.

Good.

Cole at hall corner said nothing.

Baren pushed the box slightly away.

“Done for now.”

Lila nodded.

“Done for now.”

Not finished.

Not abandoned.

Not evidence.

Puzzle.

At 1:30 p.m., Mara visited.

Scheduled because Baren had asked the day before.

Twice-weekly limit honored.

No fact unless asked.

She arrived on time.

No notebook.

No article face.

Mostly.

Baren pointed.

“Small article face.”

“Occupational injury.”

“Accepted. No work.”

“No work.”

She sat across from him.

The puzzle corner sat on the table.

Mara did not touch it.

Good.

“Fact?” Baren asked.

“One?”

“One.”

“Some birds are living dinosaurs.”

Baren stared.

“No.”

“Yes.”

“Trust fact?”

“Yes.”

“Halfway.”

“Receipts later?”

“If asked.”

He looked offended.

“Birds are trying to win history.”

Mara smiled.

“They may already have.”

“Do not tell them.”

“I won’t.”

They sat.

After a while, Baren said, “Your visits are okay.”

Mara took that carefully.

“Thank you.”

“No proud.”

“No.”

“No waiting.”

“No.”

“Available.”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

The visit lasted eleven minutes.

Mara left at eleven minutes because that was enough and enough had become a trusted measurement.

She did not ask if she could come next week.

The rules already knew how.

At 2:30 p.m., Crowe did not visit.

He had sent no message.

This was its own visit.

Plain facts slept.

Prayer Adult did not appear.

Trying Adult worked elsewhere.

Good.

At 3:00, Serena requested a visit.

Baren said yes.

Five minutes.

Nothing in hand.

She entered.

No tears.

No gift.

No future.

No mothering as evidence.

Baren sat at the table with the puzzle corner.

Serena looked at it.

“Puzzle?”

“Corner.”

“Good corner.”

He studied her.

“Good simple.”

“Trying.”

“Therapy?”

“Yes.”

“Useful?”

“Yes.”

“Sad?”

“Yes.”

“Where sad goes?”

“Adults.”

“Good.”

He asked, “Are you available next week?”

“Through rules.”

“Not waiting?”

“Trying not to.”

“Good.”

Timer buzzed.

He said, “Done.”

She stood.

At the door, she said, “Ordinary today?”

Baren considered.

“Ordinary today.”

“Review tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

She left.

No extra.

Morro later heard the exchange and placed both hands on her desk.

“Private?” Lila asked.

“Entirely.”

Good.

At 4:00 p.m., Chronald sent no update.

Not even a no update.

That was better.

Bex sent an adult production receipt to counsel.

Not relayed.

Dahlia filed an objection to the written order preserving appellate rights.

Not relayed.

Elysium’s team filed a supplemental brief arguing tools do not create intent.

Not relayed.

Mara published a piece on the adult-system tracks.

Not relayed.

The world continued.

Baren did not have to hold it.

He went to the courtyard.

The sad maple had begun producing tiny new growth near one branch.

No one called it hope.

No one called it resilience.

No one called it spring.

Baren saw it.

Cole saw it.

Lila saw it.

No one said anything.

Then Baren said, “Tree is doing tree.”

Cole nodded.

“True yes.”

Dinner was macaroni.

Reliable disappointment.

Baren ate half.

“Back to normal,” he said.

Nurse Imani said, “Accepted.”

After dinner, he stood by the drawer.

Did not open it.

Then opened it.

One check.

Everything still there.

Future folder on top.

Support Checks beneath.

Grammar pages beside.

Orders.

Learning plan.

Dinosaur boots photo.

Leaf envelope.

Private notes.

Blank envelope.

He touched the future folder but did not remove it.

Closed the drawer.

Opened once.

Still there.

Closed.

“Not tonight,” he said.

Lila nodded.

“Okay.”

“Sentence?”

“No sentence needed.”

“Maybe never.”

“Okay.”

He looked at the side table.

Ocean card.

Shark drawing.

Ordinary pencil.

Parrotfish fact still under shark.

Octopus fact near table.

The pencil had done enough.

It could rest.

Night arrived without ceremony.

No final hearing.

No final statement.

No public correction.

No camera outside.

No empty chair.

No birthday package.

No future letter.

No fatherhood ad.

No prayer.

No chant.

No vote.

No music.

No restrained sorrow.

No unresolved hope.

Just a room.

Door half open.

Cole at night distance.

Nurse Imani at desk.

Lila nearby.

Morro in her office, door open, available.

Not waiting.

Baren in bed.

Socks gray.

Blanket ordinary.

The future folder closed.

The cow puzzle partly cornered.

The dinosaur book on the school table.

The schedule for tomorrow already printed, face down.

Before sleep, Baren asked, "Is tomorrow still there?"

Lila smiled.

"Yes."

"Does it need anything from me now?"

"No."

"Good."

He was quiet.

Then:

"Can ordinary be enough?"

"Yes."

"Can ordinary change?"

"Yes."

“Can review tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“Can adults keep doing adult work?”

“Yes.”

“Elsewhere?”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

Cole said from the hallway, “True yes.”

Morro called softly from her office, “Correct.”

Nurse Imani said, “Sleep.”

That ruling carried.

Baren closed his eyes.

The room did not become holy.

The silence did not become symbolic.

The half-open door did not become a campaign.

The absence did not do work.

The future did not wait.

It was available.

That was all.

And all, for once, did not ask to be everything.

END OF BOOK THREE